

Phil 215 Ideas of the 20th Century Part 1

Numbered Transcript

PHIL 215 • Dr. Daniel Bonevac

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Lecture 1: A Mighty Maze

At a glance — Bonevac opens 'a mighty maze' of 20th-century ideas.

- 1.1 Hello. This is a course on ideas of the 20th century. Now, what is such a course? It's an odd, interdisciplinary thing. Really, it's a throwback to an old style of humanities course of the kind that would have been part of Yale's Directed Studies program or civilization programs at a variety of universities. It fell out of fashion a number of years ago. But I think it's really unfortunate that it did. Because what I'm going to try to do is trace certain themes in philosophy, literature, history, and art, and see how they combine together to give us an understanding of the problems faced by an entire century.
- 1.2 Now, why should we care about that? Partly because the 20th century is how we got here. The problems that the 20th century faced are, I'm going to argue, problems stemming from the Enlightenment and the Scientific Revolution. They're fundamental problems; we really haven't resolved them yet. But looking at the ways in which they shaped the 20th century, and the ways in which people tried to solve them, I think helps us understand both the nature of the problems and also the range of possible solutions.
- 1.3 We're going to be looking at these various themes, and I'm going to be jumping back and forth between history, philosophy, literature, art, and occasionally other things, trying to understand the way in which these themes fit together.
- 1.4 Now, part of the idea here is that things that happen in the real world do affect the world of ideas, but also the world of ideas affects what really goes on in the world. And so these aren't entirely separate areas; they have to be understood together. And when you get into a university of a traditional kind, people are split into departments—the philosophers just do philosophy, the historians just do history and so on. And you don't get many people who are looking at the interactions and the ways in which ideas shape history or vice versa.
- 1.5 So that's what this course is all about, trying to understand what I've described here as a "Mighty Maze," the way in which all of these things fit together and suggest that there are certain problems that a civilization is trying to solve. I think there are some very basic problems that the 20th century was trying to address.
- 1.6 To understand them, we need to go back to the Scientific Revolution, and in particular, the aspects of it that ended up reshaping people's lives in the Agricultural and Industrial Revolutions. If you had been born before 1750, the odds were strong that your life was going to follow much the same pattern of your parents' and grandparents' lives, even your ancestors' from hundreds or thousands of years before. Almost everybody was involved in farming and struggling to survive, struggling to find enough food, to really put a meal on the table for that night and maybe that week.

- 1.7 But things changed in the Scientific Revolution. Partly, our understanding of nature became much more sophisticated, but partly that transformed technology that changed human relationships. Starting in the 18th century, in developed countries, at least, was the Agricultural Revolution, and it really changed the way that society was organized.
- 1.8 Then we have two Industrial Revolutions in the 19th century, and they reshape things in fundamental ways. Now, in part, they just set up the tremendous transformations of the 20th century in transportation, mass production, mass communication, and so on. We're all familiar with that. In fact, just in my lifetime, there have been huge transformations in technology. But the formative era of that was really in the centuries before.
- 1.9 Let's start the Agricultural Revolution. It was something that, in a certain sense, started even in the Medieval period and then got waylaid by the Black Plague and other things. But over several centuries, a number of innovations came about that made it much easier to grow more food. Crop rotation, in part, the curved wheelless plow, new crops such as potatoes and corn that enabled people to grow crops on land that had been unarable before. Property rights and enclosures that enabled people to actually have stable farming. Selective breeding so that they could actually shift the way that animals were bred to make them more useful for humans. And then the seed drill, which actually allowed people to plant seeds at the right distance from each other and at the right depth. All of that led to immensely increased crop yields. There were slow improvements throughout the Medieval and Renaissance periods, but then starting around 1750, huge advances.
- 1.10 Now, what did that mean? Well, there was more food available at lower prices. It took less labor, much less labor, actually, to produce that amount of food. So there were lots of people who found that suddenly they weren't needed on farms anymore. They tended to go to towns and go to cities, and that made them available for other kinds of activities. There was more money for other things, more money available for investment, for example, in factories and other things that would shape the Industrial Revolution. There were improvements in transportation. It was important now to actually be able to bring the food to the towns because it wasn't all being consumed in those rural communities. People had to build more roads and transportation thus became easier in general.
- 1.11 Well, what happened over the 19th century, as a result of this, is that 60% of the population went from the countryside to cities and towns. They weren't needed on the farms anymore. And so they gravitated to areas where there were other people. In 1800, four out of five people worked in farming. By 1900, it was only one out of five. Three out of five people ended up moving to the cities.
- 1.12 Now, that's part of the story. Part of this was a matter of conceptual advances. John Locke developed a theory of property that enabled people to say, "This is mine."

Rousseau denounced this and said, "The first person to rope off a plot of land and say, 'This is mine,' and find people fool enough to believe him was the true founder of civil society." Well, Locke thought that was a good thing, because what it meant is you could invest in your land. You could actually buy things like a seed drill and a new, fancy plow that was more effective. If you were farming somebody else's property, you didn't have much incentive, really, to improve things. But if it was yours and you were producing things that you could then sell, there were tremendous incentives to actually develop things and use this new technology.

- 1.13 The result of that has been a tremendous improvement in health, well-being, and prosperity, really all throughout the world, initially in Western Europe and the United States, but gradually spreading throughout the rest of the world.
- 1.14 Now, what happened when people moved into the cities is that they needed things to do, and suddenly there was capital available for investment. There were a series of inventions that transformed the way people lived. First of all, Edmund Cartwright invented the power loom. Instead of having to sew clothes by hand, suddenly they were being mass-produced. The price of clothing fell dramatically. Here you see the increase, over a few years, in power looms went from insignificant, really nonexistent in 1800, insignificant by 1813, but widespread in common use by 1850—putting weavers, and other people who did all this by hand, out of business to a large extent, but nevertheless making clothing available at much lower prices for many people.
- 1.15 James Watt invented the steam engine, which transformed transportation and a variety of other areas. In 1800, it was capable of producing 10,000 horsepower. I mean, initially, his machine was large, very large actually, and didn't do much. But by 1850, it was producing 1.3 million horsepower. So that was tremendous and a force that was inconceivable in earlier ways. That made possible steamships, which were far more effective than sailing ships.
- 1.16 And locomotives, the first one, again, primitive in 1804, it went 5 miles an hour. By 1830, 16 miles an hour. Now, that doesn't sound impressive to us, but when you were comparing it to walking or even a horse, that was pretty good. By 1850, 50 miles an hour. And not long after that, even higher speeds. The result of that was a huge popularity of railways for people to transport themselves and to transport goods. And so by 1850, there were already 6,000 miles of track in Great Britain alone.
- 1.17 Well, corresponding to all of that was an even greater movement to the cities. London grew from a million to almost two and a half million. There were no cities in Europe under a million, but over 100,000, in 1800; by 1850, there were nine of them, and many cities that were almost that size.
- 1.18 Think about what it was like to work in these factories that were popping up in all sorts of towns and cities. It was, in a way, terrible. Twelve to 16-hour days. Terrible conditions, noxious fumes, high temperatures. It was very dangerous. A couple of my

own great-grandfathers actually died as a result of industrial accidents. So it was hard working in those mills. And in addition, when such a flux of people went into the cities, the result of that was a humanitarian disaster in a way. The cities were overcrowded. There was no plumbing. There was sewage in the street, garbage everywhere. The result of that was widespread disease, cholera epidemic after cholera epidemic. So, conditions looked bad.

- 1.19 But on the other hand, some people were getting rich as a result of this, and lots of people were actually making money to a degree that had been impossible before, not just the rich, but a growing middle class. So it wasn't just because people had jobs in these factories that improved their income. It was easier than working on the—well, not easier, but more lucrative, let's say—than working on the farms.
- 1.20 But in addition, it made the goods that they were buying so much less expensive. Before that, just owning clothes was a difficult thing. You might have a couple of outfits, one that you would wear while the other was being washed. But after that, clothing was much less expensive, so was food, and so you could live much better on even the same income. The result of that was increased trade, increased travel, these increases in income and wealth that started leading to a public culture that became perfected by the end of the century.
- 1.21 Now, the Second Industrial Revolution, to a large extent, made those problems of the First Industrial Revolution seem much easier to deal with. How? Well, first of all, it left much larger groups of people with discretionary income. So it spread wealth around a much larger section of population. It increased productivity hugely, which meant the factory jobs were no longer quite so terrible; working hours and working conditions were better. People started thinking in terms of what they wanted, not just what they needed. Instead of thinking, "How am I going to get food? How am I going to get clothing?" People actually were able to start thinking, "What would I actually like? What would make my life better?"
- 1.22 How did this happen? Well, first of all, the Industrial Revolution had progressed to a point where now the clothing, the food, the other products were starting to become much more widely available. Prices were falling. There was also dramatic population growth. The population of Europe almost doubled. Now, why? It was not so much a matter of people moving in. It wasn't really an increased birth rate. It was a declining rate of death. There were huge advances in medicine, in particular, the germ theory of disease. We take that for granted, but it was a new idea, and also a huge driver of civilization, plumbing.
- 1.23 First of all, the germ theory. Ignaz Semmelweis was a physician who was convinced that there was some explanation for why, in this wing of the hospital, women were getting sick and dying after childbirth at a much higher rate than in this wing. After an intensive study, he realized it's because in this wing, doctors are going into the morgue studying

the dead, and then going right in to deliver babies without washing their hands. Astounding to us.

- 1.24 He insisted that doctors wash their hands. They thought he was crazy. I mean, imagine, "No, there are these little things, and you've got to get rid of these little things that you cannot see." They thought he was mad. They put him in an insane asylum, where he was beaten to death by the guards. They were convinced the guy was crazy, and he kept telling them to wash their hands and so on. But he was, of course, right about all of this.
- 1.25 Pasteur realized that he was right and actually came up with ways of pasteurizing milk and all sorts of other things to make them safer. So it wasn't just a matter of treating diseases and preventing diseases better. It was also changing the way we dealt with the food supply to make problems much less serious.
- 1.26 This led to all sorts of other advances. In 1750, only about a third of babies survived birth. By 1900, it was 85%. Now, it's almost 100%. The changes in population were huge. First of all, because there was such an influx into the cities and because factories were growing so much and things were prospering, there was massive immigration. People started moving not only from the countryside to the cities, but also from country to country to take advantage of increased opportunities.
- 1.27 London, by 1900, had grown to 6.5 million. Remember, it had started the century at just 1 million. That's tremendous growth. By now, there were lots of European cities over 100,000. The same thing was happening in the United States. Chicago, for example, was a town of fewer than 30,000. In 1850, by 1900, it was a city of 1.7 million. New York grew from about half a million to over 2 million. Maybe most astoundingly, Cleveland was a tiny town of 17,000. It had almost 400,000 people by the turn of the century. So tremendous growth in all of these cities, not only due to internal movement into the cities, but also due to immigration.
- 1.28 Part of the story here was the advent of the steel industry. It was minor in 1860. By 1913, 32 million tons were being produced in Western Europe alone. Then came electricity and the way in which it transformed our lives through lighting: Thomas Edison. But also in all sorts of other ways: Nikola Tesla invented alternating current and induction motors, wireless communication, remote controls. So, thank you, Tesla. Alexander Graham Bell invented the telephone. Edison invented the phonograph. Marconi invented the wireless telegraph. Marconi, the radio. All of these things taking place within a span of 20 or 25 years. So astounding advances in ways that were totally going to reshape civilization.
- 1.29 Similar things were happening in transportation. The first bicycle was in 1886. That's not that long ago. It wasn't long before Ford and others invented the internal combustion engine. That was the first Ford motor car in 1896. It doesn't look like much,

but within just seven years, the first flight in Kitty Hawk. So, an astounding progress that has reshaped the way in which human societies are organized in the 20th century.

- 1.30** It also changed economically the way these societies were structured. There were steady, large increases in income. The rise of the middle class. National incomes were up 2-3 times. Real wages for the average person doubled. Working hours, still long by our standards—5.5 days, usually 10-hour days—but still much better than they had been a few years before. There were lower prices. This was the era of national product brands, of shopping districts, of department stores, of large manufacturing plants. So a lot of things we take for granted now were really innovations right around 1900.
- 1.31** Another innovation was mass, free primary education. All of a sudden, people realize it's very important that we have an educated citizenry. Why? Well, partly because before that, religious organizations, churches, synagogues, et cetera, were largely responsible for education, and much of it took place in the home.
- 1.32** But there was a sense that people of different religious backgrounds needed to get together, so we needed a more secular version of education. People wanted skilled labor. It took skills to work in factories that weren't required on the farm. People wanted people to participate in politics, to be part of a republic, a democracy, and so we needed people to actually be informed. There was an idea that we had to shape people coming from all over the world into the United States in particular, but it was happening in Europe, too, and shape that into a country, give people a feeling of patriotism and a common culture. As a result of all that, literacy became almost universal throughout the Western world.
- 1.33** There was a huge need for teachers, and so this led to the rise of women's colleges to train teachers. It was also the era of mass circulation, magazines, newspapers, a rise of popular culture, and then music halls, vaudeville, team sports, things where you had enough people now in cities to enable these cultural activities. All of that—the Agricultural Revolution, and then the two Industrial Revolutions—really changed the nature of not only the way the average person lived, but the whole structure of society.
- 1.34** Now, why do I stress all this? Because it really gave a set of problems and a huge set of advantages to the 20th century. But it meant that suddenly in the 20th century, the way you were living was really different from the way your grandparents lived. That was a new thing in civilization. Maybe if we go back to the Roman Empire, we would find something like this, but not nearly to this extent. All of a sudden, the life that most of us lead now would have been inconceivable to our great-grandparents. How did that happen? What kinds of problems did it face us with?
- 1.35** You might think, "Look, it's a huge advantage. I would not want to go back to living in 1700. Even if I were very wealthy, I would want things like indoor plumbing, and antibiotics, and other things." There is a huge advantage to this. I don't mean to downplay that. But on the other hand, there are reasons why people predicted that the

20th century would be a century of great wars, and it was. A hundred million people died in world wars. Another hundred million died at the hands of their governments.

- 1.36** So at the time, you might have thought, we finally achieved this wonderful state of near universal prosperity, and we have a recipe for spreading it to the rest of the world. All of a sudden, all sorts of problems arose. Why? Let's take a look in the realm of ideas at the 19th century's legacies.
- 1.37** The first has to do with the role of reason and a controversy about it. Plato had the idea that the soul was something like the driver of a chariot in the driver's seat, and the chariot was reason. But there were two horses that had to be controlled. One of them was emotion and the other was desire. Emotion usually played along with reason, how you feel about something and how you think about it are closely related. But desire was something that was hard to control.
- 1.38** In the images you see, in Plato and artworks that depict this, it's the horse of desire that is rebelling and that reason is struggling to maintain control of. The idea here is that reason gives us a way to actually live in the proper fashion. It allows us to understand the world, and we need to get desire and emotion under control. So rationality becomes the key thing. Indeed, through the Scientific Revolution and then these technological advances, it looked as a huge confirmation for this idea that reason is the right way to live. It is the path to progress.
- 1.39** Take a look, for example, at the stories of Sir Arthur Conan Doyle, who writes about Sherlock Holmes; that's his most famous character. Right at the beginning of an early story, *A Scandal in Bohemia*, Watson is describing Holmes and introducing him to us for the first time. He says, "All emotions, and that one, particularly, in this case, love, were abhorrent to his cold, precise, but admirably balanced mind. He was, I take it, the most perfect reasoning and observing machine the world has seen."
- 1.40** Notice, emotion, utterly foreign to Holmes. His mind is absolutely balanced, a perfect reasoning machine. It reflects that Platonic ideal. It's all about reason and reason controlling desire, controlling emotion. "For the trained reasoner to admit such intrusions as desire or emotion into his delicate and finely adjusted temperament was to introduce a distracting factor which might throw a doubt on all his mental results." To make progress, we really need to keep reason in control, keep everything else suppressed and utterly reined in.
- 1.41** Now, there is an issue that emerges in the 19th century. It becomes a key issue throughout the 20th century. Initially, it's very surprising, but I think I can understand why it arises and also why it poses such a problem. You would think that given the emphasis on reason, given these technological advances, scientific advances, a tremendously better understanding of the world, we would say, "Okay. Here's what's going on. The world is the way it is. It's independent of our minds. We can't just make this up. Science is hard work."

- 1.42 But eventually, we figure out what's really going on in the world. We do it by the use of reason. At that point, we've discovered some of these mind-independent truths, these things that are really true about the world, no matter what people happen to think about them. That seems to utterly contradict the thought that things are mind-dependent. The idealist, in philosophical terms, says that everything is mind-dependent. There are no mind-independent facts.
- 1.43 Initially, that's a really surprising claim. Why would somebody think that? I mean, it's obvious that some things are mind dependent. If I say, "Hey, I'm thinking about such and such," that's a fact that depends on what's going on in my mind. So, sure, lots of things are dependent on minds when we talk about psychology or our ordinary experiences. But everything? Surely science is giving us a picture of a mind-independent world, and that's what the realist says.
- 1.44 Here's why this becomes such a critical issue. First of all, if I apply this to my own life, I've got a question, and a question that was made much more acute by the Scientific Revolution, because it looks as if the picture of the world that we get through science is a pretty complete picture of the world. If you think that, you might think, "I don't know where there's any room left for, for example, God." And so the French Encyclopedists, especially, were tempted to say that science has shown us we don't need God. We have no need for that hypothesis. We can just understand the world in its own terms, period.
- 1.45 Well, if we think that, you might think, "What does that make me, and what do I do then in living my own life? Am I to guide my own life without anything external to me that guides me? Or is there really something external to me that I have to live up to?" So it matters whether I think that I am the source of all value, of right and wrong and good and evil and just and unjust, or whether I think there's something outside of me that determines all that, and I have to live up to that.
- 1.46 So at one level, we're thinking about the world and the way we perceive it and whether that's really independent of our minds in a way that would be described by science. But part of it is, what is science leaving out? If all we have is science, then what becomes of me and what becomes of God, what becomes of goodness and justice and things like that? Am I free to assign my life any meaning I want? Maybe I can say, "Hey, this is the way I live. This is just my thing, and I'm answerable only to myself." Or maybe I'm answerable to something else, something higher.
- 1.47 This is true in politics as well. It's not just a personal question. Whatever is true of me is also true for us here. Are we able to assign meaning and value however we like, or are we, as a society, answerable to something higher? Richard Fernandez has put it this way—arguing for realism, by the way—"The key idea behind civilization and indeed all progress, is that there is something out there that represents the truth. It exists independently of us. We cannot simply make it up." Once that is grasped, all else is detail.

- 1.48 "The most critical part of political theory lies in acknowledging that human institutions are not the ultimate sources of authority. They live within the world of the unread book." That becomes a key question throughout the 20th century: Are we the ultimate sources of authority, or do we live in the world of the unread book? Is there something outside of us to which we have to answer? That is really fundamental, and we're going to see people on both sides, but it becomes one of the things that drives the world wars that end up dominating so much of 20th-century history.
- 1.49 In Doyle's story—to return to Sherlock Holmes for a moment—there's a key thing that happens, and photography plays a critical role. I think it's worth reflecting on that because Doyle thinks that this is hugely important. The king comes and talks to Sherlock Holmes and says, "Listen, I had this love affair long in my past, somewhat scandalous, and now it may mess up my plan to marry this other person for great political advantage if this comes out. There are letters, and it could be bad for me. Maybe I could be blackmailed."
- 1.50 Sherlock Holmes is puzzled. He says, "I fail to follow your Majesty. If this young person should produce her letters for blackmailing or other purposes, how is she to prove their authenticity?" He says, "There is the writing." "Pooh, pooh! Forgery." "My private notepaper." "Stolen." "My own seal." "Imitated." "My photograph." "Bought." "We were both in the photograph." "Oh, dear," says Holmes. "That's very bad. Your Majesty has indeed committed an indiscretion."
- 1.51 Why? Why is the photograph so damaging? What's special about photography? Well, think about, in general, what it means. Suppose somebody had written a story, a book even, about this affair of the king with someone else years ago. Well, fiction, right? That doesn't prove a thing. What if someone paints a painting showing this scandalous affair? Again, just imagination. There's something special about a camera that makes photography different. There's a reason why we put cameras at finish lines to determine who really won the race rather than, let's say, writers or painters. That would not work at all. It wouldn't be evidence, but a photograph is evidence.
- 1.52 That's not to say photographs always depict the world exactly the way it is. Here is an image of Doyle that's double exposed, so he didn't really have that weird halo around his head. So photographs can go wrong. But still, there is a causal process operating here, and the normal outcome of it is to represent things accurately. That's why we use cameras to actually show you who won the race. Or we take a photograph—or at least did before Photoshop and all sorts of other AI tools—that indicated this really happened. We've got a photograph of it.
- 1.53 The realist thinks perception is the same way. When it functions normally, it shows you the world the way it is. It produces an accurate representation. Does it sometimes go wrong? Sure. But there's a similar causal process, and when things operate normally, it works.

- 1.54** I think stemming from the Enlightenment, a dominant attitude throughout the 19th century and surviving into the 20th, are four theses that I think of as the basic theses of the Enlightenment, and that depict a realist view of the world. The first is a thesis about truth. There are truths that are absolute, independent of mind, and universal. A good example: the truths of mathematics. Another: basic truths of science, forces, mass times, acceleration, and other scientific laws that look like they are truths, they describe the way the world is, they are independent of any individual mind; they apply universally.
- 1.55** Secondly, it's possible to have objective knowledge of at least some of them. We do have mathematical knowledge, we do have scientific knowledge, and we have common sense knowledge, like saying, "I have a hand." That's objectively true. We can know some things. Objectively, those things are independent of the mind. How do we do it? Reason is the best way.
- 1.56** Sometimes we can intuit things, sometimes we might just feel things, but ordinarily, it's reason that is the reliable path to achieving knowledge of this kind, knowledge that's objective about the world as it is.
- 1.57** Then, finally, it's acting rationally in response to that objective knowledge that gives us the best chance of progress, the best chance of achieving our aims, the best chance of improving our well-being and obtaining our own goals.
- 1.58** Those four theses—there are real truths out there about the world that are independent of the mind, that apply universally. We can know at least some of them. We do it by using reason. And if we act rationally in response to that, we can improve the world. That seems to me a basic idea from the Enlightenment that shapes these technological advances throughout the 19th century.
- 1.59** But now it does leave us with some problems. Here I want to focus not only on why you might think idealism then has any chance. Why did it become popular in the 19th and 20th centuries, but also another, more serious problem—I want to talk about a conflict of images that my own teacher, Wilfrid Sellars, stressed. Sellars was an American philosopher and the son of a famous American philosopher who was concerned with the nature of philosophy and the problem it faced, at least by the 20th century. He describes it this way. "The aim of philosophy, abstractly formulated, is to understand how things in the broadest possible sense of the term hang together in the broadest possible sense of the term."
- 1.60** That sounds very vague, but what he really means is that individual sciences study particular things. Sociologists study society. Historians study history, usually of a specific period that they specialize in. A biologist studies life and so on. The philosopher's job is not to study each of those individual areas, but to construct something like a large-scale map of the world, understanding how they relate to one another. That's a different project. How does what the biologist says about human

beings, for example, relate to what the psychologist says? How does that relate to what the sociologist says and the anthropologist says? And what picture, for example, of a human being emerges from all of that? That's philosophy's job.

- 1.61** But he says in doing this, there's a real problem that we face because it isn't just a matter of figuring out where all of these individual maps go and how to fit them together into a large terrain map, as if we all had this the assignment to go out and map a certain area, and now I have to take these puzzle pieces and put them all together. He says, here's the real difficulty: "The philosopher is confronted not by one complex, many-dimensional picture, the unity of which, such as it is, he must come to appreciate, but by two pictures of essentially the same order of complexity, each of which purports to be a complete picture of man in the world, and which, after separate scrutiny, he must fuse into one vision. Let's refer to these two perspectives, respectively, as the manifest and the scientific images of man in the world."
- 1.62** So one of these is the image I have of myself ordinarily, the image I have of myself in experience, and that seems to be the way the world is. When I say perception ordinarily reveals to me the world the way it is, I have in mind the world as I tend to perceive it, the world of ordinary objects. Yet science gives me a very different picture. So I am confronted with these two images.
- 1.63** Sellars is describing here what I'm going to call throughout this course as a two-level theory. There are a lot of these of various kinds. But the idea is that there is some realm of appearances. This is the way things are presented to us. Then there is some hidden realm that explains why things appear, are the way they are. In his concern, that base level, that's the scientific image of the world. That's the image of the world revealed to us by physics, by chemistry, by biology. But then, we get the manifest image of the world. That's the world of our ordinary experience. The idea is that what's happening at that overt macro level depends on what's going on at the micro level.
- 1.64** So, both say, I give you a complete depiction of the world, but they're in two totally different languages. One is the language of physics and of mathematics. The other is a language that seems to take ordinary objects, human beings, and so on as basic. There are many different ways of constructing this. We're going to look at different ways of putting in a scientific image. We'll look at Marxists or Freudians or a variety of others who say, "I've got an idea of what the basic driver of human behavior is." But it can also just be the picture we inherit from the Scientific Revolution. It's the atomic theory.
- 1.65** All of these have something in common. There is a surface level to be explained, and then there is a hidden depth level, a deep level that explains what's going on at the surface level. That idea is one that, I think, arises. It's already there in the ancient world with ancient atomism, except nobody had any idea how these realms related. Democritus and others could say that the world consists of atoms. You might say, "Maybe. I sure don't see them." There were no instruments that would reveal them,

and nothing really was predicted as a result of this. So, it was easy for most people to say, "Whatever, guy," and move on.

- 1.66** However, once we have a sophisticated atomic theory, and actually, surprisingly, right around 1750, we get something like a modern theory of chemistry that says that these substances actually are made up of the following elements in these combinations, and we can start thinking about atomic structure and explaining what happens at the surface level on the basis of this. All of a sudden, the atomic theory goes from a fruity sideline to the main thing, and our main way of understanding the world.
- 1.67** Why does that advance in the atomic theory that takes place over the 17th and 18th, and to some extent, 19th centuries, transform things so fundamentally? Partly because it does divide the images, because we say, "Now I have a totally different picture of the world." Partly because I also start thinking, "Wait a minute, I don't know how to fit this in with my ordinary perceptions of the world." I am ordinarily thinking about things like, let's say, hands, and clickers, and lecterns, and a variety of other ordinary objects in the world. But now you're telling me those are made up of these microparticles. They're made up of these atoms, and then the atoms are in turn made up of some atomic particles.
- 1.68** I start realizing, "Wait, you're telling me that all sorts of aspects of the world that I've been taking for granted, I shouldn't be taking for granted at all." In fact, reality isn't very much like this. I think, aha, this is solid and transparent to a large extent. It looks like I can get to the glass of water that way; I can't. But it's something that appears to have a certain structure to me. Yet, you're telling me, really, what's happening here is that there's a certain atomic structure, and as a result of that structure, it appears to have these characteristics. But in fact, for example, it isn't really solid. It's mostly empty space. It just consists of microparticles that are vibrating rapidly and held together with certain forces.
- 1.69** All of a sudden, I start thinking that what you're telling me, the world as I perceive it, isn't very much like the way the world really is at all. Once I start following that thought, then that idealist picture starts seeming much more attractive because I start thinking, "Wait a minute. You're telling me that the world as I perceive it is actually really misleading. That's not the way the world is." But then I start thinking that I construct my scientific theories on the basis of that. I could think science is real, and all this that I actually perceive is, to some extent, an illusion generated by my perceptual and cognitive faculties.
- 1.70** Except then I start thinking, "But I built science on top of that. If you're telling me all this is a fiction created by my mind, and then I built science on top of a fiction, shouldn't I think science is a fiction, too? Why am I taking it so seriously?" And so, suddenly, that idealist position that everything is mind-dependent no longer seems crazy. When you first hear it, it sounds like, "Give me a break. This isn't a construction

of my mind. It's really here." But then, once you follow this path of thinking about the atomic theory, you think, "Okay, you're telling me it's not really what it seems.

- 1.71** But then my understanding of how it seems to depend on my understanding of how it seems in a more sophisticated context, of course, as we do experiments. I begin thinking, "Okay, I don't really understand what's real anymore at all." That can make me think, "Okay, maybe everything does depend on the mind." All of a sudden, first of all, that issue between realists and idealists becomes forefront. It's like, "Wait a minute, maybe I can really take certain things in the world as independent of the mind, but maybe I can't."
- 1.72** All the things I would have thought of as basic, like that there is a lectern here, or I'm standing on a floor, or I have a hand, suddenly start seeming suspect. "Is there really a hand? Maybe they're just a bunch of microparticles connected together through nerve endings and other things with the rest of the body." All of a sudden, I start thinking that all the things I ordinarily think that make up the world aren't real, but are instead fictions of my mind.
- 1.73** But now I apply that to myself. I think, "Let's not talk about a lectern or even my hand, but me." What arises then is a really acute puzzle about what I could be. How do I make sense of myself as an agent who thinks, who decides, who intends, who acts? I think I do those things. I think I perceive things in a certain way, and I act in a certain way. I form these internal thoughts. I have the emotions. "Wait a minute. If I'm just this cloud of microparticles vibrating in certain ways, what do you mean me?" Descartes says, "I think I am." After the atomic theory, I start thinking, "Who's this I?" I'm not sure. Maybe it's just this cloud of microparticles doing all this. I don't know how to make sense anymore of myself as an agent.
- 1.74** In that way, a two-level theory like this really challenges our concept of what it is to be a human being. It implies that we aren't aware of the ultimate explanations of our behavior. I think I am here talking about this because I love talking about ideas, and I want to teach this class. But the atomic theorist might say, "Well, really? I can explain your being here by scientific principles that govern air travel and ground transportation.
- 1.75** So really, why you're here, your brain has a certain structure and there are certain neural firings and they led to this and that and so on and so forth. The same was true of a lot of other people. All of a sudden, you just get these microparticles interacting. Where are the intentions? Where are the desires? Where are the emotions? Where are the thoughts? They seem gone. In the end, it suggests you don't really know why you're here. It's ultimately an explanation to be given in terms of neuroscience and ultimately physics. That's explaining. It's all governed by scientific law, by these operations at a micro level that have nothing to do with what you call intentions or thoughts or feelings or perceptions or any of that.

- 1.76** How do we fit these visions of ourselves together? One way of looking at it that Sellars is fond of is to talk about a stereoscopic vision. We take these two images, and we have to put them together as in a stereoscope. When you do that—as a child, I had one of those little things, and it's nice—they go together, and they give you this three-dimensional image. We'd really like to do that with our scientific image of the world and our common sense manifest image of the world, especially when we turn this toward ourselves. We'd love to be able to get that wonderful three-dimensional picture, but it's not so easy.
- 1.77** Let's think about those images a little bit more. "The 'manifest' image of man-in-the-world can be characterized in two ways. They're supplementary rather than alternative. First, it's the framework in terms of which man came to be aware of himself as man in the world. It's the framework in which to use an existentialist turn of phrase, man first encountered himself, which is when he came to be man."—in other words, the world as we reflect on it and on ourselves.
- 1.78** I think about myself. I become aware of myself. I become aware of myself as a being who thinks and is and feels and acts. That's one way of thinking about this. Another is to just think about it from a more external point of view: it's the world I ordinarily perceive around myself. It's the world of lecterns and hands and animals, plants, merely material things, rivers, stones, cats, all sorts of things are the objects that I ordinarily take the world to be part of.
- 1.79** Indeed, if I'm not really thinking about science, that's the way I see the world ordinarily. I just think in terms of those macro-level objects. I don't think about their micro-physical composition or any of that, but the scientific image arises out of this. At first, and for centuries, science really consisted of just these observations and cataloging the observations. Even in astronomy, people proposed theories to explain planetary motion or other things; nevertheless, they were just pointing to things as they were being observed and trying to systematize those.
- 1.80** But the atomic theory did something different. You start with the manifest image, you start measuring, you start tabulating, trying to find ways of organizing the mass of data you're creating through measurement and observation. But then you introduce these theoretical entities: the atoms, the microparticles, genes, or fields, strings, and other things that are unobservable. All of a sudden, you start thinking, they are the things that are really causally active. They're responsible for the world as I perceive it. That's really what explains what's going on at this macro level. You realize, "I'm no longer just organizing the world as I perceive it; I'm doing something different. I'm postulating this different image, this different level of explanation that accounts for it.
- 1.81** In any theory like this, I've got the ordinary observed objects or myself as I observe myself, if I'm thinking about me. Then, I've got these hidden postulated theoretical entities. Now, in the atomic theory, they are the microparticles or other things introduced by science to explain the behavior of objects at the observational level. But

it might be something different. In a Marxist theory, for example, of society, it might be economic forces. In Freud's theory, it might be subconscious drives. In another theory, it might be a different motivation. So, I might say that it is not as Marx thought a class struggle, but it's really a racial struggle or some other thing. Whatever I do there, I'm saying, "There are these hidden forces, these hidden things that explain what's going on at this level."

- 1.82** Throughout the 20th century, people proposed different things to explain things at different levels, often trying to explain social or political phenomena in terms of these other forces. They usually don't say, "Oh, it's all going to be explained by physics," partly because nothing really follows from that. But on the other hand, a lot follows if you think it's all about class struggle or all about subconscious drives. Those things are going to make a difference in a way that maybe this doesn't for how we actually live our lives.
- 1.83** But that contrast between the manifest image at the macro level and the scientific image at the micro level, however we interpret it, but especially in that form that it takes as a result of the atomic theory in chemistry and physics, forces us to think, "Who am I?" And makes us no longer convinced we can really understand it.
- 1.84** There is, I think, a sharp clash here. It isn't just like this stereoscopic picture because there seems to be a contradiction. It's not only that each image says, "I'm the real image of the world." There is that because each one says, "I'm giving you a complete picture of the world." But there is a problem when we turn it to ourselves because the manifest image says, "I am a being who thinks. I make decisions. I form intentions." I act. I decide. I am free. I have free will to decide how I want, and I am under certain kinds of obligations. Some of them are moral obligations: certain things are right, certain things are wrong. Some of them are just practical obligations: if you want to do this, this is what you should do. They are, you might say, considerations of rationality. But those things all seem real. They seem significant at the manifest level.
- 1.85** On the other hand, at the scientific level, in the scientific image, things are just governed by these laws, generally causal laws. It seems value-free, and it seems like things are either determined or, if you have a certain interpretation of quantum mechanics, then it's determination plus a level of randomness. But it doesn't really change things. Whether my mind is determined or whether it's mostly determined, and there are a few dice rolls, doesn't really seem to put me into the picture in any significant way.
- 1.86** So, am I really free? The manifest image says, "Sure, you can make a decision about where to eat dinner tonight." The scientific image says, "Not really. It's all determined already by physical law." What about moral obligations? Would it be wrong to do such-and-such? The manifest image says, "That's a serious question. You'd better think about that." The scientific image says, "Wrong? What do you mean?" It'd be as if in a physics class, you're learning about the electron, and you find out it has a negative charge, and

somebody says, "Is that okay? I don't like the fact that these particles are negative. It seems bad."

- 1.87** The physicist doesn't have any place for what's good or bad. It's just the way it is. At the level of physics, all these value questions seem to just disappear. So, am I bound by moral constraints? Am I bound by constraints of rationality? Am I free to make decisions at all? The manifest image says yes, and the scientific image says no. That seems like a real contradiction.
- 1.88** One way of putting it is this. The manifest image is the surface picture that we have of ourselves. We think of ourselves as free. We act for reasons. We choose things. We make decisions, and we act rightly or wrongly, virtuously or viciously, rationally or irrationally. We take responsibility, or at least we think we ought to take responsibility. We have responsibility for our actions.
- 1.89** But in the scientific image, none of that seems to be true. We're determined by something we're not even conscious of, the neurophysiology driving whatever's happening in our brains. Our reasons are mere rationalizations, things our conscious mind tells ourselves to make us feel okay about being pushed around by our neurophysiology. Morality is either nonsense or reduces to something else.
- 1.90** In the next lecture, I'll talk a lot about what happens to morality here and what we could do if we really have this picture of the world. Also, since we're not free, we don't really have any responsibility for anything. If all that's true, well, then how do we evaluate these conflicting claims of the manifest image and the scientific image to constitute the true and, in principle, a complete account of man in the world? It's not just, "Hey, here are two different pictures. How do we fit them together?" It's really, they seem to give us conflicting pictures.
- 1.91** One tells us that we are rational agents who make decisions and are under obligations of various kinds. The other says that we're just machines, really sophisticated machines. So, we get these images that are very hard to reconcile, not just because they're different, but because they seem really to contradict one another. If we think hard about where they're contradicting each other, it's not just, "Oh, my hand seems relatively solid to me, and yet it's really not very solid, according to physical theory." It's not that thing. It's really thinking about why we act, the idea of acting for reasons, being under obligations.
- 1.92** Sellars puts it this way: "The irreducibility of the personal is the irreducibility of the 'ought' to the 'is'. In other words, it's what philosophers refer to as normativity, which is a fancy word for just saying, "How do we fit moral values into that scientific picture of the world?" It seems like fitting me, as I ordinarily understand myself, into that scientific image of the world is a matter of fitting these norms—the ought, a question of right and wrong, good and bad, just and unjust—into that picture of the world—for that matter, rational and irrational— into that image of the world. How do we do that?

- 1.93** It seems as if there is an irreducibility there. There is a gap. That is where this clash lies. It's at least one place where it lies. It seems to be, in Sellar's view anyway, the central place. So the ought is very real. He says in the manifest image, I am operating in the space of reasons. But in a scientific image, there are no reasons. This is just the realm of law. Things happen because of laws, the way they happen. To ask whether that's good or bad, right or wrong, just or unjust, that's like saying, "Wow, on an uninhabited planet, there was a volcanic eruption. Good or bad? It just happened." There's no such thing. The ought, the reasons, the good, the bad, right, wrong, all of that seems missing from the scientific image.
- 1.94** How do the images—how do the manifest image and the scientific image relate on that question? How do we combine the realm of law with the space of reasons? That, as we'll see next time, is David Hume's question from the Enlightenment. It remains a critical question. It's something that I think is fundamental and arises naturally from that Enlightenment picture of the world, the world as understood after the scientific revolution, and it's an unavoidable clash.
- 1.95** That is the problem: the scientific image describes the realm of law; the manifest image has us operating in the space of reasons. Maybe those are two different realms, or maybe they have the same realm, but are seen in two different ways. The problem is how we fit them together, and it remains completely unclear how we ought to do that. Thank you.
- 1.96** With the germ theory, how innovation at first is seen as curing or crazy when there is no knowing of what it is, as in we don't know what we don't know, therefore, how can we act? Then, when people are bringing this new concept, obviously, it's fear because you don't know what it is. How do we breach that because we're still seeing it nowadays?
- 1.97** That's a really hard question because you're right, often people who innovate in science — and I think it's especially true in medicine because people's lives are in the balance. In physics, if somebody comes up with a new idea and challenges a traditional theory, okay, people will fight about it. Academic politics sometimes gets quite vicious. I think it was Henry Kissinger who said, "Academic politics is so vicious because there's so little at stake." But sometimes there really is a lot at stake in terms of a scientific theory. Still, it's in medicine and psychology that people really get upset because it does affect people in very direct ways.
- 1.98** Here, you can understand maybe why people were so bothered by Semmelweis's idea. Partly, because it seemed to them obsessive. To be fair, it wasn't just that you're telling me as a doctor, I should be washing my hands all the time. I don't want to do that. What a waste of time, and so on, because of these little things I can't see. It all sounded crazy.

- 1.99** But there was also a serious problem: we didn't have any decent ways of sanitizing things back in those days. It wasn't like, "Oh, use some hand sanitizer or just wash carefully with it." He had them wash in lime. Their hands came out burning and chapped from this. So the doctors were in pain. They were like, "You're not only telling me I have to do this all the time, but it really hurts. My hands are cracking and bleeding. This is not good." And so there was some of that motivation, too. But mostly, I think it struck them as bizarrely obsessive-compulsive. In that case, it was especially bad.
- 1.100** But you're right, there was a huge resistance because throughout the history of medicine, people had thought in terms of internal humors in the body. And what Semmelweis was suggesting was not just, "Hey, wash your hands." It was also, "You're looking in completely the wrong place for an explanation for disease and for ways of curing it." That they took as a fundamental challenge.
- 1.101** It's not just when human lives are at stake, it's when whole careers are at stake. You're telling me basically that all of my medical training was garbage and that I've been devoting my life to methods that are useless and may be counterproductive. That's a hard thing to swallow. If I come up to somebody who has been at this for decades and thinks of themselves as an expert, and I say, "You don't know anything, and your entire life has been a complete waste up to now." I think that's the way they felt.
- 1.102** In addition to that, the explanation for the difference in survival rates among the women who had given birth implies, "Look, you guys were doing it. It wasn't just unfortunate. You guys were killing them by going in after being in the morgue and delivering the babies without washing your hands." It wasn't just, "Hey, your whole career is worthless," but "You're actually killing people. Stop it." That implication, you're really at fault here, I think, made them especially resistant.
- 1.103** You're right. I mean, in most cases, luckily in science, those innovations have not been met with that vicious a reaction, and partly because those factors were missing, but partly also because at a certain point, scientists started realizing it's very important to experiment and observe things like this and try to find an explanation for these differentials. But it was really only in the 19th century with John Stuart Mill's work.
- 1.104** So right around the middle of the 19th century, in other words, simultaneous with some of us, that Mill actually gave canons of induction to say, Here's how you do scientific reasoning. Before that, I think there was—some people had a sense of it, but there was no real theory of experimentation or learning from experience that would enable people to say, "There's a difference here; we need an explanation for the difference," and to be open-minded about what it might be.
- 1.105** The way that I see this is, I work in learning and development, so I'm seeing this in the leadership. So when we're training leaders, this is when I say meeting innovation with wisdom. What is a good approach in training leaders, bringing this knowledge into, "Hey, you're leading a business. Let's move towards growth and learning with the

knowledge that we have and experiences in the history. Look at all of the images that we have." I'm curious to know your point of view.

- 1.106** Okay, good. Leadership is something that does require a degree of open-mindedness, and in particular, open-mindedness, not just to other ideas, but to new evidence. I find that a lot of people, a disturbing number of people—I would not have believed it, actually, that adults could be like this, but they are—they get committed to a certain view of the world, and you cannot push them out of it.
- 1.107** To be open enough to say, "All right, that's not working out very well. I've got to take that seriously and think about where things are going wrong and how I have to adjust." I think a good leader does that. A bad leader just sticks with the idea and keeps doubling down. I see a lot of that happening around me in academics, but also in business, in government. People will not admit, "Maybe I was wrong, maybe I have to adjust my idea." It's quite remarkable in a way when a leader actually learns from experience.
- 1.108** We're going to look at some thinkers throughout the 20th century who stick to their guns no matter what, but we're going to see others that keep changing their minds. Albert Camus is going to be a good example of somebody who starts out as a communist, but then sees what Lenin and Stalin do in Russia and says, "That's not for me." He becomes an anarchist and a pacifist, and then the Germans invade France, and he says, "Well, I guess non-resistance to real aggression is not a good idea either." He keeps changing his mind. It might look like flightiness, but I think he's learning from experience. He's saying, "Here's an idea I think makes sense." Then he looks at the real world, says, "I don't think it makes sense." So he changes his mind, and that's a rare quality, it turns out.

Lecture 2: The Abdication of Belief

At a glance — The abdication of belief.

- 2.1 I've entitled this lecture, The Abdication of Belief, stealing a line from Emily Dickinson, partly because I think what happened as a result of the kinds of tensions I was describing last time, between the manifest and scientific image, between the dominance of the atomic theory and the huge progress that it made possible, but also our ordinary conceptions of the world and of ourselves, left the 20th century with a crucial problem to resolve, which is: How do we fit these together?
- 2.2 It led people to start giving up traditional beliefs. Some of this you might describe entirely historically and entirely sociologically. People who had spent generations in rural communities were suddenly finding themselves in cities and towns where they didn't know anyone, they were not familiar with local customs. And so, the traditional ways of living that had worked on the farms no longer necessarily worked in large cities or even towns of any size.
- 2.3 And so, there was already a removal from the traditions that they were familiar with, a removal from their communities, a removal from the patterns of life that had dominated people's lives for generations, that suddenly made people think, "I need to rethink values. I need to rethink the way I'm living." And to some extent, it is true that living in a city is very different from living on a farm in a rural community. So there are differences that are required, but it led people to take seriously the possibility that the way they had been living and that the traditions they had been abiding by really weren't worth very much.
- 2.4 Now, coupled with that, with the idea that we discussed last time, this problem of norms, of normativity, where we say, "I don't know how to make sense of myself as an agent who thinks and decides and acts, and is operating under various moral and practical constraints," with this picture of myself as ultimately driven by my own neurophysiology, by subatomic particles and their motions and the laws that govern them. This is a problem that was identified in the Enlightenment by David Hume, one of the great minds of the Scottish Enlightenment, and in fact, a close friend of Adam Smith.
- 2.5 He described this gap between the "is" and the "ought," between the world as it seems to be, and then the world as it ought to be, the world of our own behavior as it is, and then the world that is a matter of how we ought to behave. Where does that gap come from, and how do we understand it?
- 2.6 Here's how he thinks about it. I'll use an image from the South Park episode about Underpant Gnomes. They have this great idea. How do you make profits? You steal people's underpants. So, phase one, "We steal underpants. We collect a bunch of

underpants." Phase two, well, we'll come back to that one. Phase three, "Profit. We make lots of money."

- 2.7** And so, the South Park characters keep saying, "What's phase two?" And they admit, "I don't know." "What's phase two?" "Phase one is collect underpants. Phase three is profit." And so, it's something like that. Hume says, "All right, phase one, we talk about the way the world is. That's the is, the description. Then phase three, here's what you ought to do. Here's the way things ought to be." Well, what's phase two? How do we get from the way things are to the way they ought to be? From how I act, to how I ought to act? It looks like a complete mystery.
- 2.8** And so, the problem of normativity is the problem of that gap between the ought and the is, between description and then prescription, between fact and value. There are a number of ways of describing this, but think about this in a context that's practical, something like medicine, where the doctor says, "All right, here's what's going wrong. This is, in other words, a description of your condition, and now here's what you ought to do." You realize there's a big gap between "this is your condition" and "this is what you ought to do."
- 2.9** In fact, the doctor might be completely accurate in your description. Like, "Yeah, that's exactly what I'm suffering from. But now, what do I do about it?" It's taken medicine centuries to come up with better answers to that second question, even when the first was understood. Conversely, of course, the doctor might give you the right prescription, even though he misdiagnoses what the real problem is. So, wrong description, but right prescription, or right description, wrong prescription. And so, it can go either way.
- 2.10** But the point is, there is this large gap. How do we fill that, in general? When we combine that with this picture of the world that says there are two images we somehow have to bring together—the scientific image, which is all is; there are no oughts there, no good, bad, right, wrong, but then the world of our ordinary understanding of ourselves as agents in the world, where it seems like "what shall I do?" is a crucial question. In politics, what we should do becomes a crucial question. How do we get past that? How do we go from the way the world is to the way it ought to be?
- 2.11** You could think about this in purely linguistic terms. There are things and terms that are purely descriptive. If I say "that's blue" or "that's square," "that's a triangle," these are purely descriptive. There is no real emotional content. Nothing follows about what you ought to do. Some things are purely normative. If I say "good, bad," "right, wrong," "just, unjust," those tell us how this compares with how I think things ought to be.
- 2.12** Some terms do fall in between. They're called thick terms. They are things that describe but also evaluate. So, for example, if I call somebody courageous, or I say, "That person has integrity," I'm praising them, but I'm also describing them. It's not like saying, "Oh,

that person's good." If I say "courageous, or honest, or sincere, or kind, or they have integrity," that's something that gives you more information, so it's partly description, partly evaluation.

- 2.13** But that just hides the question of what's the relation between the two sides? You've given me a description. You've also evaluated it as good. You've given me, as it were, the is and the ought in one term, but how do they connect up? How do we link the way the world is with the way the world ought to be?
- 2.14** One answer is given by David Hume, when he points out the problem in his *Treatise of Human Nature*, a work that he says "fell stillborn from the press." He published it when he was 28 years old, was depressed that nobody seemed to pay it attention. Now it's considered one of the greatest works in the history of Western philosophy, but at the time, nobody cared.
- 2.15** In any case, he notices this problem, and he says that it's a problem that really affects not only the way we ordinarily live, because after all, he says, "I'm constantly finding people telling me how to live, and I don't see how they're justifying this or getting there." But also, throughout the Scientific Revolution period, and the Enlightenment up to Hume, people are offering scientific laws, but also, in morality and in politics, offering laws about how human beings ought to live, and they act as if they're comparable.
- 2.16** So we've got laws of science, like every reaction has an equal and opposite reaction, or force is mass times acceleration, or the law of gravitation. Then we have basic moral principles, moral axioms. So, in John Locke, it's "no one shall harm another in his life, health, liberty, or possessions." In Kant, it's "treat humanity always as an end in itself, never as a means only." Then, in Bentham, "The happiness of the entire community ought to be the end or object of pursuit."
- 2.17** So they're giving you a basic axiom of morality, something like a golden rule. Treat others as you would have them treat you. But for Locke, "don't harm anybody in life, health, liberty, or possessions." Kant, "treat everybody as an end in himself." In other words, treat everybody with respect, the kind of respect you would expect for yourself. And then Bentham, look, "the happiness of the entire community is what we ought to be concerned with." Well, where do those come from?
- 2.18** We can talk about how Newton, for example, justifies force, mass, acceleration, and relating them in the way his law does. But where do we get these? How do we derive that from a description of the world? Where do they come from? How do we justify them?
- 2.19** What that tells us is that the Enlightenment scientific image of the world, although people put forward these basic moral principles, it actually threatens to undermine them, because we can leave the status of physical laws up to science. We can say, "What do you mean, Newton? How do you justify that?" Newton can give us a

derivation. He can give us an explanation. We can do observations. We can do experiments. But how do we do any of that with respect to one of those basic moral principles?

- 2.20** I can't really do experiments. I can't say, "Let me steal something from you and see if that's bad." That's nonsense. What do you mean? It's not possible to engage in the same pattern of observation and reflection, experimentation, revision. That doesn't work. And so, what do we do? How do we get these? And is the problem that we can't get them? There's no way to get there.
- 2.21** So, Hume puts it this way. "In every system of morality I've met with, I've noticed that the author proceeds for some time reasoning in the ordinary way to establish the existence of a God or making points about human affairs. And then he suddenly surprises me by moving from propositions with the usual copula 'is' or 'is not', to ones that are connected by 'ought' or 'ought not'. This seems like a very small change, but it's highly important, for as this 'ought' or 'ought not' expresses some new relation or affirmation, it needs to be pointed out and explained. And a reason should be given for how this new relation can be inconceivably a deduction from others that are entirely different from it."
- 2.22** So, I am reasoning along, saying, "There is a God who is all-powerful, all-good, almighty. Well, actually, I cheated by saying all-good. I should take that back. But there is a God who is almighty, all-knowing, etc." And then I say, "So, you ought to treat others as you would like to be treated." And now Hume's saying, "Um, I don't see how you got from one place to the other."
- 2.23** Or you're Immanuel Kant. You say, "You are a rational being just like me. And so I have to treat you with respect." Hume says, "Where's this ought coming from? Yeah, you're a rational being. I'm a rational being. Nothing follows about how we ought to treat each other. That seems to require something else, something different." So we have the underpants gnome problem. OK, here's the way things are. But now you're saying, this is the way it ought to be.
- 2.24** In Bentham, people want to be happy. Yes, they do. Now you're saying, so we ought to concern ourselves with maximizing the general happiness. How did we get there? So, somehow, he says, moral reasoning goes from the is to the ought, or from the is not to the ought not, etc. But how do we do it? Reason, he says, can't supply any connection. Why? Because reason can't motivate me. Reason is sitting there in the chariot, but the horses are the ones that supply all the energy. And so, reason can just say, "Oh, that's bad, horse." But it cannot really motivate anything. It has to do something.
- 2.25** So, when we think about it in terms of the image, Hume's question is exactly the question of how they relate in that respect. The manifest image says, "I am operating in the space of reasons. I'm an agent who does things for reasons. I form intentions, I act, I make free choices." In the scientific image, we say this is the realm of law. Your

neurophysiology determines that you're going to behave in certain ways, and there's no discussion of is, ought, right, wrong, just, unjust, at that level.

- 2.26** Okay, so if that's true, how can we get from the is to the ought? Maybe we have to discard the ought and say none of it makes any sense. But Hume doesn't think that. He says, "Here's how I think we get there. It arouses a feeling of approbation or disapprobation in me." Feeling takes us from the is to the ought. So I say, let's do an experiment. I'm going to steal one of your shoes. What do you think about that? How do you feel about it? Well, you're not going to like it. What about the other people around? How are they going to feel about it? They're going to say, "That's bizarre. That's wrong. You shouldn't do that."
- 2.27** And so, we go from is, "you stole that person's shoe" to "you shouldn't do that." How did we get there? We disapprove. We react and say, "No, no, no, no." But it's an emotional reaction on our part. So he says, here's how we get there. Yeah, it requires motivation. The ought is supposed to motivate us in some way. The ought not is supposed to motivate us. And reason can't motivate us. So it's got to be either desire or emotion.
- 2.28** He says, "Well, I think it's emotion. I react in a certain way. I, let's say, see someone commit a murder on a videotape. I watch the news, and I see this happen. I think that's horrible." It's my feeling of disapproval, my feeling of horror, that is really responsible for my judgment that it's wrong. So Hume says it's feeling that gets me from the is to the ought. And so, it's an object of feeling, not of reason. It lies in me, not in the object, and that's the radical conclusion.
- 2.29** It's not just that, oh, morality is a matter of feelings instead of fully rational. It's that, that means the source of morality is me; it's not the world. It's not that that thing in the world is wrong. It's that I react to it in a certain way. So the wrongness is coming from me, not from it. An action or sentiment or character is virtuous or vicious. Why? Because its view causes a pleasure or uneasiness of a certain kind.
- 2.30** Pleasure. Yes, we see somebody act generously, for example, and help someone in need, and so that pleases us. We approve—and not just approve, it makes us feel good inside. We see something that is a crime, and we react negatively. We not only disapprove; it causes, he says, uneasiness. It might be horror, depending on the nature of the crime. So he says, in the end, "Reason is, and ought to be, the slave of the passions." It is the passions, it is feeling, that is driving all of this, and reason just follows along.
- 2.31** So we have the scientific level, where there is no ought. We have the manifest level, where it seems like, to act as an agent is to act according to the ought, thinking even if it's purely a practical question. What tie should I wear? Notice the should. I've got to think, "Yeah, how do I go from the is to the ought?" Well, I start thinking, "How do I feel about it?" And he says, "That's the foundational thing."

- 2.32 Now, luckily, most of us have a moral sense. That's a capacity to have these feelings. Being human beings, similarly structured, we tend to share a moral sense. In other words, the way I feel about things matches the way you feel about things pretty well. We're going to agree largely about our reactions to witnessing a crime, to witnessing a murder, or conversely, to witnessing an act of generosity, or of kindness, or of integrity. But there are going to be some people who lack that moral sense, just as some people are blind or deaf, and they may simply be unable to feel these things.
- 2.33 Or maybe there will be, just as you might disagree with somebody, looking at something off in the distance and saying, "What is that thing?" Or disagreeing about color, "Is that blue? Is that green? What is that?" Well, so similarly, people can look at certain hard cases, borderline cases, and say, "Is that right, wrong?" That's a case where our feelings maybe become clouded and vague, and maybe they differ one person to another. But in any case, it's really feeling. It's that emotional horse that is driving the moral cart. It is not reason.
- 2.34 Well, that's one way of reacting to this gap between the is and the ought. A second way is to say, "I don't know. I don't feel like, when I say murder is wrong, I'm just saying, I don't like murder. I disapprove of murder. It arouses a feeling of disapproval in me. It seems like I'm saying something else." And so, Ludwig Wittgenstein, a 20th-century philosopher, tends to adopt a very different approach about ethics. He shares Hume's idea about what the is level is, and he sees the gap between the is and the ought. But he doesn't think the ought is simply a matter of describing our feelings. It's something else.
- 2.35 So, he begins one of his great works, the *Tractatus Logico-Philosophicus*, by saying, the world is all that is the case. The world is all the facts. It's the totality of facts, not of things. The world is determined by the facts and by there being all the facts. He's talking about the level of the is. Now, here, independently of the idea of the scientific image of the world and the manifest image of the world, they're both talking primarily, most of the time, about the way the world is.
- 2.36 And so, he's saying, take those facts, whether they're scientific facts or everyday facts. That's what the world consists of, those facts. We have to think about the totality, and the fact that it is a totality; that determines what's the case. It determines what's not the case. In other words, it determines what's true and what's false. The facts in logical space are the world. That's what the world is. It's just this collection of facts, and that determines what's true.
- 2.37 Well, when we think about the world, we're thinking about it in terms of propositions, like saying, "That is blue, that is white, that is square," and so on. Since what we're doing is just describing facts, the proposition has to match in some way, has to picture the fact, and everything that can be thought, he said, therefore, can be said clearly. It can be thought clearly; it can then be put into words clearly. And so, all I'm doing is

reporting the facts. I'm saying, "That's white, that's blue, that's red, that's triangular, that's square." I can just put that directly into words very clearly.

- 2.38** But now, what happens when I turn to the ought? I say, "Oh, I think that was unfair." I don't know how to put that in terms of these facts. There's no fact in that collection of facts that corresponds to something being unfair. And so, he says, "If I just look at the facts themselves, they all seem to be of equal value." I can't say, "Oh, that's a good fact and a bad fact."
- 2.39** It's as if you ask the physicist, "OK, you've laid out these laws of Newton, for example. Which ones are good and which ones are bad?" "You mean, which ones are true and false, given relativity theory and so on?" "No, I mean morally good, morally bad. Like, maybe it's really bad that you have to work so hard to accelerate something. Wouldn't it be great if it weren't like that? We could just push it much more." Well, the physicist is going to say, "It's just the way the world is."
- 2.40** And so, that is how Wittgenstein is seeing this. That's just the way the world is, just a collection of facts. So, you're talking about what's good and bad, just and unjust, right and wrong. He says, "That has to be something outside this entire sphere of facts." That means it can't be pictured in a proposition or a thought, so it can't be true and false. He says, "There can't be propositions of ethics." Propositions can express nothing of what is higher. All they can do is express these facts.
- 2.41** Something that talks about facts being good or bad, right or wrong, just or unjust, that's not in the collection of facts. I don't know what to do with that. It can't be thought. So he says, ethics can't be put into words. It's transcendental. He feels the same about aesthetics. So if talking about something being beautiful or ugly, similarly, that's a comment on facts. I can describe the Mona Lisa in terms of facts or pixels or that type of thing. But now you want to know if it's beautiful? That's not one of the facts.
- 2.42** So, it's a question of, for Hume, how we react to the facts. But Wittgenstein says, "I'm not talking about the way I'm reacting. I'm trying to say something else, but it can't be said." So he said, "The answer can't be put into words, but that means the question can't be put into words." The riddle doesn't exist. If a question can be framed at all, it's also possible to answer it. Is that red? I can answer that. Is that good? He says, "I can't answer that," partly because it doesn't really convey any content. There is nothing in that collection of facts that would correspond to that.
- 2.43** And yet, he says, look, that should frustrate us. We feel that even when all possible scientific questions have been answered, the problems of life remain completely untouched. And he's right. I want to know, does my life have any meaning? What should I do? How should I live? Wittgenstein's saying, "Those can't be put into words. I can't give you answers, because you can't actually ask the question clearly, because it has no relation to this collection of facts." He says, "There are no questions left. That itself is the answer."

- 2.44** One way of taking this is to say, just forget about ethics. But actually, that's not his view. To some extent, it sounds like it here. He says, "The solution of the problem of life is seen in the vanishing of the problem." So it's like, none of that makes any sense. Forget about it all. And indeed, I think a lot of my students have that reaction to the moral theories and so on. Like, "I don't— none of this makes any sense to me. I'm going to forget about it." And that's one way of responding.
- 2.45** But in the end, that's not really his way. He says, "What we cannot speak about, we must pass over in silence." And that is intended not to be dismissive, not to just say, "Shut up already." He is saying, this is hugely important. The central problems of life are ones we can't put into language. We can't clearly ask the question, and we can't clearly answer it. But it doesn't mean it doesn't matter. In fact, it matters hugely.
- 2.46** In his lecture on ethics later, he says, "I wouldn't for the world want to dismiss these or tell you to ignore these questions. They're hugely important. It's just that they go beyond the realm of science. They go beyond the realm of ordinary thinking and ordinary language." He's saying, in effect, "Hume's raising a great question, and we all, deep down, understand at some level that question, but we can't put it into words. It is something that, in the end, is mystical."
- 2.47** And so, there is something about life that matters to us, but we can't articulate why. We can't articulate what our reasons are. Nevertheless, that doesn't mean the problems of life just go away. Somehow it's just, what can we do? We can maybe express this in other ways, through our actions or through poetry, but it can't be put into words in any traditional sense.
- 2.48** Let's look at a different reaction. This is the reaction of Friedrich Nietzsche, a revolutionary philosopher, a German philosopher of the late 19th century who died in 1900, but in many ways articulates problems that define the situation at the beginning of the 20th century. He was, by the way, also a musician, and he had a long-standing friendship with, and then hate relationship, with Richard Wagner.
- 2.49** Nietzsche goes through a number of stages of his thinking. He's looking for something that can be an account of that basic level; that is to say, the scientific image that would explain human behavior and other things about the ordinary world. In his early work, like *The Birth of Tragedy*, he talks about Dionysus versus Apollo, roughly energy versus order, as being the central conflict that drives things. Then, in a period I want to talk about more carefully here, he becomes a naturalist. He says it really is the atomic theory. It's our underlying chemistry. It's our neurophysiology.
- 2.50** Then he's a relativist. In effect, there he says, "Look, I think Hume's right, in a way. It's feeling, but no reason why your feelings should correspond to my feelings. And so, it's just what's true for you." And then he says, "Well, maybe we need to get beyond good and evil altogether and think about the ultimate evolution of the human race." Then he

starts attacking Christianity, and he says, "What's really fundamental is the will to power. It's power relations that drive everything."

2.51 So throughout, he's got a two-level theory. He's thinking, "Our ordinary behavior at this manifest level is explained by something." But he keeps changing his mind on what that something is that does the ultimate explaining. At the stage of his thinking I want to focus on here, he's talking about two-level theories, as I've described them, and he says, "Everything we need can be given to us only now that the individual sciences have reached their present height, is a chemistry of the moral, religious, and aesthetic conceptions and sensations."

2.52 So, people talk about what's good and bad, right and wrong. They talk about certain things as being clean or unclean, being holy or unholy. They talk about things being beautiful or ugly. He says, "I want to understand what's happening here. But I'm not going to do it by Hume's technique of saying, 'Well, it's a matter of feeling.' I'm not going to do what Wittgenstein later does, and just say, 'In the end, it's the mystical that I can't really put into words.'" Instead, he says, let's open this to a scientific investigation.

2.53 Somebody feels, let's say, that viewing something, it was terribly unjust. What's going on there? Let's examine what's happening in their brain. What's the neurophysiology of what they're doing? Maybe that will tell us what's really going on here. The same thing with religious experience. Let's actually examine what's going on, neurophysiologically, in people when they worship or pray or meditate or whatever it is.

2.54 Interestingly, people have done that with certain kinds of things and have come up with things. Well, here's what's happening in the brain of the worshipper or the person who is engaged in meditation. Similarly, what's going on in the brains of people who are actually viewing the Mona Lisa, or viewing other great works of art, and judging them beautiful? He's saying, there is a surface level here, and included in that are these norms. We're talking about things being good or bad, beautiful or ugly.

2.55 Something is going on at this basic level. There's a kind of biochemistry here, a neurophysiology, if you will, and somehow it's determining this. We need to investigate the connection and figure out what that base level is. So he says, when we do that, we start realizing that nearly all philosophical problems raise the same form of question they did 2,000 years ago. How can something develop from its opposite? Reason from the unreasonable, feeling from the dead, logic from the illogical, disinterested gaze from covetous wanting, altruism from egoism, truth from error.

2.56 In every case, he's saying, "Look, there's something at that base level that is missing. There's no talk there of feeling or reason or logic, or this purely aesthetic gaze that judges things beautiful, or altruism. Instead, there's just neurophysiology." And so, how does all that arise in some way from things that seem to involve none of that? So, in a sense, he's going beyond the pure is and ought. There's the is here, and then there's

not just the ought, but there's the rational, the logical, the beautiful, the ugly, the kind, and so on—for that matter, the true. How does all that relate to what's going on at the scientific level, whatever exactly is happening there?

- 2.57** Now, here's what really frightens him. Not just that we don't know where all that's coming from. We don't understand how it's arising from its opposite. But also, he says, it doesn't seem as if science itself progresses rationally. There is a picture of science, and a thought more generally, that says, look, there are lots of individual examples of irrationality and bad science and ignoring evidence and so on. But nevertheless, overall, you expect things to develop in rational ways. You think we've been making progress.
- 2.58** And indeed, with the Agricultural Revolution, the Industrial Revolutions, it feels as if humanity has made immense progress. So things are getting better and better, and closer and closer to the truth. But Nietzsche says, well, if you look at what happens in science, it's not really like that. People often make decisions about what they think is true and false, based on what's exciting. "Oh, a new innovative idea. I could get publications out of that. I know what experiments to run, etc." Or, "No, no, no, that's crazy. That challenges the way we've been doing things for years. I'm going to brush it aside."
- 2.59** In short, it's largely irrational. And so, he loses confidence that scientific method and rational techniques in general are going to produce better and better outcomes. He says, "What if in the end it's driven by, well, just these personality factors or irrational considerations? What if it's driven in the end by biochemistry or the will to power?" After all, the scientist is deciding that this is a good or a bad theory, in part, just depending on what's happening inside them, their own neurophysiology. So, why should we trust any of that to be rational?
- 2.60** And so he says, "What if this chemistry would reveal that, in these areas too, the most glorious colors arise from low, despised materials?" Not just in a certain sense, the good and bad, right and wrong, beautiful and ugly, rational and irrational, but also in the end, science itself seems to arise from these despised materials. So it's like, if the scientific theory tells us it itself was produced by these value-free neurophysiological activities, why should we think it's approaching the truth?
- 2.61** That leads him to a kind of relativism. If you lose faith in any absolute truth, what can you say? Maybe truth just depends on you and me. Relativism is the thesis that there are no universally valid truths about the world. Protagoras had said, "Man is the measure of all things," and he meant each individual person. But you could be a relativist in other ways, too. You could think, truth is relative to a society or a culture or some historical epic or to an interpretive community—that's Richard Rorty's phrase—or to an individual person, or even, I suppose, to an individual person in a certain mood on a certain day.

- 2.62 You could make things as relative as you like. But the point is, there is no such thing as an absolute truth. And Nietzsche has a particular version of that. He says truth is relative to a certain historical period, a certain era. So what is true for us now may not be what was true for the ancient Greeks, or the ancient Indians, or someone in medieval Europe. It may simply be that truth is relative. Why? Because we're perceiving the world in ways that are ultimately not driven by rationality, are driven by our own internal physical, chemical composition.
- 2.63 And so he says, "Philosophers automatically think of man as an 'aeterna veritas', an eternal truth, as a constant in the flux, as a safe measure of things to come. Everything that philosophers say about man is no longer fundamental, but tells us something about the men of a very limited period of time. Lack of historical sense is the hereditary error of all philosophers." So, everybody at all these periods thinks, "Here is what a human being is. Here is what it is to be human. Here is what is rational. Here is what is good. Here is what is just," as if they can somehow transcend their own historical circumstances and pronounce things for all of humanity and for all of time.
- 2.64 He says, "But that's nonsense. The most you can tell me, Aristotle, is what is admirable in your ancient Athenian culture. The most I can tell you is what, in 19th-century Germany, seems like a good thing." The British, he really attacks the utilitarians, like Jeremy Bentham and John Stuart Mill. He considers them very boring. But he says, "You're telling me what it is to be a good 19th-century Victorian gentleman. Fine. OK, but that's all you're telling me. You're not telling me what it is to be a human being or how human beings ought to act."
- 2.65 So he says, "Everything became what it is. There are no eternal facts. There are no absolute truths." If you want a bold statement of relativism, there it is. OK, that's about as blunt as you can be, about saying, in the end, it's just up to the way you are perceiving it. So what do we need now? Historical philosophizing, the virtue of modesty. I should be talking about how things seem to me, how things seem at my period of time. Here's the way we perceive the world. That's the most I can do. I can't talk about the way the world really is. I can't talk about the way you really ought to live. At most, I can say, it seems to us now that that's how you ought to live.
- 2.66 To some extent, he is inheriting this historical relativism from Hegel, an earlier German philosopher. But Hegel thinks he can uncover these dynamic meta-level, higher-level truths about the way in which thought progresses. Hegel's way of doing this is interesting, but beside our point now; he thinks, in any case, though, we construct these, we construct them according to a pattern he thinks he can identify. But nevertheless, the way we construct them makes them relative to a historical context and also a social context. So, here's how we in this culture do it at this period of time.
- 2.67 They express, he puts it, "the world spirit in its current state of development." What's the world spirit? Don't ask me that question. I don't know. But anyway, whatever it is, it develops, and it progresses toward what he calls the absolute. At that point, it will end,

and at that point, we will have absolute truth. So he thinks it's possible at the end of time. However, at this point, he ends up saying, well, whatever is, is rational. Whatever is, is right, because that's the way the spirit has unfolded at this time and place.

2.68 Now, here's a way in which that idea, rather mystical, I think, inspired something that isn't particularly mystical. C. S. Peirce, and in general, the American pragmatists, took this as a way of describing scientific method. We don't have to talk about high-level, somewhat mystical, dynamic ways of thinking. Just think about science. Here's what makes science good. It's self-correcting. We make observations, we formulate hypotheses, and then we test them through experiment. And we find out sometimes, in fact, much of the time, they need to be revised. So we revise them, subject them to further experiment, revise them again, and so on. We revise in light of new evidence.

2.69 And what we're seeking here is not so much absolute truth as stable belief. We are trying to find something we won't have to give up in the face of further observation and experimentation. But Nietzsche says, yeah, that's one way of approaching this, and a way that, especially in the United States and in American philosophy, has been very influential. But Nietzsche worries about that. He says, "But all that depends on the thought that science advances in these self-correcting rational ways. What if it doesn't? Then there's no reason to think that this is an improvement of what people used to think."

2.70 We like to think that, now that we're in the 21st century, we're so much more sophisticated than those people of earlier times. But if you adopt Nietzsche's attitude, you realize, maybe we're not. In fact, it is a humbling experience to go to a place like London or Rome or Paris or other old cities, look around and see what people produced hundreds of years ago, thousands of years ago, and think, in many cases, we don't know how to do that anymore. OK, compare a modern building to a medieval cathedral, for example. It's humbling.

Lecture 3: Wisdom of the Age

At a glance — The wisdom of the age.

- 3.1 The "Wisdom of the Age"—might not seem to be very much wisdom, but it does relate to the problem we've been discussing, about how you fit "ought" into a world that seems to be described completely by "is." We have this idea that there is a scientific image of the world, that whatever it looks like exactly has no real value in it. It just describes the way things are, the laws under which things operate for better or for worse.
- 3.2 Then we have these concepts of better and worse. Just, unjust, right, wrong. How do they fit into that basic picture? Well, it's not clear. David Hume, who focused on that problem, ended up saying it's feeling. Really, in the end, the values are coming from us; the source is in us and not in the world. And so, there's nothing about that action that makes it right or wrong. It's just my response to that action that makes it right or wrong.
- 3.3 We've looked at various other approaches, Wittgenstein saying, "I don't know how to put this into words." I get a sense that somehow saying, "There's no question here; we can't really raise the question," to saying, "But still, we have this sense that the problems of life are real and that they're unchanged. Knowing that we can't articulate them doesn't make them go away." Then we look at Nietzsche or Ivan, Dostoevsky's character, where we find, here's an attempt to do something else, and it leads us right back into ourselves, and in the end, to Hume's position, that it's something about me, that I'm projecting this onto the world. There's nothing in the world itself.
- 3.4 There's another reaction we might have, which is to just be openly cynical about values, to say, "I can't find a place for the ought in this world of is, that I think is completely described by the is. So let's just get rid of the ought. Forget it." I want to look at a particular example of someone who seems to me in some ways to be doing that, and that is George Bernard Shaw. He writes a play called *Man and Superman*, which is his retelling of the Don Juan story, but with a woman as Don Juan.
- 3.5 In the end, there is this appendix, maxims for revolutionists, which describes the views of one of the characters, the young idealistic socialist who is one of the suitors of the woman who is the main character, in a way, of the play. The title of the play comes from Nietzsche's idea that we're evolving toward a higher state, that we are evolving toward this higher state, which he refers to as the superman, and that would be beyond good and evil. We would, in the end, no longer talk about right and wrong, good and evil, but there might still be good and bad, and yet it would be defined purely in terms of what was good for us.
- 3.6 Well, Shaw is not somebody who, at the beginning at least, just forsakes all value judgments. He was a committed socialist. He won the Nobel Prize for literature in 1925

and an Oscar for Pygmalion, which later became My Fair Lady. So he was himself a highly accomplished writer. But he was part of a group in Britain that founded the Fabian Society. The idea here was to advance socialism gradually.

- 3.7** So, they thought, this society is not ready for socialism. Things have been moving along in a way that does seem to reveal dramatic progress during the 19th century, but we are nevertheless convinced that socialism is the right way to go. Even if people aren't ready for it now, we can gradually lead them there. Famous members included not only George Bernard Shaw, but H. G. Wells, Havelock Ellis, Virginia Woolf, the Webbs, R. H. Tawney, Harold Laski, a variety of other people.
- 3.8** In the end, it was people from the Fabian Society who founded the Labour Party. So this continues to be a highly influential element in British politics. Here you see a stained glass window that reflects the ideals of the Fabian Society. "Mold it to the heart's desire." In other words, reshape the world to fit the heart's desire. A good example of what Sowell would call the unconstrained vision. We have this vision of utopia. Let's mold the world to suit our vision.
- 3.9** Now, how do we understand socialism? There are lots and lots of possible definitions, and if you look at various places, you'll see it defined in various ways. Some of them are rather specific, like the abolition of private property, which makes it seem synonymous with communism. But I think the best general definition actually comes from one of the opponents of socialism, Friedrich Hayek.
- 3.10** He characterizes it this way. "Socialism is the centralized, conscious direction of social forces to consciously chosen ends." The idea here is that we centralize things, we consciously address the goal we want to reach, and consciously address the means we're going to take to that goal. And so, the key parts here are both the conscious aspects and the centralized aspects. We think about things consciously. What are we trying to achieve here? Let's start with a goal, like this vision of what the world ought to be like. Then let's centralize and consciously think about the means to those goals.
- 3.11** The idea is, let's get together and make decisions about this. If we want to contrast this with other approaches, we might look at it this way. The socialist says, "I want decisions to be centralized." The advocate of liberty typically says, "No, I want them decentralized. I want different people making choices." Now, what would motivate you toward the centralization? The key idea is to think about things the way you would think about individual action.
- 3.12** Let's say you're thinking, "How should I live my life?" Somebody might say, "Well, I think you should live it intentionally." What I mean by that is, I think you should decide what your goal is. I think you should decide how you're going to get there, construct a plan for achieving that goal, and then follow out the plan. Do all this rationally and do it consciously. What do you want for your life? Decide on that and then think, "How am I

going to get there?" In a lot of smaller ways, we do that all the time, and we think that's rational.

3.13 "I need new shoes. What should I do?" Well, first of all, I construct consciously my desire. "I want shoes." Secondly, I think, "Where do I go to get shoes?" I think about that and I then go about procuring them. We do it consciously. In contrast, it might seem that a decentralized approach to my individual life would be odd, even though, in some way, I think we all end up living that way. I don't start out thinking, "Here's the goal for my life," and then construct a grand plan to get there. Actually, I've probably done that more than most people because I decided at a pretty early age, "I want to be a professor." Well, then, OK, I've done that.

3.14 But most of us go through life seizing on opportunities as we go. We weren't expecting this to happen, and suddenly, we had a chance to do this or a chance to do that. We say yes. In short, it's a bunch of individual decisions, and it evolves, well, we hope into something good. Maybe it devolves into something utterly incoherent. But in any case, we make a lot of decisions separately. Now, the socialist says, "Well, it seems like an idea would be, as an individual, I think through my goal, and then I think how to get there."

3.15 So, apply that to society. Let's centralize this rational planning. The goal here is to have society proceed rationally. We decide rationally on our goal, and consciously we do that. We decide rationally and consciously on the means. And so, we do this in a conscious way. It's not market-driven, it's not evolutionary. We direct social forces. We don't let them evolve as various people make various decisions at various times. We do it to consciously chosen ends. We decide where we want to go. We don't just say, "Well, let's find out where we go, if lots of people make choices."

3.16 Then there are different analogies that people use here. The model for the socialist is that society is like an organism, and the various parts have to work together for the organism to survive and to thrive. Whereas the alternative is to say, no, society is more like an ecosystem, and individual beings thrive and survive within it, but it evolves in a way that's complicated and isn't really directed by any of the beings in it. And so, one way of looking at a society is to say it is like an ecosystem. Lots of people are doing lots of things, pursuing lots of different goals. It evolves in various ways to solve certain problems. That's the way devoted to liberty.

3.17 The other way says, "Here is our goal; here's how we are going to get there," and then directs us toward those ends. Well, Shaw is committed to that centralized conscious vision. For reasons of rationality, he thinks that's what a reasonable approach to life for an individual or a society would be. In a play called *Back to Methuselah* in 1921, he says, "You see things"—well, actually, he doesn't say this. This is the serpent talking to Eve in the play. "You see things and say, 'Why?' But I dream things that never were and say, 'Why not?'" The phrase is famous from a speech by Robert Kennedy back in the 1960s, but he's actually quoting the serpent in Shaw's play when he says that.

- 3.18** Nevertheless, all of this might make you think, OK, Shaw's got this very definite idea about right and wrong, good and bad, and he has this certain conception of how this works in politics, and he pursues that. Well, in some ways that's true, and yet in the writings of the revolutionists here in the play, he's utterly cynical about all of this. Look at what he says about certain things that are important values, indeed, important values for a socialist. He says, "He who confuses political liberty with freedom and political equality with similarity has never thought for five minutes about either. Nothing can be unconditional; consequently, nothing can be free."
- 3.19** What about liberty itself? "Liberty means responsibility. That's why most men dread it." Here, he sounds a bit like Ivan in the *Brothers Karamazov*. "Where equality is undisputed, so also is subordination." In short, he thinks, equality, liberty, they aren't what you think. They aren't really such great values. Liberty, people don't want to be free. There, he agrees with Ivan. But also where equality is undisputed, so is subordination. The socialist trumpets equality. He says, "That's a cover. That's nonsense."
- 3.20** What about property? One of the fundamental rights, according to John Locke. "Property," said Proudhon, "is theft. It's the only perfect truism that's been uttered on the subject." Utterly dismissive then of rights to property or rights to liberty, even rights to equality. What about democracy? He said, that doesn't work. "If a lesser mind could measure the greater as a foot-rule can measure a pyramid, there would be finality in universal suffrage. As it is, the political problem remains unsolved. Democracy substitutes election by the incompetent many for appointment by the corrupt few."
- 3.21** Notice what he's saying there, "if the lesser mind could measure the greater." In other words, people are idiots. To allow all the idiots to vote is not really going to solve the problem. It's not just because they're lesser minds, it's because there's no way of measuring. How do you measure whether somebody would be a great leader? The point is, there's no way of doing that. If only we had a measuring stick, if only we had a foot-rule, we could say, "Here's how this leader measures up, here's how that one does." But we don't have that. And so, in the end, democracy is no solution. It just substitutes election by the incompetent for appointment by the corrupt. It doesn't help.
- 3.22** What about civilization itself? You might think, well, even if, in any given democratic election, people might make the wrong choice because they have no real way of knowing who is going to be a great leader, what about civilization? We have the whole heritage of our civilization. Maybe we can rely on that. In any individual case, yeah, we can get things wrong, but overall, we've produced great things.
- 3.23** He doesn't like that either. "Civilization is a disease produced by the practice of building societies with rotten material." What do you mean, rotten material? He means you and me, friends. We're the rotten material. OK, so civilization, that's no answer. It's, instead of just these idiots on this occasion, those idiots, just add all that up. It's just a bunch of

idiots on a bunch of occasions. That's all it is. In fact, he goes so far as to say, "The imagination cannot conceive a viler criminal than he who should build another London like the present one, nor a greater benefactor than he who should destroy it."

- 3.24** Now, that's an amazing thing for Shaw to be writing in 1903. London, at that point, is the greatest city in the world, and not only the largest city, but also one that is viewed as the height of civilization. It is the center of the British Empire, the most powerful empire on Earth. And so, for him to write this about London at that time is a shocking thing. Still, he says, "Build another one like this? No, thank you. A vile criminal act." And destroy it? That would be a benefit.
- 3.25** Well, he didn't have long to wait. London would at least suffer a lot of destruction within just a few years. Here are children crying outside the rubble of what used to be their house after the bombing in the Battle of Britain. Now, you might say, well, this is just Shaw speaking through a character and in an appendix of a play. So these are the things that supposedly motivate this one character. Surely, you can't take that as representing Shaw's views. Fair enough. Shaw's views were worse. So if you think this is something that's a little shocking in its cynicism, it goes much further.
- 3.26** His cynicism leads him to extremism. So, Shaw admired Stalin. He had a portrait of Felix Dzerzhinsky, the founder and head of the Cheka, that's the secret police, from 1917 to 1926, on his wall. The Cheka were the people who went around executing people. He thought that was great. Shaw said, "If we desire a certain type of civilization and culture, we must exterminate the sort of people who don't fit into it. The majority of men at present in Europe have no business to be alive."
- 3.27** So he not only was willing to tolerate this in the way that later, Walter Duranty, for example, said, "Well, to make an omelet, you have to break some eggs," as if, yeah, it's unfortunate, but it's got to be done. He actually liked it. "These people have no business to be alive." And he put the portrait of the guy who is the killer on his wall. It gets worse. "The ungovernables, the ferocious, the conscienceless, the idiots, the self-centered myopes, and morons, what of them? Don't punish them. Kill, kill, kill, kill, kill them."
- 3.28** The essential justification for extermination is always incorrigible social incompatibility and nothing else. So the cynicism about value, getting rid of the ought, is something that leads him to embrace the most extreme—not just, well, violence, violence and intolerance. He says, "I've seen all the quote, unquote, 'terrors'"—that is, he's talking about Stalin's regime, "and I was terribly pleased by them." So not an unfortunate necessity. No, he was pleased by them. He wants the bloodshed. He wants the murder. It's astounding.
- 3.29** Now, then Hitler arises and here's somebody else who's doing this act of extermination. Shaw's all in favor. He wrote an essay entitled Heil Hitler! "Tell Colonel Hermann Göring, with my compliments, that I backed his regime in England to the point of

making myself unpopular and still continue to do so on all matters on which he and Hitler stand for permanent truths and genuine Realpolitik." So, Shaw is willing to take this cynicism about value, this rejection of any kind of moral constraint, to an extreme.

- 3.30** Now, that is maybe a reason for you already to think, "I don't want to hear anymore." But it's not just a cynicism about ought in this particular area. Shaw is willing to extend this all across the board. So, for example, education. Here, he's sitting close to home. I, as a professor, feel especially under attack by this, but here's what he has to say. "When a man teaches something he doesn't know to someone else who has no aptitude for it and gives them a certificate of proficiency, the latter has completed the education of a gentleman. A fool's brain digests philosophy into folly, science into superstition, art into pedantry; hence, university education."
- 3.31** Well, most famously, he says, "He who can, does; he who cannot, teaches." Woody Allen added, "He who cannot teach, teaches gym." But in any event, yeah, he's saying, in effect, yeah, teachers are the ones who can't actually do it. That's why they're up there teaching. "A learned man is an idler who kills time with study. Beware his false knowledge. It's more dangerous than ignorance. No man can be a pure specialist without being in the strict sense an idiot."
- 3.32** Now, here he's saying something that I think is in part cynical and insulting, but he does have a point, which is two things. First of all, beware false knowledge. It reminds me of a line in the Talmud where one of the rabbis is saying, "Beware— by all means, sit around the fire and listen to the words of the wise, but beware of the embers." Because even a wise teacher can say things that will lead you astray. So be careful about that. By all means, value knowledge, but beware false knowledge because you can be misled. I think that's a legitimate point.
- 3.33** Also, specialization does have a danger to it. You can specialize to the point that you think you know lots and lots about this, and you do, but you also think, "I'm an expert." And think way too much of your expertise. We find people like that a lot in our current society, who are experts on X, Y, or Z, and think it gives them the title to pronounce on almost everything, like a guy who knows a lot of philosophy and thinks he can talk about literature and art, for example. But mostly, it's people who actually have studied one thing and have won the Nobel Prize even in some area, but then start opining on all sorts of things they don't really know in the end that much about.
- 3.34** To some extent, Shaw is pointing out, look, you spend all your time studying this particular thing. There's a huge amount you're not going to know. How do we know? He says, "Activity is the only road to knowledge." Again, I think there's a legitimate point here. You know by doing in a lot of cases. It's one thing to study something in a book. It's another thing to actually do it in practice and learn in practice. Some things, maybe that is the only way to know.

- 3.35** Now, I think that's not true for a lot of things. If you're studying theoretical physics, you can do fine studying from teachers or from books. But on the other hand, doing things does teach you about certain things. Imagine saying, "Oh, I know all about playing the tuba. I read a book on it once. Well, I never picked up a tuba or anything," but that's absurd, right? It's obviously absurd. Or, "Hey, I've read some books on tennis, so I think I know how to play tennis." No, you've got to do it. And lots of things are like that.
- 3.36** He says, "Every fool believes what his teachers tell him and calls his credulity—science or morality, as confidently as his father called it divine revelation." So that idea, "Every fool believes what his teachers tell him," but now here's the thing. That much, OK, people believe what you tell them. But then "he calls his credulity science or morality, as confidently as his father called it divine revelation." In other words, people don't think critically about what they hear. They just accept it.
- 3.37** To some extent, testimony is a very good source of knowledge. There's perfectly rational reason to do this and believe things because other people tell you. On the other hand, be careful because people can tell you false things. So it goes back to that idea: beware false knowledge.
- 3.38** What about reason itself? Let's go back to Plato's chariot with reason in the driver's seat and the two horses of emotion and desire. "The man who listens to reason is lost. Reason enslaves all whose minds are not strong enough to master her." So here, he's not thinking of reason as driving the chariot. He's thinking of reason as the potentially dangerous thing that can actually enslave you. You have to master reason. It's not a matter of reason mastering emotion and desire.
- 3.39** Now, one interpretation would just be to say, well, he's saying emotion and desire have to master reason. But I think he's, in a way, saying something different. It's not just that he's championing emotion or championing desire. He's really saying, be careful about reason itself.
- 3.40** Why? "The reasonable man adapts himself to the world. The unreasonable one persists in trying to adapt the world to himself. Therefore, all progress depends on the unreasonable man." That is a weird little argument, but it is making that point. He's saying, if we do not start out with this concept of where we want to go, it's just a matter of the world pushing us in various directions at various times, and we end up someplace where we think, "How did we get here?"
- 3.41** In the end, what drives progress? What makes people advance? What leads to innovation? It's the unreasonable person who says, "I'm not just going to adapt to the way things are; I'm going to make them different." I need, for example, something that would actually plant these seeds in regular patterns, and so Jethro Tull invents the seed drill. Or it might be, look, I don't really understand how all of this is possible. These experiments suggest we don't understand the nature of light. And so, starts saying, "I

have to try to understand this, and I'm going to adapt things to a very different way of thinking about them," and we get the theory of relativity.

- 3.42** Well, so far, I've been, except for political questions and violence, I've been ignoring the question of the ought. But let's address that directly. What about the ought? And what is his attitude about ethics, about morality? Well, the golden rule. He says, "Do unto others what you would have them do unto you," as it says in Matthew 7. Well, that idea of Jesus' is reflected in all sorts of other places. Kant says, "Don't make an exception for yourself. Decide on the basis of principle and treat everybody as an end in himself." Well, the idea here is to treat others with the respect and dignity you'd like to be accorded.
- 3.43** Shaw's response, "Don't do unto others as you would have them do unto you. Their tastes may not be the same." Note the underlying relativism here. He's saying, wait, I think— how would I like to be treated? Well, I wish people would treat me to a beer, so I should treat other people to a beer. No, that's not how it goes. I mean, this is actually not by any means a new objection or something to—it's hard to say. Is this an objection? Is this simply a joke? It's a little hard to tell in Shaw, but it is a traditional objection.
- 3.44** The right response over the history of theology has been to say, well, look, it's not talking about whatever whim you might have at the moment. "I'd like a beer, so let me buy other people beers." It's instead a matter of how I would like, rationally, people to treat me. In other words, it's something that is basic, how I would want as a human being to be treated. I'm not talking about this sort of whim or that sort of whim, day to day. I'm talking about something that is more fundamental, more constant, as something I would hope for.
- 3.45** What about another thing from the summary of the law? "Love your neighbor as yourself." That appears in the Old Testament and repeatedly in the New Testament. His response, "Don't love your neighbor as yourself. If you're on good terms with yourself, it's an impertinence; if on bad, an injury." So again, a kind of relativism. "Love your neighbor as yourself." Well, I want to—Shaw wants to ask you, "Well, how do you feel about yourself?" And again, partly a joke, partly a serious point. But the answer is, at least traditionally, well, we all have a certain basic desire for survival, for self-preservation, and for self-improvement. So, respect that in others as well as in yourself. Treat them the same way.
- 3.46** But to some extent, Shaw here, I think, is being a bit, well, cynical, yes, and partly facetious. "The golden rule," he says, "is that there are no golden rules." In other words, there is no basis. He's partly challenging that indictment idea that there are foundational principles of morality that are analogous to scientific laws. But to some extent, I think he's just saying there's no such thing as morality. Discard the ought, discard this sense of obligation, discard the good and evil, right and wrong stuff. It doesn't do anything for you.

- 3.47** What about temptation? The problem is ancient, going back to the story of the Garden of Eden. It's something that Roman poets, interestingly, write a lot about. Ovid, for example, characterizes it as "knowing the better and doing the worse." And characters in Ovid do that all the time. They know what they ought to do, but they don't do it. They give in to temptation and do what they themselves judge to be worse.
- 3.48** You find this in the New Testament in a very powerful and classic form, in Romans. Paul says, "I don't understand what I do. For what I want to do, I do not do. But what I hate, I do. For I have the desire to do what is good, but I cannot carry it out. For I don't do the good that I want to do, but the evil I don't want to do, that I do." That idea—that I know I ought to be doing this, but I don't do it; I do this other thing instead, even though I judge I shouldn't do it—that seems like a common feature of human existence.
- 3.49** How does Shaw respond to that? There are various ways of responding. I mean, one, in Mark, "Watch and pray so you do not fall into temptation." Or Thessalonians, "Prove all things, hold fast that which is good." Here is Shaw's response: "Never resist temptation; prove all things; hold fast that which is good." So be willing to try anything. Don't resist temptation. Maybe it'll turn out to be great.
- 3.50** How about this? "Don't resist an evil person. If someone strikes you on the right cheek, turn to him the other also." Here's Shaw's response. "Beware of the man who does not return your blow. He neither forgives you nor allows you to forgive yourself." Now, that's something. "Beware the man who does not return your blow. He neither forgives you nor allows you to forgive yourself." He is saying, actually, something that comes close to a saying of Jesus at one point, which is, "You will in this way be heaping burning coals upon his head." But it's partly through giving a sense of moral shame.
- 3.51** I don't think that, however, is how Shaw means it. He's too cynical for that. And so, what he means is, look, don't trust this. That person doesn't forgive you. What they're doing is trying to make you feel guilty. So where Jesus says, "Yeah, in that way, good, because that person should feel guilty," Shaw is saying, "This is just a dirty trick, so look out for it." Then there are all sorts of other stray sayings. Here's one relevant to that. "If you injure your neighbor, better not do it by halves," kind of like, "If you take a shot at the king, you'd better not miss."
- 3.52** He mocks all sorts of other Enlightenment ideals. "Decadence can find agents only when it wears the mask of progress." So he's writing this at the end of what was described as an age of faith and an age of progress. It's not progress, it's just decadence. "The love of fair play is a spectator's virtue, not a principle's." You think justice is an important value? Fairness? Nonsense. That's just what the spectator cares about. Those who are playing the game, they just want to win. "Marriage, it's popular because it combines the maximum of temptation with the maximum of opportunity."
- 3.53** Now, so far, I've been talking about things in Shaw that I mostly think are outrageous, though there are nuggets of wisdom in there. But there are a couple of things he says

that I think are really interesting, and this is one of them. "You can't believe in honor until you've achieved it. Better keep yourself clean and bright: you are the window through which you must see the world." That seems to me a great point. "Keep yourself clean and bright. You are the window through which you must see the world."

- 3.54** There's something very much like this in Chinese philosophy, in Mencius, and again in Wang Yangming, this idea that the mind is like a mirror of the world, and you've got to keep it clean and bright. Otherwise, it distorts things. But you see the world in that mirror, so be very careful about it. Keep it preserved, keep it protected, and keep it clean. When you think about that idea, that how you perceive the world is something fundamental, and it depends a lot on you, not just on the world, I think there's some deep insight there.
- 3.55** One that I think is nicely expressed by somebody we'll talk much more about later, Iris Murdoch, a British philosopher and novelist who, at one point, writes, "We spend most of our lives in a kind of inner dialogue with ourselves. It matters hugely what kind of dialogue it is." I am constantly telling myself a story and engaged in a dialogue with myself inside my head, even when I'm sitting there silently, alone. And it matters what kind of dialogue that is.
- 3.56** Every moment, she says, has a moral tag because I'm talking to myself, as it were, and that talk matters from a moral point of view. The nature of our inner dialogue determines, at least as much as anything external that happens to us, what kind of life we lead. I think Shaw recognized that. That's why he says, "We are the windows through which we see the world."
- 3.57** Well, I want to leave Shaw for a moment because, after all, he's one guy. I think, even though he's part of this influential Fabian group, maybe in the end, it doesn't matter so much what he or a character in one of his plays thinks. But I want to look at an Italian movement that actually, I think, had a more significant impact on world history and the history of art, but maybe less so art than a more general sense of capturing an idea of what people cared about and what they thought just before the First World War and what helped to promote the idea of the First World War.
- 3.58** So, futurism. It was a new artistic movement. The hero of it, the originator in some way, was Filippo Tommaso Marinetti. He began this Futurist movement in 1909, and he thought of the nostalgia for the past that a lot of people felt. After all, there were radical social changes going on. People thought, "I miss the good old days. Even if we didn't have airplanes and cars and telephones and so on, still, there was something about life in the countryside that I miss." So there's a nostalgia.
- 3.59** The Futurists said, "No, embrace the future. That's just a failure of nerve." So in part, they were confident. They were optimistic. They embraced the modern. In their art, they had skyscrapers, tunnels, things that were technological advances, airplanes, other things like that as subjects in a lot of cases. They were people who said, "Look,

yes, the world is changing, and it's fantastic. It's wonderful. Embrace it." And so, here is something that Marinetti published as the Futurist Manifesto. Some quotations from it.

- 3.60** "We want to sing the love of danger, the habit of energy and rashness." In other words, plunge ahead boldly. Don't worry, don't worry, embrace the new. "The essential elements of our poetry will be courage, audacity, and revolt. Literature has up to now magnified pensive immobility, ecstasy, and slumber. We want to exalt movements of aggression, feverish sleeplessness, the double march, the perilous leap, the slap, and the blow with a fist. We declare that the splendor of the world has been enriched by a new beauty, the beauty of speed." Speed of a roaring train, the speed of a motorboat, the speed of a steam engine and a motor car.
- 3.61** So there is this sense partly of embrace this new technology. It's exciting, it's wonderful. But also a sense in a deeper way that there is something about change, something about dynamism, something about the energy as something moves, that tells us something about its inner being. So if I want to say: What is essential to this thing? What are the properties that make it what it is?, and I try to answer that in terms that are static, just look at it there, I'm not going to be capturing what is really making it tick. I'm not going to capture the essence.
- 3.62** I have to think about what makes it move, how it changes over time. That's what the essence of it is. And so, I need it to be dynamic. I need to see change. Here's, I think, a nice way of illustrating it. Suppose you see a photograph of someone. Do you get a sense of who that person is? Sometimes, but often you don't. If it's just a still photograph, it's hard to tell much about a person's personality from that. But suppose you watch them on video. Suppose you meet them in real life. You immediately get a stronger sense of who that person is, what they're like.
- 3.63** It's through the movement, the dynamism, the energy. It's the changes that tells you what's really going on. It's not so much just the way the person is presented in a freeze frame. That idea, that you've got to get a sense of motion to capture the inner being of things, is, I think, fundamental to Futurism. Here you see a really nice image of dynamism, of a dog on a leash, a little dog, as you get the sense of it running along. It's that motion, and the attempt to capture the motion, the energy, in the art that I think is part of what makes futurism really innovative and exciting.
- 3.64** But now there are aspects of it that are not so exciting. So part of that dynamism is a willingness to accept violence. "We want to glorify war, the only cure for the world, militarism, patriotism, the destructive gesture of the anarchists, the beautiful ideas which kill, and contempt for woman." Now, what did women have to do with it? How did they get into this? Well, I think the idea is something like Orson Welles's thought: "Hey, we built civilization to impress our girlfriends. If it weren't for women, we'd still be sitting around in caves eating raw meat."

- 3.65** So maybe it's that, but maybe it's a sense that women preserve civilization. Men may be actually the innovators in a lot of cases, but on the other hand, it's women who hold things together. And they don't like that. They hate civilization in a way. They want war, they want change. And so, contempt for a woman just because—contempt for those who actually want to worry about, "What are we going to have for dinner? And hey, what's happening at home, and how are the kids?"
- 3.66** No, instead, they're saying, no, change, be willing to embrace it no matter what. That wild abandon is something that they think, rightly or wrongly, is incompatible with womanhood. Well, however that may be, notice the willingness to embrace "the beautiful ideas that kill." Militarism. "We want to demolish museums and libraries, fight morality, feminism, and all opportunist and utilitarian cowardice." In other words, all these other sources of value are to be rejected. Libraries, museums, records of the past—we don't care about the past. We want the future. Get rid of them.
- 3.67** Morality, that's the set of rules we've inherited for how to behave. Get rid of them. They just restrict us. Feminism and opportunist and utilitarian—in other words, a stress on happiness, a stress on equality, a stress—no, we want change. We want excitement. We want innovation. We want dynamism. All of that is a way of saying, "Hey, you got to abide by certain rules." We don't want to abide by any rules. We want to just pursue change wherever it leads us.
- 3.68** So, Marinetti writes, "It's in Italy that we're issuing this manifesto of ruinous and incendiary violence, by which we today are founding Futurism, because we want to deliver Italy from its gangrene of professors, archeologists, tourist guides, and antiquaries." Go walk through the streets of Rome. Everywhere you go, you see ancient buildings; you see ruins. People start digging to put in a new pipe. Immediately, they find ruins, and it has to be an archeological investigation. It's actually a big issue.
- 3.69** We saw riots last time I was in Rome. Well, riots, at least protests, pretty large protests, of people who were there saying, "But we need the pipe. Get rid of these archeologists." They were in effect like the Futurists, saying, "Come on, yeah, the past is here. It's just restricting us. It's keeping us from good things." "Let the good incendiaries with charred fingers come! Here they are! Heap up the fire to the shelves of the libraries! Divert the canals to flood the cellars of the museums! Let the glorious canvases swim ashore! Take the picks and hammers! Undermine the foundations of venerable towns!"
- 3.70** So, in other words, destroy the history of this civilization. Destroy the past. Instead, let's embrace the future. "The oldest among us aren't yet thirty. We have at least ten years to accomplish our task. When we're forty, let younger and stronger men than we throw us into the wastepaper basket like useless manuscripts. The crowd around us, panting with anguish and disappointment, exasperated by our proud indefatigable courage, will hurl themselves forward to kill us, with all the more hatred, as their hearts will be drunk with love and admiration for us." A little narcissism there. "And strong, healthy

Injustice will shine radiantly from their eyes. For art can only be violence, cruelty, injustice."

- 3.71** So there's a rejection of the past, a rejection of civilization, a rejection of any kind of constraint. "We've been discussing right up to the limits of logic and scrawling the paper with demented writing." And so, they're willing to take this quite far. "A great sweep of madness brought us sharply back to ourselves. Drove us through the streets, steep and deep, like dried-up torrents. Here and there, unhappy lamps in the windows taught us to despise our mathematical eyes. 'Smell,' I exclaimed. 'Smell is good enough for wild beasts.'"
- 3.72** So, "Let us leave ourselves behind, good sense behind. Hurl ourselves, like fruit spiced with pride, into the immense mouth and breast of the world. Let us feed the unknown, not from despair, but simply to enrich the unfathomable reservoirs of the absurd." Now, that seems to me a really interesting thought, "the unfathomable reservoirs of the absurd." We're going to confront absurdity in some form or other in a number of different ways throughout these lectures. And part of the idea here is coming from the Futurists.
- 3.73** They are saying, notice, let's enrich that. The absurd is not something to be shrinking back from. It's not something to worry about. It's something to be enriched and embraced. Yes, forget logic, forget reason. Instead, embrace the absurdity. So a lot of Futurist paintings have a fragmentation of form. They collapse time and space. They are trying to show dynamic motion and dizzying perspectives, but they're really kind of shattering the ordinary ways we look at the world.
- 3.74** One movement within Futurism is heroic Futurism. Look at the leaders who have done this. Here, an image of a Funeral, or here, States of Mind, meaning to reflect something going on in the mind that is formless, exciting, dynamic, but kind of indescribable. The idea here is, yes, it is heroic to be this agent of change, to be fighting, to be somebody who is breaking these barriers. In photography, too, they tried to capture motion, capture movement by using two artistic techniques, new artistic techniques, in order to show, for example, motion or the movement of fingers on a typewriter.
- 3.75** There was an attempt to reconstruct the universe in radical new ways, reconceiving what it would be like to be a teapot or a vest. There is also a celebration of mechanical arts, ways of transforming technology to present new things in the changed society. Here, Numbers in Love, for example, or here, a Speeding Motorboat, showing things that are actually technological or scientific or mechanical advances. Then the heights of the city, the cosmopolis, the skyscrapers, the new kinds of buildings that were possible as a result of technological advance.
- 3.76** There's also a fascination with aviation and especially motion, corresponding to the motion of a propeller or the motion of someone who is actually flying over a city, the motion of the skydiver plummeting toward the Earth, and in some ways, the motion of

things within a city, showing movement, showing dynamism, and in that way, revealing something about inner being. Well, the willingness of Shaw and of Futurism to embrace violence, I think, is part of the intellectual movement that actually helped to define how World War I was possible.

- 3.77** To some extent, yes, it's like we learned in the textbooks. I don't want to say, everybody read the Futurist Manifesto and became convinced this was the way to go. Not at all. But still, World War I was something that took movements of cynicism in Shaw, or a willingness to embrace violence in the Futurists, and suddenly took them from the fringes of intellectual life and put them much closer to the center. It brought the optimism of the 19th century to an abrupt end.
- 3.78** Sir Edward Grey said, "The lamps are going out all over Europe. We shall not see them lit again in our lifetimes." He recognized the fundamental change and the collapse of civilization that the advent of World War I was bringing. Paul Johnson wrote, "The 19th century saw the climax of the philosophy of personal responsibility, the notion that each of us is individually accountable for our actions, which was the joint heritage of Judeo-Christianity in the classical world."
- 3.79** There was a conception of a hero, the person who was a moral and spiritual success, who accomplished his good goals as a result of his own virtues. And that gets replaced after the war by the idea of an anti-hero, a person who has no moral compass, no concept of success, no verdicts, just wanders through life. There's a kind of moral anarchy that starts affecting the literature and the thinking in all sorts of areas after the war. It shatters that sense of progress, of faith.
- 3.80** H. G. Wells described the war as "the war that would end war." Well, he was wrong about that, but it did reverse the idea of progress. Doesn't progress itself suggest that its value as a doctrine is only relative, corresponding to a certain, not very advanced, stage of civilization? So it didn't just undermine people's faith that things would continue to progress, made them worry about the concept of progress itself.
- 3.81** Here's how Churchill described it. "All the horrors of all the ages were brought together. Not only armies, but whole populations were thrust into the midst of them. The mighty educated States involved conceived, not without reason, that their very existence was at stake. Neither peoples nor rulers drew the line at any deed which they thought could help them to win." We saw things like gas warfare for the first time. We saw bombing used for the first time. The map of Europe, there in 1908 or here after the various wars in the Balkans in 1914, was about to change radically. Lots of empires were simply to disappear.
- 3.82** Now, part of the background here is not just an intellectual matter of an increased cynicism about values and acceptance of violence. Part of it is that the political boundaries were not matching ethnic boundaries or linguistic boundaries very well throughout a lot of Europe. You take a look at Western Europe: Germany, France,

Spain, Portugal, Britain. You see people who speak a certain language and have a certain ethnicity, and it more or less corresponds to national boundaries.

- 3.83** But take a look at Eastern Europe. It's not true at all. The Austro-Hungarian Empire had dozens of different ethnicities, different languages taking place within it. That was something that led to, for one thing, all those Balkan Wars, but for another thing, a sense that that part of Europe was extremely unstable. Here is a map of Austria-Hungary as it existed at the time, with all the linguistic groups that were spoken there. That includes just the main languages—not, for example, the language of some of my ancestors, which was, I suppose you could say, a dialect of one of those languages, but nevertheless, its own distinct dialect. These were the major languages. There were lots of other little dialects that were spoken in that empire.
- 3.84** How do you hold all of that together? My great-grandmother spoke six languages. Because she was a genius? Well, more like because she was a citizen of Austria-Hungary and had to, to get along. After all, official things from the government were either in German or Hungarian, but her native language was a dialect of Serbian. Then there were all these other ethnic groups around that you had to interact with all the time.
- 3.85** This is part of the background to the assassination of the Archduke and his wife that ended up leading to the First World War. Notice that we've got a group here called the Black Hand, Serbian nationalists who were responsible for the assassination, and they were willing to use violence to achieve their ends. But also, we had the instability of the Balkans. This visit was supposed to calm things down. It did not, to put it mildly.
- 3.86** Gavrilo Princip was the assassin. He was actually the last of a group of assassins. Along the parade route, a number of people were supposed to kill the Archduke. There were six of them, and several of them chickened out. One took a grenade and threw it at the car, but the Archduke, quite large and quite athletic, leaped up and batted it away. One of his guards ended up being injured, so he went to visit the guard in the hospital. The mayor said, "Look, let's call this all off. There's already been an assassination attempt." The Archduke said, "Yeah, but it failed. What are the odds of two assassins?" And so, he insisted they'd continue it.
- 3.87** At the mayor's insistence, they changed the route, however, so that any assassins waiting along the route would be disappointed. However, at some point, the driver took a wrong turn and started crossing a bridge, realized, "Wait, I've gotten off the path," and backed up. At this point, Princip was the last of the six assassins. He thought, "Oh, well, this isn't happening today. They've changed the route, so I'll go in and have a beer." He hears a commotion outside the bar, walks out, and realizes there's the Archduke, and suddenly shoots him, and in that way starts World War I, to make a long story short.

- 3.88** Anyone who tells you about historical inevitability of social forces, be suspicious because it's a bizarre series of events that led to that outcome. In any case, well, there's the bridge. But initially, although this did make international headlines, it was also thought to be another of those Balkan things. Probably this will start another one of those series of Balkan Wars that's been taking place over the last couple of decades. Few people thought it would lead to a world war.
- 3.89** But Austria-Hungary issued the ultimatum to Serbia. They were willing to accept all but the last, which turned Serbia into a province of Austria-Hungary. So Serbia rejected it. Austria-Hungary declared war on Serbia. As a result, Russia joined Serbia, Germany joined Austria-Hungary, then France joined Russia, Britain joined France, the Ottoman Empire joined Germany, and so you quickly found Europe lined up into the Allies and the Central Powers.
- 3.90** Now, who in that group really wanted war? Maybe there were subordinates within Austria-Hungary who did, who were angry at Serbia and wanted revenge. But otherwise, none of the people thought that this would land in war. None of them wanted that. The Kaiser was racing a sailboat. It was summertime. He sought to negotiate a peace. The Serbian Prime Minister tried to be conciliatory; on the other hand, felt immensely guilty because he actually knew about the assassination plot and tried to stop it but was unable to, but hadn't told Austria-Hungary about it.
- 3.91** Russia didn't want war, but they didn't want to seem weak, so they mobilized. France, well, the Prime Minister was visiting Russia. Britain was preoccupied with Ireland's attempt for independence, and so there was an attempt by Edward Gray and others to negotiate that failed. So in the end, nobody really wanted this outcome, and yet people felt trapped into it. So in the end, those alliances emerged. Well, at that point, the war took its course.
- 3.92** I don't want to talk in detail about this, though there are lots of interesting things to be said about all of these battles. June 28th was the assassination. August 1st was the beginning of the war, so it was only a little more than a month later. Then what happened were a series of battles, major battles, on the Eastern Front. Here in the United States, we don't tend to study that aspect of the war all that much, but it was very different from the trench warfare that dominated Western Europe. It was a series of cavalry actions. It was large motions over large areas of space. It was not a matter of dug-in trench warfare at all. It's easy to tell what's going to happen in these various battles.
- 3.93** Germany always defeats Russia. Russia always defeats Austria-Hungary. And so Tannenberg, Lemberg, Masurian Lakes, all of these battles are ones that are sweeping over large areas and involve many, many deaths. But it always works out that way. Germany is stronger than Russia, that is stronger than Austria-Hungary. It's not until September that you start finding battles of a serious kind on the Western Front. In 1915, more battles, and again, bloody battles, costing countless lives. Masurian Lakes,

Dardanelles, Ypres, Gallipoli, Isonzo. The Armenian genocide then, which takes a vast number of lives within the Ottoman Empire.

- 3.94** 1916, the British evacuated Gallipoli, then Verdun, and then on July 1st, the Battle of the Somme, which I'll come back to, because I think it is the bloodiest battle of the war, but also symbolic of its impact on culture in general. 1917 saw submarine warfare, the abdication of the Tsar in the Russian Revolution, the United States declared war, more battles, French troops began to mutiny, refusing to leave the trenches. Then, finally, in 1918, peace came near the end of the year, November 11th.
- 3.95** That's a super fast summary of the war that I feel guilty about. Nevertheless, there are a couple of things I want to focus on. One is the sort of experience that people had at the Somme, but also in Verdun, or at Passchendaele, or Ypres, or any number of battles could be used here. But the Somme is the one that affected people maybe most deeply. It involved a very tiny bit of territory. All of the motion that took place by any army at the Battle of the Somme, which lasted for months, took place within a tiny region of northeastern France.
- 3.96** A German officer put it this way. "The whole history of the world cannot contain a more ghastly word, Somme." Now, why? Well, it lasted from July 1st until November. 306,000 people killed in that battle. British casualties: 420,000. 60,000 on the first day alone. Almost 100,000 dead. The French: 50,000 dead, 200,000 total casualties. The German: half a million casualties, 160,000 dead.
- 3.97** It started with the explosion of a 40,000-pound mine under the German trenches. The Allies had tunneled under No Man's Land, thought that exploding the mine would open up a huge gap in the German lines that they could then storm through. It did not work. It did cause a huge explosion, and it itself killed a lot of German soldiers. On the other hand, the Germans very quickly moved in and reinforced. It did not change the outcome of the battle at all.
- 3.98** At this point, you start seeing this radical divergence between what's really going on on the ground and the way journalists are reporting it. Fake news had been around for a very long time, famously in the Spanish-American War. But here you start seeing it systematically, in the way that people presented the war to their own populations. You can think, how did people allow this slaughter to keep going on? Well, the answer is partly because the public had no idea, and in many cases, the politicians had no idea what was really happening.
- 3.99** Here is a journalist's account of the first day at the Somme. This is a British journalist. "At about 7:30 o'clock this morning, a vigorous attack was launched by the British Army. The front extends over 20 miles north of the Somme. The assault was preceded by a terrific bombardment, lasting an hour and a half. It's too early to as yet give anything but the barest particulars as the fighting is developing in intensity, but the British troops have already occupied the German front line. Many prisoners have

already fallen into our hands, and as far as can be ascertained, our casualties have not been heavy."

- 3.100** Here is the machine gunners' account on the scene. "The next morning, July 2nd, we gunners surveyed the dreadful scene in front of us. It became clear that Germans had always had a commanding view of No Man's Land. The British attack had been brutally repulsed. Hundreds of dead were strung out like wreckage washed up on a high watermark. Quite as many died on the enemy wire as on the ground, like fish caught in the net. They hung there in grotesque postures. Some looked as if they were praying. They had died on their knees. The wire had prevented their fall. Machine gun fire had done its terrible work."
- 3.101** Sixty thousand casualties on the first day alone. So that account of the journalist was utterly outrageous. Well, as I mentioned, in the end, the Somme cost 306,000 people their lives. One writer described it as "the Great F***-Up," The largest engagement fought since the beginnings of civilization. Verdun was almost as bad: 305,000 dead. Passchendaele: 150,000 dead. Gallipoli: 130,000. Lemberg: 125,000. Frontiers: 115,000. And it goes on and on and on.
- 3.102** Take a look at that. Second Aisne, second Somme, second Marne, third Aisne, second Artois, and so on. Battles over the same territory again and again. Some of them between Austria-Hungary and Italy were some of the most damaging and costly. 11th Isonzo, 10th Isonzo, battling over the same river, the lines had never moved, and yet tens of thousands of people losing their lives at each of those battles. So the amount of death and destruction as a result of this war was simply unprecedented.
- 3.103** By the end, Germany suffered more than 2 million military deaths, about 2.5 million total deaths. Russia, looking just at the total deaths: 3.3 million. France: 1.7 million. Britain: 1.2. Austria: 1.6. Ottoman Empire: almost 3 million, although many of those were due to the Armenian genocide. Italy, Serbia, Romania, the US: 117,000. That is a lot of people to die, and yet it seems small compared to the other numbers that those European powers had suffered. In the end, 16.5 million people were killed in this war.
- 3.104** If you look at the percentage of the population killed, it's even more dramatic. Serbia: one out of six people died as a result of the war. The Ottoman Empire: one out of seven. Romania: one out of 11. France: 4%. Germany: almost 4%. Greece: the same. Italy: 3.5%, and so on. When you think most of these deaths were concentrated among military-age men, you realize they were concentrated in maybe a quarter of the population. What you're talking about here, let's say in Serbia, it's not just 16%, it's really 64% of the relevant population killed. Two out of three Serbs of fighting age died.
- 3.105** And think about the same thing in France, let's say. It's not just 4% of the population, bad as that is; it's really about one out of six fighting-age males. That is an astounding human cost. Why was it so terrible? Partly trench warfare. It turned out to be immensely costly. Partly it was new technologies: machine guns, artillery. Partly this

strategy: attack, overwhelm! That wave of soldiers got cut down by machine gun fire? We need more soldiers to go. Let's do more, more, more.

- 3.106** I think part of what inspired people, maybe, was Grant's defeat at Cold Harbor, where he was able to overwhelm the built-in trenches of the Confederate Army at the end of the American Civil War. Grant did immensely outnumber the Confederates at that point, so he could actually do it. But it's not something that was the case in these cases, partly because the trenches were so well established, but partly because neither side did vastly outnumber the other.
- 3.107** There was a lack of information, an underestimation of the enemy. The Allies had no idea how sophisticated and invulnerable the German trenches really were. There was a huge lack of communication. The British landed at the shore before the Battle of Gallipoli. They could easily have climbed the heights. Atatürk and his army were a long way away. But instead, they were waiting for orders, and so they camped out on the beach for a week. There was no communication with headquarters. Finally, headquarters said, "We'll climb up to the top and head toward Constantinople." By that point, Atatürk was there, and the result: 130,000 dead.
- 3.108** So, all of this led to, ultimately, the armistice. It was supposed to be open covenants of peace, freedom of navigation, an impartial adjustment of colonial claims, autonomy for the peoples of Austria-Hungary, and so on. Well, it turned out, that's not in the end what it was. Walter Lippmann said, "The treaty is not only illiberal and in bad faith, it's in the highest degree imprudent." John Maynard Keynes said, "They had a chance of taking a large or at least humane view of the world, but unhesitatingly refused it. It ended up being a tragic farce, seeking to lay the foundation of another war."
- 3.109** And indeed, that's what it did. The map of Europe was fundamentally changed. The Ottoman Empire no longer existed, neither did Austria-Hungary. Russia and its boundaries changed. Poland sprang into existence. But it more fundamentally led to a loss of faith, a loss of faith in political leaders, in democracy, and civilization itself. The war intensified that. So later, Philip Larkin wrote this. "Never such innocence, never before or since, has changed itself to past without a word. The men leaving the gardens tidy, the thousands of marriages lasting a little while longer. Never such innocence again."
- 3.110** "The innocent army fully attained the knowledge of good and evil at the Somme on July 1st, 1916." That sense was then reflected in the war poets. It was reflected in a German officer's reflection, *All Quiet on the Western Front*, but it was reflected in various ways that indicated the same themes. Our innocence is lost. We're no longer young. We are lost. We go home after the war, even those of us who have survived, and we've seen such horror. We don't know how to live in society anymore. We don't know how to communicate any of this to the people who are left.

- 3.111** And so, in the end, we learn not to trust anyone, not to trust our officers, not to trust our political leaders, not to trust anyone else around us who wasn't together fighting for his life. Even then, we recognized that what controlled our outcomes was not good or bad soldiering or decision-making. It was just a chance. You get blown up, I don't. There was nothing you did that made the artillery shell hit you.
- 3.112** And so, that idea of chance made people indifferent, made them think, "In the end, nothing I do, nothing I decide matters. I shouldn't trust anybody else, but I also can't trust the world, because at any point, I might be wiped out purely by chance." The people who sit in the offices and theorize this have no idea what it's really like.
- 3.113** So they all tend to think, "I've peeled back the curtain. I've seen what's really going on underneath. I've seen the horror, and I don't even know how to begin to tell you." It reshapes the way an entire generation thinks about life, thinks about the world, thinks about themselves.

Lecture 4: Disturb the Universe

At a glance — 'Disturb the universe' — T. S. Eliot and modernism.

- 4.1 "Do I dare disturb the universe?" T. S. Eliot asked in *The Love Song of J. Alfred Prufrock*. I want to talk today about two competing political ideologies that were significant, especially in the teens and '20s, but have largely shaped the contemporary scene in American politics, and really politics throughout much of the Western world ever since. It's a contrast between a conservative approach to things and a progressive approach to things. It really came to the fore just around the time of the First World War and immediately afterwards.
- 4.2 What I want to do at first is talk about progressivism, especially in the presidency of Woodrow Wilson. It represents a fundamental shift in ideas about how society should be organized. It moreover reflects the distinction I've been talking about between realist and idealist approaches to the ought, the question of normativity in general, but specifically to the question of how we should live together.
- 4.3 The realist, to remind you, says some truths are independent of mind, of what people think. But the idealist says, no, everything is mind-dependent. There are no mind-independent facts. Everything is really shaped by our own perceptual faculties, our own cognitive faculties, by the way we think about things. Whatever's true for each individual person is also true at the collective level when we, as a society, are trying to decide how to govern ourselves. So, it becomes a question of: Is there a mind-independent truth? Is there something outside of us that we have to live up to, or can we assign meaning and value however we like? Are we free to organize ourselves however we want, or are we answerable to something else? Do we live in the world of the unread book?
- 4.4 This corresponds roughly to two models of how to think about politics. One comes from John Locke. It's a bottom-up model. The idea is that some rights that people have are natural rights. They're independent of government. Typically, it's a right to life, health, liberty, and property that is yours just by virtue of being a human being. It's not a matter of being a citizen of this or that country. They're just yours. Even apart from any political organization, it would be wrong to murder people, it would be wrong to rob them, it would be wrong to enslave them.
- 4.5 And so the government derives its power from the rights that people already have. Those rights people agree to consign the enforcement of, at least of some of them, to the government, so that the rest can be better protected. And according to this conception, rights are general rights. They're rights that other people not interfere with me. So my right to life is not one that requires you to do things to keep me alive. It's simply one that says you can't kill me. The same thing with my right to property. You

don't have to give me property, but you do have to respect my right to the property I have and not rob me, for example, or steal from me.

- 4.6 There's an alternative conception, which is a top-down model. This is one that's much more naturally fitted to an idealist approach to politics, where we start with a conception of how things ought to be. This comes from Jean-Jacques Rousseau and a series of followers of Rousseau. The idea here is that we don't really have any natural rights, rights that are inherent in us as human beings. Instead, all rights are really civil rights. They derive from the government.
- 4.7 So, instead of saying government gets its powers from the consent of the governed, as the bottom-up person thinks, this says no, government starts out with all the power and then assigns certain rights to individual people. So, the rights of individual people derive from the government. Rights in this sense might be rights to non-interference: you must not kill me, you must not rob me. But they could also be positive. It could be that other people have to do things for me and have obligations to me, giving me certain entitlements. That's a part of the picture on the bottom-up conception that isn't really there, or could be derived only by the consent of the governed.
- 4.8 Now, those two models, a top-down model and a bottom-up model, I think have tended to dominate much of politics really throughout the last century and a half, at least. But also, there's another fact about, at least American politics, that I think is really remarkable. Every election in the past 30 years has fit an L-shaped pattern. Democrats tend to be strong in the Northeast and on the West Coast, and Republicans in the Mountain states and then in the South. If you start looking at American history, you realize that the general pattern goes back all the way to the beginnings of the Republic. Really, only around the time of the Civil War does a North-South split take over and become dominant.
- 4.9 Here, for example, is the map that indicates the results of the 2024 election. You can see, I mean, it's vague, but you can see a big fat L there. Here's the 2016 election— not too different, 2012 and then 2008. Roughly speaking, when the Democrats win, it becomes a narrower and wholly L. Then when the Republicans win, it's a fatter L. But in any case, it looks very much the same. There are only a few swing states. We can keep going back: 2004, 2000, 1996. You see a similar type of pattern, 1992, and so on. It goes, as I say, all the way back to the very earliest days.
- 4.10 Here, I think, is the idea: one party tends to represent urban interests. It's strong in the more urbanized areas, the big cities, and so creditors, finance, big business, industry, the rich, but also the poor, tend to favor that particular political party. And the other tends to represent the countryside, the more rural areas. So debtors, agriculture, small business, small towns, in many ways, the middle class.
- 4.11 Here's the weird thing in terms of that sociological observation about who the parties represent: at some point in the 20th century, the parties switched places. Take a look

at the 1896 map, William Jennings Bryan versus William McKinley. McKinley won, and it looks a pretty big fat L in that case. But notice, it's the opposite result, partly because Arizona and New Mexico and Oklahoma weren't yet states at that time. But in 1900, you see—well, sometimes it's in 1904, you see the North-South pattern predominate. In 1908, you see the fragments of that L, and yet the parties are in the opposite places.

- 4.12** When we look at 1912, we suddenly see a map that looks confusing. Why? Partly because there was a split among the Republican candidates. The Republicans nominated William Taft. But Teddy Roosevelt wanted the nomination. Not getting it, he decided to form a third party: the Bull Moose Party. So he ran as the Bull Moose candidate. Well, the result of that is splitting the Republican vote. So Wilson won the 1912 election with only 42% of the vote.
- 4.13** So, here you look at this, and you see that only a few states won by Roosevelt, only a few states won by Taft. The vast majority of the country was won by Wilson, and yet with a minority of the vote. If you look at it county by county, it's also confusing. So, there was something about the 1912 election that really broke this pattern, and was the beginning, I think, of the shift that I've mentioned that probably wasn't completed until around 1960.
- 4.14** Take a look at the results in 1916. Wilson then won over Hughes, and it was, again, a big fat L. That became clearer when the Republican vote wasn't being split. But now watch this. There's the 2004 map; here's the 1916 map. It's almost like they're the same map with only a few states remaining the same. Otherwise, it just switches colors. It's as if the parties completely switched places. What on earth happened?
- 4.15** Here, I think, is one way of understanding. In the 19th century, all of the parties, really, the Whigs, the Federalists, the Republicans, the Democrats, were all really sharing that bottom-up conception from John Locke. So they all thought people have natural rights, and the government gets its powers from the consent of the governed, as people agree to limit some of their rights in order to have the rest better protected. So they believed in natural individual rights. They differed only on how much power people would give to the government.
- 4.16** So some would say, "We're going to retain most of these ourselves. We want a very limited government." Others would say, "No, we can consent to a much more active government." But nevertheless, it was all happening within the confines of that bottom-up model. The Republican idea, which went all the way back, at least to Henry Clay, but really, in some sense, back to the Federalists at the beginning of the Republic, said, "Government exists to develop and protect a framework of liberty." So what did this involve?
- 4.17** Basically, you might say building the infrastructure for liberty, allowing people to do what they wanted and pursue their own conceptions of the good to a large extent, but

nevertheless providing the things that would be common pool resources or common goods that people could use to actually exercise their liberty.

- 4.18** So, for example, here were things that Republicans tended to favor: a federalized bank, a bank of the United States, infrastructure like building transportation, roads, canals, and so on, bridges, and then tariffs, which became the main issue in elections in the late 19th century and have reemerged as an issue now. Why was all this done? To say that here is a general way of building out the infrastructure that people can then use to develop their own conceptions of the good.
- 4.19** The Democratic Party throughout the 19th century was actually a libertarian party. It thought that gave the federal government way too much power. And so instead, it championed free trade and low taxes, hard money, and a minimal government, a strict interpretation of the Constitution, leaving most power in the hands of individual people in the states.
- 4.20** When I point that out, it seems striking at first, right? You don't tend to think of the Democrats as basically libertarians, but in the 19th century, they were. But in the 20th century, things had changed dramatically. The Democratic Party opposed that Republican idea as giving the federal government way too little power. It tended to champion, in at least most of the 20th century, protectionism and high taxes, soft money—so inflating the currency, making more money available to more people—and then a pretty extensive government, corresponding to a looser interpretation of the Constitution, much talk of a living Constitution that would be reinterpreted as conditions changed. How did that happen?
- 4.21** The Republican idea really didn't change much throughout that entire time. I think Republicans today actually have a platform that's not too different from the Republicans of, say, well, 1860. But on the other hand, the Democratic Party is really different. So how did it happen?
- 4.22** In 1896, and again in 1900, William Jennings Bryan ran for the presidency on a platform of easy-money populism, class conflict, and then, he ran again in 1908, added an income tax, and then later, Prohibition and the war on drugs. He was a Democrat, but obviously, departed radically from the general pattern of democratic politicians in the 19th century. Not in every respect, the idea of making money more available was something that was a democratic idea, especially in the context of the 20th century. But still, that, at least, he had in common with the Democrats of the 19th century. To some extent, it was also true with populism and class conflict.
- 4.23** But his specific prescriptions, even if his diagnosis was similar to that of Democrats throughout the 19th century, the prescription, what he wanted to do, was very different. There was an idea at the time that he was swallowing up the Democratic Party and changing it fundamentally. Here is a political cartoon that illustrates that.

Bryan, there, pictured as swallowing up the donkey entirely and transforming it into a different political party. Why did it happen and how?

- 4.24 The 19th-century Democratic Party thought it was very important to decentralize power. The central idea was, "It is dangerous to have too much power, economic power or political power, in the hands of one person or a small number of people. We want lots of money in different places. So, beware of people who become too wealthy, and also beware of any form of government that becomes too powerful."
- 4.25 That was why they championed a relatively weak federal government and stronger state governments, and even stronger local governments, because the idea was you want as many power centers as possible to compete with each other, and to some extent, to limit one another's powers. And so they wanted decentralization, and they thought the best way to achieve that was really just sit back and let things happen, don't actually have a strong central authority.
- 4.26 But Democrats began to suspect that that was the wrong approach due to one factor: the rise of the corporation. I've talked about the Agricultural Revolution and then the Industrial Revolutions that ended up producing mass culture, mass communication, department stores, and national product brands. That led to the rise of the national and, finally, the international corporation. That, Democrats began to worry, was concentrating, at least initially, economic power in the hands of a few people.
- 4.27 By 1932, Roosevelt was saying in his speeches for the campaign that within a few years, only a handful of people would control almost all of the money in the United States and have almost all of the economic power of that tremendous concentrated wealth. Progressives became convinced, increasingly, that economic power was centralizing, that the same economic forces that had been leading in the 19th century to a naturally decentralized situation, which makes sense in a largely agricultural society, was becoming concentrated due to industrialization, and that that was a really dangerous situation. What was the idea? How do you combat the rise of the corporation and the power of a few industrialists, the so-called robber barons of the late 19th century and early 20th century?
- 4.28 The thought was this: you need to centralize political power in the hands of the federal government and use it against these national corporations. It was one thing when companies were largely limited to a certain area, and the people selling this product in one part of the country were different from those selling it in another part of the country and so on. The companies were small. You could let local and state governments handle any issues that arose there. But now that you've got national or even international corporations, that won't work anymore. You need, instead, a strong centralized authority.
- 4.29 So, Bryan's idea was that the federal government needs to be stronger, not only stronger than Democrats throughout the 19th century had thought, but stronger than

the Republicans wanted it to be. It had to be using this power against corporations and against the people who had accumulated so much wealth.

- 4.30 Now, what is progressivism really as an idea? It isn't just a label. It is instead really a political ideology. The idea is, to some extent, like socialism, you want centralized conscious direction of social forces, at least some of them. But on the other hand, it's not really necessarily toward a consciously defined end. It's instead to promote progress as that gets defined, and that is open to interpretation, but then countering the concentration of economic power.
- 4.31 It isn't exactly, "Let's choose a goal and then find ways to achieve that goal," as the socialist wants. It's a way of saying that the way things are operating naturally is concentrating power in too few hands. So, we need to step in with a strong central authority that will consciously take away that power and give it back to a variety of people who then can actually pursue their own ends.
- 4.32 So, it would be far too simple and a mistake to say that progressivism is a form of socialism; it's not. But it does believe in centralization, and it does believe in the conscious direction of social forces. It's just that it's in order to decentralize and allow people to pursue different ends. It's a way of saying we need a powerful central authority, but its goal shouldn't be something that it chooses and pursues independently of what people want. Instead, it's a matter of returning power.
- 4.33 This does lead to a certain puzzle, and it's a puzzle the political theorists throughout the 20th century have thought a lot about, whether they like the progressive idea or not. Here's the problem: if we're worried about centralization due to the rise of the corporation, and then we centralize political power to fight that, what guarantees that it will fight it?
- 4.34 First of all, if centralization is dangerous, promoting more seems scary. Why won't it have an analogous problem? But there's an even worse problem because government has, in a way, more power than any corporation. After all, it can coerce you. If you don't like what a corporation is doing, you can stop buying its products. But if you don't like what the government is doing, you'd have to leave the country. You can't just say, "I'm not paying taxes anymore. I think I'll just mount my own national defense," or something of that sort. You can't really do it. In that sense, it's less accountable than a corporation. It seems to have more power. As Hayek later said, it really becomes the most powerful monopolist conceivable.
- 4.35 First of all, why isn't that centralization dangerous in the way the centralization of economic power is dangerous? But also, if that's the way we think about things, what keeps the government power as a tool for fighting the corporate power? What if they get together? It's as if you have a class bully and you decide, "I don't like that class bully. I need somebody even stronger." So you manage to recruit a bully who's also

strong. "Okay, great. He'll fight that bully." That's your idea. But what if the bullies team up? Now you got two of them working against you. What stops that from happening?

- 4.36 That's something that, as the century went on, people thought more and more about because initially, these agencies that were set up to exercise federal authority to control corporations seemed to be doing that quite well. But at a certain point, people began to worry: What if they're working together? It seemed increasingly as if they were.
- 4.37 Initially, progressives thought, "How are we going to do this? First of all, we're going to try to break up trust, break up monopolies. Take some of these large corporations and split them apart." That's what happened to Standard Oil, for example. It was done with a number of other corporations, including much later, AT&T, which was split up into various kinds of things. So, there was that attempt to decentralize economic power.
- 4.38 In 1914, the government created the Federal Trade Commission and passed the Clayton Antitrust Act to try to make that a general policy. But it is a little bit worrisome. As I mentioned, you might be concerned that Hayek turns out to be right. We've now created a very powerful monopolist, and what if it just adds to the power of the corporations?
- 4.39 Political scientists refer to this as the problem of regulatory capture. Why won't the government and corporations stand together against everybody else? Why don't the two bullies, instead of fighting each other, get together and fight the rest of us? Well, it's not a trivial problem. People have talked a lot about an iron triangle between congressional committees, for example, that are supposed to regulate, special interest groups, corporations or other nonprofit organizations, for that matter, and the bureaucracy. There's a worry that really the same people float between all of these, that there's a revolving door of personnel.
- 4.40 So, somebody is hired for the bureaucracy to regulate a certain set of companies. Why? Because they've served in those companies. They have expertise in that particular area. Then maybe they decide to run for Congress, and they do. The congressional person is there overseeing the committee, regulating blah, blah, blah. At a certain point, they lose an election or they decide not to run. What happens? Well, they may well get hired by that industry and so on. The same people float between all of these different groups.
- 4.41 What it means is these interest groups, whether they're corporate or rather some other interest group that's interested in this question, tend to know the people in the bureaucracy, they tend to know the people on the congressional committees, and in short, there's a huge amount of interaction between the people in this iron triangle.
- 4.42 Notice who isn't there. We've got interest groups, whether corporate or otherwise. We've got the bureaucracy. We've got Congress. Where are you? Where am I? We're missing from that picture. You might worry then that they team up and actually scratch

each other's backs while the rest of us find, "Wait, you were supposed to be limiting each other." Now, I think sometimes this works, sometimes it doesn't work. But the problem from the point of view of political science, is how do we keep that from happening? That's what I've referred to as the paradox of progressivism. Maybe it'd be better to say it's simply a problem of progressivism. How do we solve that?

- 4.43 It seems as if the same forces that would lead us to say that we need these regulatory bodies to actually keep watch on the corporations are going to encourage cooperation among them, which will be dangerous and actually work against the public interest. So, in any case, that's a problem that I think remains to be solved. It's one that political scientists really don't have a clear answer to. It's not necessarily, as I say, fatal. It may be that in lots of cases this works well, but there is a tendency for the overlap between these various groups and the cooperation among them to become strong enough that it doesn't work at all.
- 4.44 Let's return to that watershed election of 1912. The Democratic Party jumped from being to the right, informally speaking, of the Republican Party to the left of the Republican Party. Again, Wilson was elected with only 42% of the vote. It was ironic because Wilson campaigned against Roosevelt's so-called New Nationalism. But on the other hand, he implemented many of the same policies that Roosevelt was advocating, and he argued in his speeches for a New Freedom. I want to talk some about that Wilsonian idea, much of it overlapping Roosevelt's ideas, but not entirely.
- 4.45 Wilson had this conception that we had misunderstood freedom, and we needed to come up with a new understanding of it. Here's one way of thinking about it as a form of romanticism, almost. We've said that an idea from the Enlightenment is that reason is the best path. It's the best path to truth, the best path to progress. We can know some things about the world, and we can know them objectively. Reason is the best way to do it.
- 4.46 But this idea that comes out of the idealist tradition in the 19th century, and especially from the German philosopher, Hegel, says that it's actually emotion, feeling, that is the best path. Why? Because it's the key to discovering what he referred to as the spirit of the age. Remember, I said that he wrote a great book called *The Phenomenology of Spirit*? The idea is that each age has a spirit, and the history of the world consists in this spirit working itself out according to these generally rational principles.
- 4.47 Well, then, what you have to do to get things right is to grasp the spirit of the age. How can you do that? By reason? Maybe. But the best path is actually that you feel it. You're part of the age, and you get the sense of this spirit. You have it within you. Wilson is an advocate of this idea. He thinks there is a spirit of the age, in fact, a new spirit of the age, and you have to grasp what that is. He thinks it involves radical change. So he says there's an old spirit that the country was founded with, but that spirit is gone. Now, things have developed to the point where there's a new spirit of the age, and it forces us to reject the past.

- 4.48 So here's how Wilson put it. We're in the presence of a new organization of society. Our life has broken away from the past. The life of America is not the life it was 20 years ago. It's not the life it was 10 years ago. We've changed our economic conditions absolutely from top to bottom, and with our economic society, the organization of our life. The old political formulas do not fit the present problems. They read now like documents taken out of a forgotten age.
- 4.49 What is he talking about, these old formulas, these old documents? The Declaration of Independence, the Constitution. He had written a book on the Constitution. In fact, as a scholar. He was a scholar of the Constitution. But now he's saying that those documents are out of a forgotten age. We're in a new social age. It is nothing short of a new era of human relationships, a new stage setting for the drama of life.
- 4.50 Why? Because of cities, because of the rise of corporations, because of transportation, communication. All of those things mean that we're not a bunch of isolated communities banded together through consent. Instead, we're really becoming one integrated society. We thought that required a new set of rules. Wilson says, "We're in a temper to reconstruct economic society as we were once in a temper to reconstruct political society. Political society may itself undergo a radical modification in the process."
- 4.51 What does this mean exactly? He talks about his days as President of Princeton University. He says, "In those days, I wanted to make the young gentleman of the rising generation as unlike their fathers as possible. Not because they lack character or intelligence or knowledge or patriotism, but because their fathers were out of sympathy with the creative, formative, and progressive forces of society." It's that idea, again, of the spirit of the age. The spirit of the age, he says, is creative, it's formative, it's finding new ways of organizing things. We've got a new organization of society through mass communication, mass transportation, and so we now have to recognize there's a new spirit. People have to become as unlike their fathers, as unlike their grandparents as possible. They have to fit this new age.
- 4.52 Here are some of the things that he thought followed from this. First of all, he uses this biological metaphor. "The state is organic." It's like one organism. He thinks the Declaration and the Constitution are based on this mechanical idea, and he thinks that the state is like an organism. The parts have to work together. Then, he believes that an individual has value only in the context of the state, just as a hand has value only because it's a part of the body.
- 4.53 Then, what is liberty? Well, what is liberty of a hand? It's its ability to coordinate with the state. In fact, if my hand, if let's say I lost control of it and it started doing weird things apart from my will, I would say, I've lost freedom to move my hand. And so freedom is coordination with the rest. It turns out, then, everything becomes political. Everything is possibly a subject of government activity. And then the most shocking claim: "The state can do no wrong." Why? Because the state is the embodiment of the

spirit of the age, and the spirit of the age defines what's right. So if the state embodies it, the state has to be right.

- 4.54 Let's take a look at each of these. First of all, the organic metaphor. Now, his opponents tend to think of society as something like an ecosystem. Okay, and various people compete within that. But there is a general evolution of society to make it better and better. That leads to progress. But Hegel had this idea that society is like one organism; all the parts have to work together. Wilson agrees with that. He says that the government is not a machine, but a living thing. And notice, he says, "a living thing," not an environment for living things or an ecosystem filled with living things, but instead "one living thing."
- 4.55 What that means is he thinks that, as Hegel put it, all worth the human being has, all spiritual reality, he has only through the state. Wilson actually agrees with that. He uses the image of a beehive. He says that in these great beehives— he's talking about cities—in which every quarter swarms with men of flesh and blood, it's a privilege of the government, whether of the state or of the United States, as the case may be, to see that human life is protected, that human lungs have something to breathe. He's thinking about human society as a beehive.
- 4.56 Then, there's this old idea of thinking about human beings as bees. Mandeville had written something called *The Fable of the Bees*, and his idea was private vice is public virtue. In other words, as long as the bees do their thing, the hive works well. But if the bees start changing and trying to act in a different way, they mess up the hive. The thought is that the bees each have a task. Mostly, they're just looking after their own benefit and doing their own jobs. That makes the hive work. If all the bees start saying, "Oh, I've got to look out for the welfare of the hive," all of a sudden the bees don't know what to do when it falls apart.
- 4.57 But that is the opposite of Wilson's idea. I think part of the reason he goes to the beehive here is to say, I disagree with Mandeville. No, the bees need to worry about the success of the hive. The bee actually has value only as part of the beehive. So he says, "No living thing can have its organs offset against each other. On the contrary, life depends on their quick cooperation, their ready response to commands of instinct or intelligence, their amicable community of purpose." The same thing has to apply in a society. So he says, "There will be a family in a great building whose noble architecture will at last be disclosed, where men can live as a single community, cooperative as in a perfectly coordinated beehive."
- 4.58 You might think, that's not much of a conception of liberty, but he's okay with that. He ends up saying, "What is liberty? I've long had an image in my mind of what constitutes liberty. Suppose I'm building a great piece of powerful machinery, and I awkwardly and unskillfully assemble the parts. Well, when one part tries to move, it's interfered with by the others. It would all buckle up and be checked." He says, "Liberty for the several parts would consist in the best possible assembling and adjustment of them all, would

it not?" The same thing applies in society. "Human freedom consists in perfect adjustments of human interests, and human activities and human energies." It's a matter of us being adjusted to one another.

- 4.59 This idea in German is referred to as Gleichschaltung: coordination, bringing into line, alignment. It's a mechanical engineering term for adjustment and alignment. But what it tends to mean is that everybody has to accept the same worldview. Everybody has to be coordinated. Everybody has to be committed to the success of the whole and to cooperation with everyone else. That requires a certain commonality of thought. You can already see that a commitment to this idea is going to threaten things like freedom of speech and freedom of thought, because after all, we don't want people working in different directions. Everybody has to cooperate. Everybody has to be adjusted to everyone else.
- 4.60 That leads us then to think, wait a minute. We can't allow these private spheres of activity where you're doing your own thing. We need coordination. If some bee decides, "You know what? I'm bored with this honey thing. I'm going to go off and do something else. I want to produce music," or something. We can't allow that. That is going to threaten the success of the hive. There is no limit in principle to government power. In the end, everybody has to pitch in and not do their own thing in some sphere of liberty, but instead work toward the good of the whole.
- 4.61 That requires us to reinterpret certain things in the American founding that guarantee people those spheres of liberty, getting rid of constitutional guarantees, checks and balances, and limits on government power. In fact, most of what he's talking about with this mechanical idea of one part interfering with another is to say that we don't want checks and balances. We don't want opposing power centers. We want everything to be coordinated within one.
- 4.62 So he champions the living constitution, which means an ability to reinterpret it to fit current needs. So he says the time has come for the governments of this country to do justice to men in every relationship of life. There is no limit in principle. Every relationship is subject to government authority. And so he envisions a time when every part of life will be sustained or at least supplemented by government activity.
- 4.63 Finally, there's the idea that if the government is embodying the spirit of the age, it can do no wrong. And indeed, he goes along with that. He says, "I cannot imagine power as a thing negative and not positive." He doesn't just mean, it's a good thing for a person to be powerful—good for that person, at least. He means, "No, I cannot imagine government power being negative as opposed to positive."
- 4.64 What about things like inalienable rights? The right to life, health, liberty, and property, for example, or the right to life, liberty, and the pursuit of happiness, say. "Nonsense. Mere vague sentiment." He rejects individualism. He rejects natural rights, individual

rights, and any conception like that that comes out of the Declaration of Independence or the Constitution.

- 4.65** What are the consequences of this in practice? Some of them were new amendments. The 16th Amendment allowed Congress to impose an income tax. Initially, "Don't worry about it. Most people won't pay any income tax. The top rate, even if you're a multimillionaire, will be only 7%." Five years later, the top rate was 77%, and the average person was paying about a quarter of their income in income taxes. It changed very quickly.
- 4.66** The 17th Amendment provided for the direct election of senators by popular vote. Before that, senators had been chosen by state legislators. What did this do? It was a massive shift of power from the states to the federal government and from rural to urban areas. Why? Because before that, senators came out of state legislatures. They were people who had built up alliances within their state through political activity over a long period of time. Typically, they were senior diplomats, senior statesmen. But all of a sudden it became popular for people due to just popularity to win seats in the Senate. It changed the nature of the people being elected to the Senate. The 18th Amendment prohibited the manufacture or sale of alcohol. And so that began Prohibition. And then the 19th Amendment gave women the right to vote.
- 4.67** That was part of the progressive platform. But Wilson had things that weren't really part of progressivism, but were part of his own way of capturing what he saw as the spirit of the age. One of them was racial division. He was a big fan of the Ku Klux Klan, and in fact showed *The Birth of a Nation*, the movie, a very early movie that actually championed the cause of the Klan, in the White House. He segregated the federal government, including the military. He promoted eugenics. The result of that: race riots, lynchings all over the country, a huge amount of turbulence. A thousand troops ordered out in Chicago. Race riots spread, 27 dead, 244 injured, 300 hurt in Washington race riots, and so on.
- 4.68** He had a policy of military intervention in Latin America. After all, the government can do no wrong, so it can help other countries as well as its own. There were interventions in the Dominican Republic, Mexico, Haiti, Cuba, Panama, Honduras, Nicaragua. He restricted liberty. The first military draft for the First World War since the Civil War,
- 4.69** He championed the Espionage Act of 1917 and the Sedition Act of 1918. What did they do? They were passed by Congress over Republican objections, but they forbade interfering with the war effort, opposing the war or the draft. So if you said, "Down with the war," or "Down with the draft," you could be arrested, for that matter, for any disloyal, profane, scurrilous or abusive language against the United States.
- 4.70** Over 400 periodicals lost mailing privileges. There were more than a thousand convictions of people for saying things that were opposed to the draft or opposed to the American involvement in World War I, or for that matter, just seemed to criticize

the government. E. E. Cummings, the famous poet who would not use anything but lowercase letters, said in Europe that he didn't hate Germans, and as a result of that, he spent three and a half months in jail. These were astounding limitations on liberty.

4.71 There was a War Industries Board, an industrial dictatorship without parallel, said one historian, as well as a Committee on Public Information that had a propaganda effort to try to get people to support the war and to support the Wilson administration. The leader of that said, "Truth and falsehood are arbitrary terms. They're lifeless truths and vital lies. It matters very little if an idea is true or false."

4.72 Among those kinds of things were also things that continue to have a very powerful effect today: the creation of the Federal Reserve System, the Income Tax, the Anti-Trust Act, the Federal Trade Commission, and in general, the rise of the administrative state, all of these various alphabet agencies that represent bureaucracies that regulate various aspects of economic activity and other kinds of activities.

4.73 No one knows these days how many such federal agencies there are. One guess is 316. Other people say, no, it's 423. It depends on how you define an agency as opposed to a board, as opposed to a commission, etc. But in any event, there are a lot of them governing a huge number of areas of human life. It seems rather ironic that progressives wanted to give power back to the people and instead created this huge administrative state that gradually became largely unaccountable.

4.74 Finally, the war did end. You might think, "Great, things got back to normal after the First World War." Well, not so easy. First of all, throughout the entire world, really, there were epidemics, hunger, continued fighting. There was a huge economic recession throughout much of the world, all sorts of labor disputes, strikes, race riots, and then a series of anarchist bombings.

4.75 First came the Spanish flu. Between January of 1918 and December of 1920, so lasting for three full years. The Spanish flu ravaged populations, between 20 and 50 million dead. It might have been as much as 3% of the world population. Moreover, the Spanish flu, overwhelming health systems in virtually every country, was in some ways worse than more recent epidemics that we're all familiar with. Why? Because those affected mostly the elderly. The Spanish flu affected mostly the young. The hypothesis is that there had been a flu a few decades before that helped to immunize older people against this. So it was primarily hitting people in their teens, and 20s, and 30s. So the deaths were concentrated among younger people, which meant more life years were being lost.

4.76 Prohibition took effect, depressing everyone. There were anarchist mail bombings, as I mentioned, race riots throughout the country. The Red Scare, so-called, where the Wilson administration cracked down on critics. And so 14,000 leftists, socialists, and so on were held without charge. Some were deported. There were strikes in Seattle,

Boston, and Pittsburgh. In the end, the country seemed out of control. President Wilson himself had a stroke in October.

- 4.77** You can see here, bomb explosions in eight Eastern cities. Eventually, they were traced to a group of anarcho-communists, essentially. Finally, that was part of this—that group wanted to get rid of tyranny, but it was otherwise unclear exactly what the goals were. The strike? Well, 20% of the nation's labor force went on strike. One out of five workers was on strike due to various things. That really disrupted the economic recovery that otherwise might have been expected from the war.
- 4.78** The result of that was an overwhelming victory. Warren G. Harding, the Republican candidate, defeated Cox, the Democratic candidate, in the election of 1920 by the strongest margin of victory ever in the United States. And there you see it. It's about a 27% margin between Harding and Cox. Interesting, since that was the first election in which women voted.
- 4.79** What was his platform? It really was to get back to normal. He said, "America's present need isn't heroics, but healing; not nostrums, but normalcy; not revolution, but restoration; not surgery, but security." Let's get back to normal. Let's stop all these disruptions. The war is over. Let's get back to the way things used to be.
- 4.80** He inherited a severe economic recession. The country was in turmoil, torn apart by strikes, and his response was to practice laissez-faire economics. In other words, don't interfere. Back off. He cut government spending by 40%. So he did the opposite of what a progressive would be inclined to do, undoing some of the policies of the Wilson administration. The result of that was that the economy boomed. He also freed all of those political prisoners that Wilson had imprisoned as a result of the Red Scare.
- 4.81** Things seemed to be going extremely well. He was enormously popular until 1923, and the advent of the Teapot Dome scandal. What happened? His Secretary of the Interior, Albert Fall, accepted \$400,000 for favorable leases on government land. That sounds to us like a small amount of money. On the other hand, inflation means that was worth millions, probably tens of millions in today's currency. Nevertheless, there was no suggestion that Harding himself knew about this. It created an image that his administration was highly corrupt. But I don't think that was in general true. In any event, here is Albert Fall.
- 4.82** When Harding found out about this, he called Fall into his office, grabbed him by the collar, shook him and said, "What have you done to me, man?" The result of that is that Harding really felt shattered, felt betrayed not only by this person he had trusted, but also knew that this was devastating to his own administration and ended up feeling lost. It's as if the spirit of the man had just been crushed by that betrayal. Not long after that, Harding suffered a stroke and died suddenly.
- 4.83** Calvin Coolidge, his vice president, became president. Coolidge was himself an odd choice for a politician. He was a Vermont farmer who was fond of reading classic

literature in the original Greek and Latin in the White House. He was not somebody who was a typical politician at all. He ended up getting into office, though, and saying the chief business of the American people is business, economy is idealism in its most practical form. And so he thought of the government's role, very similar to those 19th-century ideas, as providing the framework within which people can seize opportunities, but not otherwise trying to direct things.

- 4.84 Part of what motivated him is what we now consider the law of unintended consequences. He thought, typically, when you act, and it's especially true if you act on a large scale as the government does, the unintended consequences usually turn out to matter more than the intended consequences. You enact a certain policy trying to achieve that goal, and it may or may not do that, but it's going to have all sorts of other effects that you're not thinking about. Those usually end up being far more consequential than the effects you actually anticipate.
- 4.85 Notice, once you think about this, how often in a newspaper report or some other bit of news, you find the word "unexpectedly"? Coolidge is basically saying, yeah, that happens all the time. It's often the case that you enact something and then, unexpectedly, certain things happen. Now, sometimes, really, everyone was expecting them. It's just that they didn't want it to happen. But other times, it's really because, yes, there are all sorts of effects, secondary effects of this that people don't anticipate. Change people's incentives, and they start behaving differently, and you get effects that you were not anticipating.
- 4.86 In any case, he thought, often those turn out to be bad. So government activity, even if it achieves the positive goals, often has a lot of negative consequences that nobody thought about. So he said, there's far more danger of harm than there is hope of good in any radical changes. We do best by changing things gradually, trying to finetune adjustments, get things a little better in this respect or in that respect, but being very wary of doing the change that could produce unanticipated consequences.
- 4.87 He also thought that we all have a natural desire for freedom. We have an unconquerable desire to be masters of our own destiny. So, tell people what to do, and even if it's what they would have done anyway, they're far less happy than if they get to choose it themselves. If somebody had a crystal ball and said, "Here's the job you will eventually have, and you will enjoy it. So, we're now going to force you into that job." You would be much less happy there than if you had chosen it. So his idea is that desire for liberty, not as perfect adjustment with everyone else, but instead following your own dream, being your own master. That, he says, is what people really value.
- 4.88 So go back to the Declaration of Independence and that guarantee of inalienable rights, rights to life, liberty in the pursuit of happiness, those really are fundamental. And so he gave a speech on the anniversary of the Declaration saying, remember what that document said. "We hold these truths to be self-evident, that all men are created equal, that they're endowed with certain unalienable rights, and that therefore the

source of the just powers of government must be derived from the consent of the government."

- 4.89 He says, about that Declaration, "There's a finality that's exceedingly restful. It's often asserted that the world has made great progress since 1776, that we've had new thoughts and new experiences which have given us a great advance over the people of that day, and that we may, therefore, very well discard their conclusions for something more modern." He has in mind Wilson here. "But that reasoning cannot be applied to this great charter. If all men are created equal, that is final. If they are endowed with unalienable rights, that is final. If governments derive their just powers from the consent of the governed, that is final. No advance, no progress can be made beyond these propositions.
- 4.90 If anybody wants to deny their truth or their soundness, they can't go forward. They're not progressing. Instead, they're going backward, backward to a time when there was no equality, no rights of the individual, no rule of the people. Those who wish to proceed in that direction shouldn't really claim to progress. They're reactionary. Their ideas aren't more modern but more ancient than those of the revolutionary fathers."
- 4.91 The thought is that these people who are saying that no, no, no, it's a matter of perfect adjustments, discard these unalienable rights to life, liberty in the pursuit of happiness, they want to take us back a time when we weren't guaranteed equality, when we weren't guaranteed individual rights, back toward feudalism, back toward monarchy, back toward other forms of government. There's no way forward from that. Those things are the goal. That's what we want.
- 4.92 In any event, he implemented that. He tried to keep government as small as possible. He was notably taciturn, in fact, famously so, unwilling to speak. There's a joke that a man came in to meet him together with his wife at some White House function and said to the President when he met him, "I bet my wife that I could get you to say at least three words to me." Coolidge's response was, "You lose."
- 4.93 He really was somebody who said at one point, "Here's my job as president. People come into my office and they ask me for things. They're generally things they don't deserve and shouldn't have. What I do, I just sit there. I let them talk. I don't say anything, and eventually they go away." That was his idea of government. It sounds like a rather minimal and inactive role of government, but still, there was a remarkably rapid recovery after the war and all the lives lost there, the huge economic disruptions after the Spanish flu epidemic. Still, the bounce back was incredible, both in health and in prosperity.
- 4.94 It's incredible how, as a result of Harding's and then Coolidge's policy, things changed very rapidly and in positive directions: the strikes ended, the economy boomed, unemployment fell dramatically, things seemed very good. The result of that: the jazz age, the Roaring Twenties, huge social changes. André Siegfried put it this way: "As a

result of the revolutionary changes brought about by modern methods of production,"—basically mass production, factories— "the American people are now creating on a vast scale an entirely original social structure."

- 4.95 And so you get a new attitude, new fashion, new ways of behaving in society. Their 1920s swimsuits, in the ads, look bizarre, but actually, when you see what people were actually wearing, they look pretty modern. Here, Coolidge is standing next to his new motor car, thrilled by that, and all sorts of people began to be able to afford a car for the first time during the '20s. The advent of aviation. Now, Kitty Hawk had happened in 1903, and there were airplanes in World War I, but commercial air travel, available to a person who was not a member of the military, really started happening in the 1920s.
- 4.96 Then the telephone became much more widespread. And radio, radio was a new thing. The very first radio station, KDKA in Pittsburgh in 1921. Radio very quickly began to spread throughout the United States. The advent of the typewriter. I remember my grandparents' typewriter. It was a big thing in those days because that was new. You mean you didn't have to write out everything by hand? And then the rise of not only department stores, but shopping districts, areas where people were engaged in large amounts of activity. And then mass transportation in trolleys, or bus routes, or trains. Theaters became commonplace for the first time. Movies were an oddity before this, but in the 1920s, films became a powerful thing, and theaters.
- 4.97 There was a new classlessness in dress, speech, and attitudes. Partly, that was improved travel, partly movies, partly radio. It was common before then that someone from one part of the United States would go to another part and simply not be able to understand what anyone was saying. That started to break down. It really didn't completely break down until television came along in the 1950s and '60s, but still, the '20s, with the advent of radio, did change things. People started hearing what we now think of as standard English and began increasingly to speak that way. In some sense, too bad. Lots of regional accents were lost, but it meant people could communicate with anyone else anywhere in the country.
- 4.98 There was a cultural liberation. Women began working outside the home in large numbers. A spread of education—literacy rate in the United States was 96%. There was also a cultural flowering in literature, in the arts, in music. Think of the names of people whose great works were in the 1920s. In literature: F. Scott Fitzgerald, Ernest Hemingway, Sinclair Lewis, John Dos Passos, Theodore Dreiser, William Faulkner, Thomas Wolfe, Eugene O'Neill, Thornton Wilder. In fact, much of high school reading lists traditionally came out of authors who were working during the 1920s. Then, that isn't even to mention the authors of the Harlem Renaissance, people like Langston Hughes, Countee Cullen, Zora Neale Hurston, James Weldon Johnson, Alain Locke, Claude McKay.
- 4.99 And then, in painting: Edward Hopper, Maxfield Parrish, George Bellows, John French Sloan. Photography: Man Ray, Alfred Stieglitz, Ansel Adams. In Sculpture: Calder,

Whitney, French. Then, the first showing of Picasso's works at the Museum of Modern Art in New York City. Then, in popular culture: Mickey Mouse, Popeye. A lot of iconic characters really first appeared during the 1920s. In music, this being the jazz age, it was a tremendous age for the development of American music: Irving Berlin, Jerome Kern, the Gershwins, Aaron Copland. And then, all the heroes of jazz: Duke Ellington, Louis Armstrong, Hoagy Carmichael, Bessie Smith, Fats Waller, and so on and so on and so forth. The list goes on and on and on.

- 4.100** Now, there is this sense, or was this sense at any rate before the 1920s, that America was a backwater, that real culture was going on in Europe. Starting in the 1920s, that seemed no longer to be true. Where it was happening was in the United States, largely as a result of increased literacy, increased travel, increased communication, but also the government adopting policies that allowed for this flowering and didn't try to restrict speech or other things in any way.
- 4.101** There wasn't entirely a wonderful picture, on the other hand, as a result of this. The development of American culture did lead to a sense of arrogance. If before that, Americans felt as if they had a bit of a chip on their shoulder, that the real action was happening in Europe, now there was a sense that it's happening in the United States, and it's easy to let that success go to your head.
- 4.102** The education of Henry Adams, for example, in 1918, had talked about already an educated disillusionment, a national culture that was really seeking a multiversity, something like that. But that was based, I think, in part, on that sense of inferiority. Like, "We're really not much, so we have to expand our view and really think of ourselves as continuous with the culture of Europe." But, it increasingly, throughout the '20s, developed into this educated but disillusioned group that really were ambivalent about the rest of America. There was a sense in which, "There's this huge cultural flowering. Look how well we're doing. Look how great this is." But then, "Look how great we are." Indeed, it's easy to go from how great this is to how great we are.
- 4.103** Van Wyck Brooks wrote, even as early as 1917, "Never forget that it's we New Yorkers and New Englanders who have the monopoly on whatever oxygen there is in the American continent." In other words, saying that yeah, there's a part of America that's actually ready to do this, but it's all happening in New York and New England. I mean, the rest of the country is still a backwater. As literature developed throughout the 1920s and the jazz age emerged, there was more and more that sense that all the activity, yes, it's happening in the United States now, but it's mostly in New York and New England. At least that's the way the people involved in New York and New England saw it.
- 4.104** So increasingly, what arose was this, well, dictatorship, if you can call it that, of a self-appointed scholastic elite. The thought was, "We are the guys who know things. We are the people who count." This East Coast cosmopolitanism, you might think was the height of American culture, but it also threatened to become a counterculture. Later, it

was captured in this cover of the New Yorker: 9th Avenue, 10th Avenue, Hudson River, Jersey, then the rest of the country, Pacific Ocean, etc. In other words, really, half the country is New York City, really Manhattan, forget the rest.

- 4.105** That view is something that still persists. I have lots of friends who teach at universities in New England or in New York, and they do have that attitude, "What really matters happens here," roughly between Cambridge, Massachusetts, and New York City, and the rest of the country is like, whatever. That attitude, however strong it might still be, despite the growth in the Sun Belt and the West Coast and so on; nevertheless is still strong, but it was much stronger and really, although already there, before the first World War, even, became much stronger during the 1920s.
- 4.106** It was in 1927 that Julien Benda, a French theorist, wrote a book called *The Treason of the Clerics* or *The Treason of the Intellectuals*. He said that there is growing now, throughout the West, an intellectual group that's treasonous, destructive to society. It sets itself up in opposition to the ruling class. But its idea is to train the leaders to come. What happens is that those leaders no longer identify their own interests with the interests of their society or its members. So, we're producing a leadership class that no longer believes in the country and no longer cares about its citizens. So he said, that's really dangerous.
- 4.107** Traditionally, there was this group of intellectuals, and societies tolerated them and even encouraged them. Why? Because they were supposed to have the time and the leisure to actually study the good, the true, the beautiful. Most of us were involved in day-to-day activities, keeping ourselves going and keeping the economy going.
- 4.108** But it's good to have a few people who are doing abstract research, who are thinking about deep things, asking questions, not only about how the world really is and investigating science, but also who were dedicated to thinking about deep questions: What is good? What should a society be like? What is truth? What is beauty? He said, throughout that period, humanity might have done evil, but at least in that way, it honored good. It was hypocrisy, but on the other hand, that's how civilization slipped into the world. At least we were honoring the good, and that was a good thing. Hypocrisy was the homage that vice paid to virtue.
- 4.109** But, Benda said, that started changing. It started changing by the end of the 19th century, in the beginning of the 20th. People began promoting authenticity, as Nietzsche did, and no longer thinking that this hypocrisy was acceptable. But actually, it was important. It was vital because at least you were honoring the good. What happened then is intellectuals abandoned these traditional ideals, abandoned the search for the true and the beautiful and the good.
- 4.110** Sometimes, as Marx alleged, they just took on the values of the ruling class. But actually, Benda said, most of the time, that wasn't what was happening. Actually, they started seeing themselves as in opposition to the ruling class and in opposition to the

rest of the people. Often in the name of the people, but nevertheless not really, and so began promoting their own interests, sometimes reflecting the desires of the people, but sometimes dividing them by race, by class, by nation, and in other ways, really encouraging hatreds and no longer serving the good, the true, and the beautiful, but maybe even their opposites. So Benda said, "Our age is becoming the age of the intellectual organization of political hatreds. We are heading for the greatest and most perfect war ever seen in the world."

4.111 Mostly today, I wanted to tell you a story of turmoil that turned into tremendous success in the Roaring Twenties. But there is this note that Benda saw that something is happening now. We are producing leaders that no longer believe in what they lead. That, he saw, was going to lead to big, big trouble.

Lecture 5: Downward to Darkness

At a glance — Downward to darkness.

- 5.1** I've entitled this lecture, Downward to Darkness. One of the most significant developments in the 20th century was the Russian Revolution, taking place in 1917, while the First World War was going on. It helped to resolve the war to some extent in the way that it did, though not in the way you might expect. Russia's withdrawal from the war meant that Germany could move its troops from the Eastern Front to the Western Front. You might have thought that made Germany's chances of winning the war significantly better. So why didn't that work?
- 5.2** Well, as it happened, it did sort of work, in that the leaders that Germany had in the East, who had been defeating the Russian army soundly in every battle, were actually much more talented than the leaders who had been there on the Western Front. So they came over and started adapting some of the German strategy in the West to what they had been using very successfully in the East. And believe it or not, it worked. However, the fact that they were able in some places to break through the Allied lines didn't lead to a German victory. It led to the opposite.
- 5.3** Why? Because of the communication problems I was mentioning that affected especially the British and French in the early stages of the war. The German soldiers broke through the lines and ended up in these French villages. Well, suddenly you're a German soldier who has been deprived of everything good and fun and enjoyable, living on minimal rations for years, and suddenly you're in a French village, and you find out they have wine, they have cheese, and it's France. It's good wine, it's good cheese. And in short, the German soldiers went into the basement of these wine shops and got drunk.
- 5.4** At that point, they were easily captured, and there was no way of communicating with headquarters to get further orders, so they just found themselves there. The result of that was, basically, they broke through the lines only to find themselves quickly surrounded and captured. It was part of the reason Germany ended up actually trying to seek the end of the war. In any event, in that backward way, Russia's withdrawal, even though they were allies of France and Britain, nevertheless helped the Allies win the war.
- 5.5** In order to understand the Russian Revolution and what happened, we really need to go back into the 19th century to study Marxism, because what Lenin claimed at least to be doing was implementing Marxism in Russia. So, we need to go back to the thought of Karl Marx. Marx himself was a creature of the 19th century, born in 1818, dying in 1883. He started out as a journalist and then quickly became attached to his friend, Friedrich Engels, who had inherited factories, and so basically lived as a client of Engels

and a friend. He never, after that, really had any job. He simply sought to bring about the revolution.

- 5.6 He ended up doing that in a number of countries, so Marx became a kind of hero in parts of the world, including in the Soviet Union. Now, Marx was in some ways very fortunate, not only in befriending Engels, who supported him for the rest of his life, but also in publishing, with Engels, the Communist Manifesto in 1848. That was the year of revolutions. Throughout cities in Europe, in Italy, Austria, Hungary, Germany, France, there were revolts, partly because this was happening at the end of the first Industrial Revolution.
- 5.7 And as we saw, that was a part of the Industrial Revolution that led to tremendous inequality, terrible working conditions, overcrowding in the cities, epidemics of disease. So it was natural for people to think, "Wait a minute. Capitalism has brought this about. This is terrible," and to seek revolution. In a way, they were able to publish this document that said, "A specter is haunting Europe, the specter of communism," as if all of these revolutions were really about their ideas. In fact, they were riding a horse that was already well underway, and jumping on and saying, "Hey, yeah, this is our thing." But the timing couldn't have been better from their point of view.
- 5.8 Now, if we look at, from a historical perspective, what was going on at that time in 1848, you can see that it was a pivotal moment because the history of the world's economy is mostly a flat line. Then suddenly it takes off, as a hockey stick, but only in the last two centuries. So, go back to 1848, and the first Industrial Revolution was just starting that rise, but it was only barely beginning. It was the second Industrial Revolution, and then the advances of the 20th century, that really led to an explosion in prosperity throughout the world.
- 5.9 It wasn't just GDP per capita, which you might chart in this way, and you notice, oh, it had just started bending upwards. In 1848, you can also look at this throughout the entire world; and in various individual countries, you find the same thing, things bending, at least in European countries and in North America, upward right around the same time. It was true for life expectancy as well. Things began to improve, but it improved only very slightly by 1848. The big improvements were just about to come.
- 5.10 So, in a sense, Marx and Engels were publishing at a time when this tremendous disruption, due to the initial parts of the Industrial Revolution, had taken place, but the benefits were just beginning to be felt. It was a perfect time from one point of view to say, "Look, things are going terribly. Huge changes are taking place. They're overall bad changes, and we need to try to analyze them." Fifty years later, it seemed to most people as if, wait, things have gotten much, much better. But at that time, people were seeing all the costs of this huge change, and weren't yet seeing many of the benefits.
- 5.11 Let's take a look at how Marx was thinking about the problems that society was facing, ones that, to some extent, Lenin and others who followed him in the Soviet Union

shared. To some extent, however, they ended up departing from some of Marx's key premises. Here's the first premise—materialism. Marx was inspired by Hegel's idealism, but what he does is flip it over on its head. He ends up saying that Hegel has these mystical laws about how things work, and they're all based on this idea that everything depends on the mind. That's nonsense. He started in the wrong place.

- 5.12** In fact, everything depends on material conditions, on the basics of our material lives. He says, "They are the real individuals, their activity and the material conditions under which they live, both those they find already existing and those produced by their activity. These premises can be verified in a purely empirical way." What he's saying is, first of all, I want my theory to be scientific. I want it to be based on an empirical study of how people are actually living.
- 5.13** Secondly, what really matters, what is the base level here, as it were the scientific image that's going to explain what's really going on, that base level is purely material. It has to do with the way people really live, the practical aspects of their lives. Now, ideas which Hegel had taken as primary, and which any idealist takes as primary, he says, that comes afterwards. We get ideas on the basis of the problems we face in real life.
- 5.14** So he says, "Conceiving, thinking, the mental intercourse of men, appear at this stage as the direct efflux of their material behavior. The same applies to mental production as expressed in the language of politics, laws, morality, religion, metaphysics of a people." What he's saying is that our ideas arise out of the material conditions under which we're living. It's not that we start with an idea and then start to live that way. We live this way. We confront various problems, and our ideas come out of that. Our ideas are dependent on the real, practical problems of life.
- 5.15** So, here is how he puts it in a slogan. "Life is not determined by consciousness, but consciousness by life." He's saying, it's our real lives, our real material, practical lives that are fundamental. Ideas follow from that. So, it's not that ideas determine how we live; it's rather how we live that determines our ideas. So far, clear enough, he's trying to say. Don't start with the ideas. The ideas come after. They're the byproducts. So the basic level is life, our material, and ultimately, he thinks economic forces, the economic conditions under which we live. That's really fundamental.
- 5.16** So, all of the ultimate causes are actually material. They're economic. And then consciousness, ideas, the way we perceive the world, that arises out of the real, practical problems we face. Well, as a result of that, he's pretty suspicious of things at the level of pure ideas—maybe most of all of religion, because he thinks religion is really purely at the realm of ideas. It doesn't really directly relate to our practical problems of life at all, he thinks. So religion, he says, is just the opiate of the masses. It's your way of trying to avoid the real problems of life. So he attacks that.
- 5.17** And that, later in practice, that meant Marxists opposed Christianity, opposed other religions, and tried to wipe them out. But it isn't just religion. All norms, all

abstractions, are really just effects. None of them are to be taken seriously in their own terms. In the end, it's all money, it's all economics. It's all practical things that come down to, how am I going to live? How am I going to make money? That's what drives human behavior.

- 5.18** Well, is it true that economic motivations explain everything we do? Marx says yes. And yet, if you stop and think about it for a moment, you think, "There's a lot of stuff I do that doesn't seem economic. I mean, admittedly, I have a job." OK, that part is. But other parts, you might worry, really aren't. So Marx is going to have to claim, "Yes, they are. They don't seem to be, right? But I'm going to analyze them, and I'm going to think, yeah, you really think the way you do, you have feelings the way you do, all because of, in the end, these material circumstances."
- 5.19** It might be purely economic circumstances, but we could also expand this, as later Marxists often did, to say, yes, he thought the primary economic practical things in the end were economic, but maybe they don't have to be. Still, we can preserve that idea that it is the material conditions in which we live and the practical problems we face that determine how we think about things and how we live. Even if it all doesn't come down to money, it comes down to things that are at that material level. So, Marx himself thought it was really the economic stuff that mattered, but we could preserve the whole and not have to actually defend that if we didn't want to.
- 5.20** Now, one thing that they do—and by they I mean Marx and Engels— do take very unseriously is ethics itself. It's not just religion. That's the opiate of the masses. That's to be avoided. But what about what we say about how we should live? Maybe we think we should promote human happiness, or treat people with respect, for example, or treat them as we would want to be treated. Maybe we think that, in the end, what really matters is just trying to develop a good state of character, developing virtue.
- 5.21** Engels and Marx say none of that is to be taken seriously. It's all derivative from the practical problems of life. Now, a traditional ethicist might say, yeah, I'm trying to talk about how to live. So of course, it's derivative from the practical problems of life. But they don't mean it in that sense. They mean, you're always covering up for something. You say this is good, this is bad, this is right, this is wrong, this is fair, this is unfair, on the basis of what serves your advantage, what promotes your interests, and specifically your class interests.
- 5.22** So Engels writes this. "Men, consciously or unconsciously, derive their ethical ideas in the last resort from the practical relations on which their class position is based, from the economic relations in which they carry on production and exchange." So they might not seem economic, but really, there is this intermediary of a class you identify with. You say this is the right way to live, but you're reflecting the values of your class, and that social class becomes that social class primarily because of its economic position. So in the end, it turns out, it is economics driving all of this, even though it doesn't seem to be. Economics determines your class position. That determines your ideas.

- 5.23 One thing that follows from this is that ideas aren't to be taken seriously on their own terms, as I mentioned. So it leads to what has been called the hermeneutics of suspicion. Hermeneutics is just the science of interpretation. In short, when you tell me something, I should be suspicious. So you say, "I think that was unfair." I think, "Why do you say that?" It's in some way promoting your interest that you say that was unfair.
- 5.24 How does it do it? I don't interpret your language or your behavior, for that matter, by taking it seriously on its own terms. I say, "I am not interested in your evidence. I'm not interested in your reasons. I don't want to know why you think you said that. I want to look at the ultimate material economic causes." You're really saying, you thought that was unfair because it undermines your class position.
- 5.25 Then I have to ask, "What class are you?" And think about what their class position is. Maybe you think it's unfair because you're at the bottom of things and you think it's keeping you down. Or maybe you think it's unfair because you're on top and you think this challenges your position of authority. In any case, I'm going to look for reasons like that. I'm going to say, "I am not interested in your arguments. I'm not interested in your reasons. I want to know why you're really doing it." Often, that ends up making me think, "You're just saying this because of your position." So it makes you pretty cynical.
- 5.26 Everything, really—behavior, ideas, language—everything becomes a front for your own class interests, your own economic self-interest. In that way, suspicion makes me no longer really believe in any of these stories that people tell me, because they're all just cover-ups, they're all just rationalizations. And there's a kind of loss of respect that follows from that. Nobody's telling you the truth. Nobody's authentic. Everybody is just reflecting their own underlying economic self-interest.
- 5.27 You see people, let's say, having lunch together. Why are they doing that? If you ask them, they'll say, "We're friends, and we had a chance to meet up. I'm not usually in this town," but hey, that's not why. That's not why. This is in some way promoting your class interest. Or, why is she telling me this? Maybe I was wrong not to keep that promise, but maybe it's serving her class interests. In any case, I am going to be suspicious about this, no matter what it is.
- 5.28 Well, another thing follows, and a thing that is hugely important from a historical point of view follows from this. It's not just that I should be suspicious. It means ethics is nothing but a tool. I'm not going to take it seriously, either. What should I do? Well, if it's nothing but a front for economic self-interest, I'm going to use it to promote my self-interest, and in particular, the self-interest of the party. Because if I'm a good Marxist, I shouldn't identify with my own social class; I should identify with the party, the party that's going to bring about revolutionary change.
- 5.29 Trotsky says this. "None of us desires or is able to dispute the will of the party. Clearly, the party is always right. We can only be right with and by the party, for history has provided no other way of being in the right." Now, at first glance, this sounds like it's

contradicting Marx and Engels, because he's taking this pretty seriously. He's saying the party is always right, and he's not saying, "Hey, of course, this is just a front for my own interests." Instead, he's claiming this to be right. So it sounds inconsistent.

- 5.30** On the other hand, if you decide, "Oh, ethics is all just rationalization," he's just being open about the rationalization. He's saying, "Yeah, look, the party defines, that's the class I identify with. The party, it's the one that's going to change the position of all these other classes. So, I'm just being open about it. That's what ethics is. It's just reflecting the self-interest of your group, and that's my group, so that's what you have to do."
- 5.31** From that point of view, he's just being open and honest about the fact that it's just a tool. It is just a tool that you can use to bring about what you want. It's not to be taken seriously. In the end, ethics is just tactics. Indeed, "to us, morality is subordinated to the interests of the proletariat's class struggle. What's right? Whatever serves the interests of the party. What's true? Whatever serves the interests of the party." And so, things like truth, the good, beauty, none of that matters in any independent way. It's all just what serves the interests of the party.
- 5.32** What's permitted then? What am I allowed to do? Anything that serves the interest of the party. Now, Dostoevsky had worried that, if God is dead, then everything is permitted. Well, in a certain sense, that's the position we're in now. Although it's not absolutely anything, it's got to be whatever brings about this revolutionary change. But it does become nothing but tactics. So, ethics is just tactics. I am to produce whatever serves the interests of the party by any means necessary. There are no ethical constraints on me. I can do whatever I want, because what is right is simply whatever serves the interests of the party.
- 5.33** So in quest to the interests of the party, I am bound by no ethical constraints at all. Whatever works for the party, works, period. Anything is permitted. So there are no ethical constraints. I want to use propaganda to promote the interests of the party? No problem. I want to make people engage in double-think, so that they're saying with complete sincerity something that, in some part of their brain, they know is a lie? No problem.
- 5.34** I will induce that attitude of double-think, as Orwell described it, where people can actually—for a long time, as a kid, I didn't think this was possible. I read Orwell in high school, thought, "Who could do that?" Now I look around and I see lots of people do that. They say with complete sincerity things they have to know are false. It's not just, they're good liars. I think while they're saying that, they really believe it, even though they know it's not right. Engage in censorship? Again, no problem. No ethical constraints. Conduct surveillance on my political enemies? No problem. Punish dissent, even kill those who oppose me? There are no constraints. It's just tactics. Does it serve the interests of the party?

- 5.35** Ethics is one thing that Marx and Engels and their followers later don't take very seriously for that reason. But Marx, in *The German Ideology*, does tackle a question that I think is fundamental, and about that, he's quite serious. He asks, "What is it to be a human being? What is the essence of man?" At first, it sounds like he's cynical about that question, too. He says, "Men can be distinguished from animals by consciousness or religion or anything else you like." So, you expect him to say, "That's not really the question." But actually, that's not his view. There are lots of people who have thought about this question. Aristotle, for example, says, "Here's what's essential to us—rational activity. I think, I plan, I do." And so, what's happening is that we human beings are capable of acting according to rational plans. That's what's essential to us.
- 5.36** There are lots of other answers people have given. We walk upright, we reflect, we speak, we abstract, we theorize, we laugh, we cry, we feel, we pray, we worship. Lots of things seem distinctive of human beings. But Aristotle would say, all of those involve some kind of rational activity. That's what they all have in common. But Marx has a different answer. Marx says, here's what's special about us. It's not just thinking or acting according to a rational plan. Animals can do that. Birds can build nests. They seem to be acting according to a rational plan.
- 5.37** Here's what's special about us. We make, we produce. We're capable of farming. We're capable of building factories. We can build institutions like hospitals and universities. We can do things that actually produce things. Other animals are basically at a hunter-gatherer-type of stage. We're not like that. We were at that stage, but we've evolved to the point where we can actually make and produce the things we need. That's what's special about us. We distinguish ourselves "from animals as soon as we begin to produce our means of subsistence."
- 5.38** If that's what's essential to us, we can ask: What are the necessary conditions of it? What's essential to that, to that act of producing our own means of subsistence? The answer is, well, we have to have the means to produce. I can't produce what I need out of nothing. I've got to have the means to do it. So control of the means of production is absolutely central.
- 5.39** What is essential to us is being able to make things, to produce things. But I need something in order to make and produce things. I produce and make things out of other things. If I don't have those other things to start with, if I don't have the tools I need to do it, I can't do it. So the means of production are absolutely central to what it is to be human.
- 5.40** And he says, now here's the problem. Throughout the history of the world, it's been a history of class struggle, the bourgeoisie against the proletariat. How do we define those? In terms of ownership of the means of production. Do you have the means of production yourself, or is somebody else loaning them to you? So the bourgeoisie, they own the means of production. They're capable of actually fulfilling their essence because they do have what they need to produce things.

- 5.41 On the other hand, the proletariat, they're the workers. They lack the means of production. They have to work for somebody else, work on somebody else's farm, work in somebody else's factory, for somebody else's company. They are doing something for someone else, because they don't have the means themselves. And so they need to rely on someone else. They're dependent on the owners of the means of production.
- 5.42 He says that sets up a tension, because this group has what they need to be fully human. This group doesn't. They have to depend on those. And so, a conflict in their interests is inevitable. If you look at the Communist Manifesto and you do a word cloud to see what the significant terms are—bourgeois, class, proletariat, bourgeoisie—those are the big terms that are used throughout this entire document. It's all centered around that conflict between the bourgeoisie and the proletariat.
- 5.43 How do we solve the problem of class struggle? Some people own the means of production. Some people don't; they have to rely on them. Rousseau had talked about this kind of issue in his Discourse on the Origins of Inequality. He said, "The true founder of civil society is the first person to rope off a plot of land, declare 'this is mine,' and find people fool enough to believe him." Well, Marx looks at that and says, "Interesting." That's when great inequality started arising in human society. I rope off this plot of land, and let's say it's more than I can actually farm. I'm no longer a subsistence farmer. Now I have to hire people to work on my land.
- 5.44 All of a sudden, that employment idea is something that means they depend on me for their ability to produce. I own the means of production, in this case, the land. They have to work for me. And so that leads to great inequality. The bourgeoisie, the owners of the means of production, they become the masters, as it were. The proletariat increasingly become their slaves, completely dependent on them. Even if they get paid, it's a form of wage slavery. Why? Because it's a dependency. They depend on the people who actually own the means of production.
- 5.45 Marx, I think, is inspired in part by Rousseau. He looks at that and says, well, Rousseau thinks, we do all of this. We engage in various social contracts that don't work. Eventually, we adopt the kind of social contract that he advocates, which redistributes things within all of this. Marx says that's not the right solution, because that redistribution can't be counted on, for one thing. For another thing, the tension remains.
- 5.46 And so he says, if you really want to go back to the beginning, go back to that true founder of civil society, who ropes off the plot of land and says, "This is mine." Don't let them do it. All the problems start there. So don't let them do it. Abolish private property. If there is no private property, then there are no owners of the means of production. If there are no owners, there are no bourgeoisie. If there are no bourgeoisie, there is no class struggle. So we get rid of the class struggle by abolishing private property. That's the root of all evil here.

- 5.47 Now, it's often said that there are lots of people who aren't part of the bourgeoisie and aren't really part of the proletariat either, and Marx and Engels admit that. They say, "Yeah, I'm not saying these are the only two classes. It's just that the conflict between those two classes drives human history." There are the professors over there doing their thing, but nobody cares about them. There are the clerics who are there giving the masses their opiates, whatever. There are, and he says, "the rural idiots," the small farmers who are just sitting there doing their thing, or the person who's doing their crafts and selling them at the local fair, whatever. They are doing their thing, but they don't really matter. They don't drive history.
- 5.48 Here, it's not exactly as if Marx is saying, "I don't care about those people," though maybe he doesn't. But really, he's saying, "Nothing about human history depends on what they're doing, typically." The professors, they're dealing with ideas. That's derivative. Those people who are the small crafts people, they don't really have any effect on the larger social framework. But the owners of the means of production and the people who have to work for them, that's what drives most of the economy. It's what drives human history. That's the one to worry about. So am I saying everybody's part of one or the other group? No. But on the other hand, they're the groups that matter, and it's their conflict that we have to resolve. That's how we do it.
- 5.49 Now, in practice, what does this mean? Marx and Engels in the Communist Manifesto spell that out. It means state ownership of the means of production, and that means the means of communication, of transportation, of farms, of factories, of banks. Anything that's involved in the large-scale shaping of the economy needs to be under state ownership, state control, no longer privately owned, but instead collectively owned.
- 5.50 Secondly, there needs to be a progressive income tax. The more you earn, the more you pay, and the greater the percentage is that you pay. There should be no inheritance. We have to stop people from inheriting these bits of wealth that allow people to form stable social classes. So a complete estate tax, everything is taxed away when you die. There should be industrial armies. In other words, once we've adopted this, so there are no owners of private property, it means there is no employment as traditionally understood. There's nobody who is saying, "I've got this farm, I need people to work on the farm." Nobody owns the farm. It's our collective farm.
- 5.51 Who determines who works where and who does what? Well, we're going to need industrial armies. We'll need something like a draft to say, "Hey, we need you people on the farms. We need you people in the factories," and so on. There should be free education, so that anybody is prepared to take on the roles that we need them to play in society.
- 5.52 There are also things that communism attacks. If they advocate that kind of state ownership and so on, and free education, there are certain things that stand in the way. Why? Because we need people to be committed not to their own private

interests, but to the interests of the whole. And so there are other things that people care about that are going to stand in the way. For example, people are attached to members of their own family. And if we put people in situations where their obligations to their family conflict with their obligations to the state, all too often the family is going to win. Marx and Engels say, "We need to undermine the family."

- 5.53** We need to undermine marriage. After all, husbands and wives are going to actually value each other, and that, too, will compete with allegiance to the state. Any form of private association, any conception of a private sphere, that's something that's going to be a potential source of conflict with the state. Here is Marx's maybe most controversial idea or most puzzling idea, depending on how you look at it. He thinks in *The German Ideology* that it's ultimately the division of labor that leads to serious problems, and so it has to be undermined.
- 5.54** He says, "The bourgeoisie, wherever it's got the upper hand, has put an end to all feudal, patriarchal, idyllic relations." Notice the idea of the feudal relations and patriarchal relations being idyllic. He says, "It has pitilessly torn asunder the motley feudal ties that bound man to his natural superiors, and has left no other nexus between people than naked self-interest, than callous 'cash payment.'"
- 5.55** So in part here, he almost sounds romantic. It's like, remember the good old days in the Middle Ages, where we all had a role to play, and it was all good, and then it got broken apart by capitalism, and all of a sudden, we start working for other people and being paid and caring about money? There's an element of Marx that I think is actually reactionary. It's sort of romantic, saying, "Things used to be good. We all knew how it worked."
- 5.56** But he says, here's what's happened increasingly: division of labor has taken over. So, as soon as that happens, each person has a particular exclusive sphere of activity. You can't escape from it. You become a hunter or a fisherman or a critic or a professor or a plumber or a computer programmer or whatever it is that you do. That becomes part of your identity. He says that also competes with your allegiance to the whole and the good of the whole. But it moreover limits you.
- 5.57** You, instead of thinking of yourself as a full human being, whose job is to make and produce for the good of the whole, instead you start thinking of yourself as just a hunter or an artist or a professor or a plumber. And that is a danger. So he says, what it does is not only undermine allegiance to the whole, it also limits you. You have too limited a conception of yourself. You put yourself in this little box as a result of this, and that undermines your own essence. You're more than just a plumber. You're more than just a professor. You're more than just a computer programmer.
- 5.58** He says, "In a communist society," at least an ideal one, "nobody would have an exclusive sphere of activity." You could do anything you want. Society would regulate the general production, but you wouldn't be locked into a particular sphere. You could

"do one thing today and another tomorrow. You could hunt in the morning, fish in the afternoon, rear cattle in the evening, criticize after dinner."

- 5.59** I find that one funny. Reminds me of my graduate student softball team where we lost almost every game, but we'd sit around afterwards and criticize each other. "Well, if only you had caught that ball, we would have won." One time, we actually won a game, and we sat around afterwards, just staring at each other for 20 minutes. Finally, somebody said, "Why is nobody talking?" It's like, "We won. There's nobody to blame." This reminds me of that. But anyway, the whole idea is, I could do any of those things without actually becoming a hunter or becoming a fisherman or becoming a critic. I could do various kinds of things.
- 5.60** I've asked my students sometimes, if you could do and be anything, and all occupations were paid exactly the same, what would you choose to do? When I survey them this way, I find that an astounding number of them want to be artists and musicians. Well, good for art and music. But also, what happens to a society where most people decide, "I'm just going to sit around and paint, or I'm just going to play guitar"? Nothing good, and we'll come back to that.
- 5.61** But now, does Marx have a theory of justice? He claims to be completely cynical about ethics. Ethics is just tactics, whatever serves the interests of the party. On the other hand, he's also ending the Communist Manifesto by saying, "Workers of the world, unite!" You might think, well, that's a command. Where does that come from? Is it just something that serves the interests of the party? Why don't we act cynically toward that?
- 5.62** By the way, it is controversial among scholars whether Marx has a theory of justice. Some say yes, some say no. I think, if you look at his work carefully, you can see three different theories of justice, and I just want to mention them very briefly. One is in Capital, his very massive work on economics, where he turns Locke's labor theory of property into a theory of value. Locke had the idea: What is it that makes things mine? He imagined someone going to the forest and picking up acorns, and he brings the acorns home and, let's say, makes a big stew out of them. What makes them his? He says, well, it's his labor. The moment he picks it up, it becomes his. He's exerted his labor and put it into it. So that makes it his property. It's a labor theory of property.
- 5.63** Marx says, well, we can go even further. What is the value of the acorn? It's the amount of labor it takes to actually obtain it. So it's not just that, yes, it becomes your property. Marx says this is also a measure of what it's worth. So the value of a worker's labor, he calls it, is surplus value, the value being added by the laborer's activity. Here's the idea then. What's just? Getting the full value of what you produce. And so, whatever you add as value, that's something you should receive in turn.
- 5.64** Well, a distribution is going to be just, then, to the extent that it rewards people in proportion to their surplus value, in proportion to that value added as a result of their

labor. Now, one thing that follows from that is, profits are inherently unjust, because if somebody's earning a profit off of this, they're taking money that actually wasn't exerted through their labor but somebody else's. So I think it does follow from that theory of justice that he advocates at one point that all profits, all business, you might say, is inherently unjust.

- 5.65** In the Critique of the Gotha Program, on the other hand, he takes that back. He asks, what is a fair distribution? And he criticizes prevailing socialist views, including his own earlier view. He says, wait, a surplus value, that can't be what determines a fair distribution, partly because you get back a lot of things that aren't really in wages. After all, even a government has to do things to try to protect you and to try to keep the lights on in the factory, for example, and so on.
- 5.66** So, there's administrative overhead, there are energy costs, there's insurance, there's the cost of the machinery, there are social welfare programs, there's just the cost of the space in which you're pursuing this activity. He says, you know, a lot of this isn't going to come back to you in the form of wages, but in the form of other things, other social goods that enable this to happen. He says that what we're talking about, even then, is just justice within what is basically a capitalist society. Then, in a new, freshly formed communist society, it will be different, because now the state will own everything.
- 5.67** But he says, in a really advanced communist society, it would be different—"From each according to his abilities, to each according to his needs." So that's the ultimate goal. In the ideal society, people would contribute what they can and would get back what they need. So, that becomes his ideal. But he admits that's not something we can do now; that's something once the revolution has taken place and once we get to where we'd ideally like to go.
- 5.68** Well, do you have a problem with this? There are certain problems that emerge and that Marxists, as well as those who oppose them, have thought a lot about. One is just the question of motivation. What motivates me? After all, if I'm not actually able to make choices, if I am somebody who is in a position to not earn any profit from what I do, I'll get paid back what I actually contribute, but nothing more; there's no way I can really get ahead of the game, what motivates me to do anything?
- 5.69** I've asked students, "How many points on the exam would you be willing to donate to those at the bottom of the distribution?" So you score 95, how many points are you willing to give to those who didn't study and scored 30? Well, amazingly, a lot of people are willing to contribute something, but very few are willing to contribute a lot. Now, some do, but I assume those are the people who think, "I'm going to be a plumber with a 30." In any case, it's like, well, how motivated are you to study if some of your points are going to go away? And suppose your grade was just the class's average grade. How motivated would you be? How hard would you study? The answer is typically not very hard.

- 5.70** I've mentioned the problem that if you let people be what they'd like to be, most say, "Oh, I want to be an artist. I want to be a musician. I want to be creative." Those are great things to be. I don't mean to criticize that. But Marx and Engels weren't the first people to think of this idea. Robert Owen, for example, started New Harmony, Indiana. There were similar communities in Pennsylvania and Ohio. The idea was, we'd have common ownership. Nobody would be locked into anything. People could do what they wanted.
- 5.71** But those experiments usually lasted a very short time. New Harmony lasted for less than two years. Charles Fourier was a French socialist who was, as it happens, criticized by Marx, but had a similar idea. He couldn't find anyone in France who would actually implement this. But later, George Ripley in Massachusetts created Brook Farm to implement Fourier's ideas. That lasted about five years.
- 5.72** In both cases, the problem was that nobody wanted to do the hard work. Lots of people joined the band and said, "We'll inspire the workers by playing music as they work in the fields." Well, you can imagine how well that went over, and not enough people were actually working to produce the needed food. So, the result of all that was that it didn't work out very well at all. That highlights this problem of motivation. Who's going to go out there and do the unpleasant, hard work of society if we're really treating everybody equally and just giving you what you need?
- 5.73** Why should I bother developing talents for that matter? I mean, going to school takes a lot of effort over a long period of time. Why should I work hard to become excellent at what I do? After all, if I don't get any benefit from that, what's my motivation? Why should I do it? Why should I undertake risk? Why should I start a new business? Why should I do anything where I might lose out and might fail? Most new businesses fail, for example. Why should I start that coffee shop or start that new ad company or whatever it is, taking those risks, if there's nothing to be gained?
- 5.74** Now, somebody, moreover, is going to have to be deciding who gets what and who needs what. And so, who is that group? Who's going to be controlling this? Well, there's going to be some group that manages to do this. In Russia, they were called the "nomenklatura". They were the people who were, in effect, the bureaucrats who said, "Here are the rules, here's what you get, here's what that's worth," and so on. And indeed, that tends to happen in a Marxist society. Somebody's got to make things run.
- 5.75** Milovan Djilas, a Yugoslavian Marxist, said, "Lenin, in the end, in the USSR, just replaced one ruling class with another. He called it the new class." This new class was the class of administrators, the class of bureaucrats who made things run. Well, it felt like, "Meet the new boss, same as the old boss." It's not the capitalists anymore. It's this administrator appointed by the state. But the relation between that person and the worker seemed pretty similar. There was this vanguard elite of party functionaries, and they ran things, and everybody else, in effect, had to do what they said.

- 5.76** Now, maybe that's inevitable. Robert Michels said, in the Iron Law of Oligarchy, "All forms of organization turn into oligarchies. Whoever says organization, says oligarchy." Why? Because somebody has to organize the group. An organization is a group organized for a certain purpose. Who determines the purpose, and who establishes the organization? Somebody's got to do it. It doesn't arise naturally.
- 5.77** So, in any kind of organization, somebody has to be in control. That's just what organizations are. As a result of that, you can't really get rid of the basic problem, the basic tension. It's not just a question of owning the means of production, it's controlling the means of production, and these party functionaries end up fulfilling that role. The tension remains. That group tends to grow to a certain point, and in the end, starts fulfilling what the bourgeoisie used to do.
- 5.78** What about me as a worker? Marx says, in a capitalist society, I'll be alienated. I'll be working for somebody else. But now it seems like I'm still working for somebody else. Now I'm working for the party boss, instead of the actual boss in the capitalist enterprise. I still don't get the value I add. In fact, now maybe I get even less because there are all these social programs and other things that mean I'm taxed at a higher rate, and I have less to spend.
- 5.79** So it seems like I actually have more reason for alienation. I may be in the position that Lincoln denounced when he said, "The same old serpent says, 'You work, and I eat. You toil, I'll enjoy the fruits of it.'" But now, it's somebody determined by this group of the nomenklatura. It seems as if we all have to fit in and care just about the will of the collective, so it enforces a kind of uniformity. And indeed, in Marxist societies, there tend to be political prisons and other things that enforce conformity.
- 5.80** But even more seriously, you might think, if my essence is to make and produce, and you're making me make and produce not for myself, but for some other group, even if it's the whole of society, isn't that more damaging to my essence? If it was damaging to my essence to work for that guy, then why is working for all those guys any better? It seems as if maybe it's even worse. Now, Marx says these are temporary problems. Human nature itself will change. He says, "The philosophers have only interpreted the world; the point is to change it." And human nature itself will change. We will stop being selfish and start caring most about the collective.
- 5.81** The first real test of this was in Russia, 1917, the Russian Revolution, when Lenin ended up being sent back by the Germans, actually, to foment revolution in Russia. He was in exile. The Tsar had exiled him, but the Germans found him and said, "This is a way of getting Russia out of the war," and that trick worked. So, Lenin established a dictatorship there.
- 5.82** Here is how Gary Saul Morson put it. "Lenin did more than anyone else to shape the last 100 years. He invented a form of government we've come to call totalitarian, which rejected in principle the idea of any private sphere outside of state control. To establish

this power, he invented the one-party state, a term that previously would have seemed self-contradictory, since a party was, by definition, a part. An admirer of the French Jacobins, Lenin believed that state power had to be based on sheer terror, so he also created the terrorist state."

- 5.83** Indeed, he went back in April of 1917 to foment revolution. He was a professional organizer of totalitarian politics, the first of a new breed, and he ended up succeeding. He wrote a manifesto called, "What is to be done?" And there he outlined his view. Now, in part, he's saying, "I am an orthodox Marxist. I simply intend to implement the ideas of Marx. From the philosophy of Marxism cast as one piece of steel, it's impossible to expunge a single basic premise, a single essential part, without deviating from objective truth. Orthodox Marxism requires no revision of any kind."
- 5.84** But in practice, that wasn't true. He believed in human freedom. He believed in the power of will, and Marx didn't. Marx was a determinist. Social forces: the conflict of social classes is driven by these economic forces. Human beings are simply determined by all of that. We have no freedom of the will. And so the revolution, if it comes about, will come about not as an act of will, but just will arise through the social forces themselves.
- 5.85** Lenin—and here, keep in mind, this is now 75 years almost, after these ideas were developed in the 1840s—what's happening now is, Lenin is looking around saying, "I don't think this is going to work." I mean, increasingly, this has developed into unions and strikes and people caring about higher wages and better benefits and shorter working hours. There's no revolution being sought. That's going to have to come about, if it comes about at all, through an act of will.
- 5.86** Here is how he thought of it. "Classes are led by parties, and parties are led by individuals who are called leaders. That's the ABC. The will of a class is sometimes fulfilled by a dictator." So the class, the party, those aren't going to do anything by themselves. It requires individuals to lead them. He said, "I volunteered to be such a leader." So how does this work? Well, remember Trotsky saying, "The party is always right." It's the only way of being right. So we need an individual to take control and lead things in the direction of the party.
- 5.87** Now, some Marxists recognized, wait a minute, this is a very dangerous departure from Marxism. Rosa Luxemburg, for example, "This is going to lead to a military ultra-centralism," because there's going to be this small secret group that's going to be in control, total control, of everything and everyone. Those vanguard fighters, as Lenin described them, she saw as a very dangerous element. Well, they were very dangerous, but Lenin embraced that and created, you might say, an ideology or almost idolatry around himself as the great leader, the great dictator, who could not possibly be wrong.

- 5.88** Rather than thinking, as Marx did, that the revolution would happen by itself, he says that's not going to work. The working class is just developing trade union consciousness. They care about their own welfare. They're not seeking revolution. So we need an organization of revolutionaries. That's the only way it's going to happen. It's got to be people who are professional revolutionaries. It can't be the kind of thing where the guy works for 10 hours in the factory, gets home, and then has to go to a trade union meeting.
- 5.89** Then what's he going to do? He's going to sit around and say, "I'm tired of working six days a week at a 10-hour job. Let's have shorter working hours. How about five days a week at eight hours a day?" OK, fine. But that's not going to be plotting the revolution. So he says, "We need a different kind of person. We need a person who's professionally dedicated to revolution." They're going to be tired at the end of a long day in the factory. That's not the kind of person I'm talking about. I want somebody who's a full-time revolutionary.
- 5.90** We need just a few of them. They've got to remain as secret as possible, and they need to be stable. We've got to have the same group of leaders. No more of this "let's have another union election, a different person takes over," etc. No, we need a small, secret, stable group. They have to be professional revolutionaries, and they've got to be willing to do anything to bring about their revolution. They must recoil from nothing because it's going to be hard. You've got an established society; you've got this tiny group. How are they going to bring about a revolution all by themselves? They've got to recoil from nothing. They'd better be willing to do it by any means necessary.
- 5.91** So here's his goal. First of all, destroy all power outside of the party. Secondly, consolidate all power in the party in a few hands. Destroy all opposition within the party and concentrate all the party's power in itself. So think of it in terms of concentric circles. Get rid of anything outside the party; then, within the party, get rid of any opposition. Concentrate power within a small group, and then, in the end, in one individual who can be the leader of that small group.
- 5.92** Well, that produces a dictatorship, in fact, a totalitarian one, because the party is now in control of everything. So dictatorship, Lenin said, is nothing other than power, which is totally unlimited by any laws, totally unrestrained by absolutely any rules, and based directly on force. That's what he pursued, and he sought popular support for that and managed to do that. After all, Russia was losing all those battles in the First World War. The Tsar seemed corrupt and out of touch. People were getting killed in all of those battles at an astounding rate. It was a huge imposition on Russia's economy. And so, Russia was falling apart anyway. Lenin presented himself as the savior.
- 5.93** Upon seizing power, first thing he did is close all newspapers. He had elections at every organization. So, no longer the person who had been in charge, now, leave it up to the workers who's going to be the boss. He searched houses, confiscating jewelry, confiscating fur coats, anything else of value, seized schools, banks, factories,

established revolutionary courts, and also prohibited interest, dividends, and withdrawals from bank accounts. Suddenly, everybody was cut off from the money they had, whatever it was, and then began to implement a reign of terror.

- 5.94** That was part of the program. It wasn't just a regrettable necessary means. It was something he embraced. He said, "We've never renounced terror and cannot renounce it. We'll ask the man, 'Where do you stand in the question of the revolution? Are you for it or against it?' If he's against it, we stand him up against a wall," and shoot him, is the implication. He created a secret police force, the Cheka. It was not officially acknowledged for 10 years, but within three years, it had a quarter of a million full-time agents.
- 5.95** "When we are reproached with cruelty," he said, "we wonder how people can forget the most elementary Marxism." Well, of course, it was not elementary Marxism. Marx thought all this would arise from itself, not through a secret police force that would go around killing people. A good communist, he said, is also a good Chekist. So for Lenin, that idea of the use of terror, the use of force, was just essential to the whole view. That's why many people talk about Leninism or Marxism-Leninism, as opposed to just Marxism, because these were specific things that went beyond anything that Marx seems to have said.
- 5.96** Well, by 1918, by 1919, the Cheka was averaging 1,000 executions a month. They arrested, tried, sentenced, and punished people with no checks on power whatever. More Russians died in this purge than died in the Great War, and more died this way than died in the Russian Revolution. Lenin said, "To us, morality is subordinated to the interests of the proletariat's class struggle." So again, that idea later expressed by Trotsky that it's just tactics. In the end, it's whatever you need to do. There are no other moral constraints.
- 5.97** Lenin embraced this and delighted in it. He said, "We must seek out, arrest, and shoot immediately. Enemies, idlers, bribe-takers, speculators, prostitutes, ex-officers, work-shirkers, hoarders, and so on. Not a minute to be wasted." So notice some of those groups may be fairly well defined; a lot of them are not very well defined. Work-shirkers, hoarders, and so on—oh, gosh. In 2020, my wife bought a lot of toilet paper when it was finally possible to get it. Our garage is still full of toilet paper. I suppose she'd be shot by Lenin as a result of hoarding all of this. In any case, some of these were pretty ill defined.
- 5.98** But within weeks, he was operating a system of concentration and labor camps, and by 1920, there had been more than 50,000 executions. So the idea here wasn't that you in particular were guilty of anything, necessarily. I mean, maybe you were, but maybe you were simply part of a group. It was a conception of collective guilt. You're a member of a certain class; that automatically makes you guilty.

- 5.99** "Without mercy, without sparing, we'll kill our enemies in scores of hundreds. Let them be thousands. Let them drown themselves in their own blood. Let there be floods of blood of the bourgeois." It's simply being an owner of the means of production, or even being an agent of the owners of the means of production, that earned you a death sentence. You didn't yourself have to have done anything.
- 5.100** In January 1918, Lenin announced, "We need to purge the Russian land of all kinds of harmful insects." Notice that dehumanization. They're just insects. It's just like stepping on a bug. The bourgeoisie have no independent human dignity or worth. "Our revolutionary courts must shoot," he announced. Now, I've already mentioned the targets that he listed—the prostitutes, the ex-officers, the work-shirkers, the hoarders, and so on.
- 5.101** But Solzhenitsyn ended up cataloging, well, who really were the targets? Who were these people accused of all these things? Homeowners, they own something. Private property had to be destroyed. Originally, in Marx, I think that meant factories, means of communication, means of transportation. In other words, large-scale things. But in Lenin's view, that included things like houses. What about high school teachers? They were part of it, too, because they taught things, they were trained the old way. They were teaching the way things used to be, rather than imbibing the values of the revolution.
- 5.102** Priests, monks, well, of course, they were involved in selling the opiate of the people. Nuns, similarly. Pacifists, well, they weren't willing to do whatever was necessary for the cause of the revolution. Trade union officials. Why them? After all, they had been leaders for reform. The answer is, well, because they were satisfying the workers with things like pay raises, shortened working hours, better working conditions, and so on. They were standing in the way of the revolution. So get rid of them.
- 5.103** Latsis, who was the head of the Cheka for a time, said, "The Cheka doesn't judge the enemy. It strikes him. We're not carrying out war against individuals. We are exterminating the bourgeoisie as a class. We're not looking for evidence or witnesses. The first question we ask is, to what class does he belong? What are his origins, upbringing, education, or profession? These questions define the fate of the accused. This is the essence of the Red Terror." Just ask about a person's class. What's your education? What was your upbringing? What were your origins? Those determine your fate.
- 5.104** Now, here, I think it's interesting to contrast this with the idea in the Communist Manifesto. There, Marx and Engels are saying, "We have to eliminate the bourgeoisie as a class, but how do we do it? We abolish private property. We don't kill people necessarily. We simply say, 'You don't own the factory anymore.' We nationalize." Nationalizing industry, that's rather different from lining people up against a wall and shooting them.

- 5.105** So, these are two rather different conceptions of what it is to abolish the bourgeoisie. One says, "Well, get rid of their ownership of the means of production. Take that over and take the company away from them." The other says, "Line them up against a wall and kill them." And so Lenin interpreted this "abolish the bourgeoisie" idea in a way that required terror, required violence, required executions on a mass level, and in a way that—I don't mean to say, "Oh, I think Marx never imagined it." I don't know what Marx imagined, but at least the obvious way of interpreting what he said is, "I want to nationalize industries," not, "I want to kill all those who are members of the bourgeoisie now."
- 5.106** Now, I think Lenin did have a reason. He said, first of all, it hasn't happened. But secondly, he didn't see how those people could have their influence removed in any other way. I don't want to at all defend his claim, but what he thought was really, "If I nationalize the industry, who do we get to run it? It's probably going to be many of the same people. I don't want that to happen. We have to eliminate the people, not just eliminate that job."
- 5.107** Keep in mind, the underlying thought here is: What's good? Whatever serves the interests of the party. What's right? Whatever serves the interests of the party. What's true? Whatever serves the interests of the party. So, don't tell me this is horrible. Don't tell me I'm murdering innocent people. There's nothing wrong with any of that. Ethics is bunk. It's just whatever works to bring about the revolution.
- 5.108** This involved a huge amount of barbarism, among them, most famously, the murder of the royal family in 1918. A British naval attaché in the British Embassy was also murdered. Now, Churchill thought that Britain should immediately go into Russia and capture and shoot Lenin and Trotsky, bring the revolution to a stop quickly. But the Western powers were tired of war. They didn't want to do that. And so in the end, the Russian Revolution was allowed to proceed.
- 5.109** What did people think of this in the West? Astoundingly, maybe, the Western press approved of all of this. The reports were generally glowing. Now, not without exception. Some people reported what was going but not many. Lincoln Steffens in 1919 said, "I've been over into the future, and it works." He visited Russia and came back saying, "This is all great. All roads in our day lead to Moscow." And yet, it's hard to imagine what he saw. Petrograd, between 1917 and 1920, lost 72% of its population. And 3 million people died in the winter of 1921-22 of starvation. So what on earth was he seeing? What on earth did other Western observers see?
- 5.110** It's not just that. The Russian economy was collapsing. 1920, compared to 1913, before the war, iron production was down to 2%. It was one-fiftieth of what it had been before the war. Manufactured goods, 13%. So in those respects, the Russian economy was sputtering, barely alive. People were vastly worse off than they had been before the Revolution, and even before the First World War. Some defenders will say, "It was

really all the First World War and the Russian Revolution." But actually, go back to 1913, before the war, things were vastly better than for Russians.

- 5.111** So what on earth did people see? It's a good question. Lenin himself recognized that things were going terribly, partly due to the difficulty of motivating anyone. So he introduced in 1921 his new economic program. He allowed ownership. He allowed the free exchange for peasant farmers to end the famine. They could actually own a portion of their crops. They could sell them if they wanted. They could consume them. He had to find a way of motivating people to actually produce something.
- 5.112** He said, "It's the biggest mistake to think that the NEP will put an end to the terror. We'll return to the terror, and to economic terror." But he said, "I've got to allow some degree of private property here, because otherwise nobody's doing anything. Everything's falling apart." I think there is a general dilemma here. If you implement a program where there is no private property and there is no profit, there is no benefit to taking risks. There's no benefit to developing talent or working hard. People don't do any of those things, and everything starts falling apart.
- 5.113** So in the end, you either let these market forces reassert themselves, you allow people to actually benefit from their activities to give them a motivation to do it, or you use force to stop that. When you do that, there's a terrible economic cost, a terrible human cost. So in the end, there was a dilemma here. Lenin had to give up some of his ideas and go back in the direction of private ownership, or just see his population and the economy and the whole country go down the tubes.
- 5.114** He decided, "I'd better allow some degree of private ownership." But shortly after that, he had a stroke, and by 1924, he was dead. So that barely began before it was wiped out, and Russia ended up taking a very different path. But that's a story for a future lecture.

Lecture 6: The Ruins of Meaning

At a glance — The ruins of meaning after WWI.

- 6.1** The First World War had an incredibly strong impact, not only on the formation of societies throughout much of the world, but on the intellectual scene as well. Some of it is that the cynicism that had arisen by the end of the 19th century, the loss of faith in faith, the loss of faith in progress, was intensified. It went from a few people on the edges of society to a much larger group, in many ways to an entire generation, that lost faith in their leaders, lost faith in their countries, lost faith in their civilizations. It also reshaped the way people thought about the world, the world of values, but the world in all sorts of other ways.
- 6.2** What I want to do in this lecture, and in the next several, is think about questions that involve the reactions that people had throughout, especially the 1920s, to the First World War and to the condition of civilization that they inferred from that war. One point of view would be, look, there was nothing wrong with our traditional values. It's just that a lot of people made bad decisions based on bad information, and we'll see that reaction.
- 6.3** One reaction is to say, there's something deeply wrong with this civilization, and indeed, the loss of faith in it is justified. Something has gone fundamentally wrong. But what has gone wrong, and what are our chances of recovery? Maybe this civilization is doomed to fail, or maybe it badly needs reform, but reform of what kind? How do we fix the problem that this conflict has revealed?
- 6.4** I'm going to start today by talking about two different thinkers, William Butler Yeats, an Irish poet, and also T. S. Eliot, and try to understand their reactions. Those are two poets, two of the greatest poets of the 20th century, but their ideas are deeply shaped by the war and react to it in ways that are in some ways parallel, but in some interesting ways different. Let's first turn to William Butler Yeats. He's very concerned with a view of cycles of civilization, and he thinks that the war has revealed that we're nearing the end of one of these cycles. He also then writes about a quest for unity, a quest for eternity. So let's look at those themes in his work first, and then we'll turn to T. S. Eliot.
- 6.5** Who was William Butler Yeats? An Irish poet and a playwright. In 1923, he won the Nobel Prize for literature. He was himself a strong advocate for Irish independence. There were a number of themes that pervade his poetry and suggest this idea of the war revealing something deeply wrong. He sees civilization as weary, as starting to collapse. That alarms him, of course. He thinks the war reveals something deep, something really breaking down in civilization.
- 6.6** But nature, on the other hand, abhors a vacuum. It's not as if there's going to be no civilization at all. He doesn't really fear that we're just going to collapse into barbarism.

But the problem is, what are we going to change into? We've got this, in part, nostalgia, in his work, a thought that things used to be better. This civilization used to make sense to the people within it. They believed in it, they trusted it. Now the war has shattered that sense of trust, shattered that sense of belonging. And so, what do we do about that?

- 6.7 But also, something is arising. There's going to be a new thing that fulfills this role that our civilization has fulfilled. But what on earth is it? His most famous poem is called *The Second Coming*, published in 1920, so written just at the end of the war. Here's how it begins. "Turning and turning in the widening gyre, the falcon cannot hear the falconer. Things fall apart. The center cannot hold. Mere anarchy is loosed upon the world. The blood-dimmed tide is loosed, and everywhere, the ceremony of innocence is drowned. The best lack all conviction, while the worst are full of passionate intensity."
- 6.8 There are a lot of phrases there that have crept into common parlance and into the culture at large—things like, "things fall apart," "the center cannot hold," or "the ceremony of innocence is drowned," "the best lack all conviction, the worst are full of passionate intensity." But let's go to the beginning. He's talking about a falcon that is getting further and further away. The idea is that the falconer has the falcon there on the arm. The falcon takes off and is going in these wide sweeping circles, and is supposed to come back to the falconer when the falconer calls.
- 6.9 But in this case, those spirals get wider and wider, further and further away. The falcon can no longer hear the commands to come back, and things are spinning out of control. There is a general pattern. This idea of a gyre, of a spool, of something like that, pervades Yeats' work. It's a common theme, and here is the underlying view. He thinks that history progresses, if you can call it progress—it changes, anyway—in terms of 2,000-year cycles. They overlap in something like this way.
- 6.10 As one arises, another one is becoming less significant. By the time you get to the peak of one, the other is totally gone, and then it starts to decline, and a new one begins to take its place. So we've got these spirals, these gyres, as he puts it, that grow very gradually, reach a peak about a thousand years later, and then begin to decline. He sees us near the end of one of these cycles. So here's how he views it. Go back to as far as we really have much of a record, let's say the period from 4,000 to 2,000 BC. This is the Bronze Age. It is the era, as far as we can trace, of the beginnings of civilization.
- 6.11 This is the time when there is an advent of writing. The earliest writings we have appear to be accounting books from various civilizations in the Fertile Crescent. This is a time of Sumerian civilization, Persia, early Egypt. And so we have a record, a strong record, of these civilizations. There may have been things beyond this, back in an earlier period; we're not really sure. But in any case, here we see the rise of significant, and large and powerful civilizations.

- 6.12** Then, in that period from 2000 to minus 1, we see a 2000-year period where gradually the Bronze Age is replaced by the Iron Age. Now we see mature civilizations in Egypt, in China, in India. This is the time of the Rigveda and the Upanishads being written. Then in Greece, we have Homer, the Iliad, the Odyssey. We have Joseph, David, Solomon, in Jewish culture. Then we have what Karl Jaspers referred to as the Axial period, where, for some reason, all around the world, around 600 BC, we find a dramatic change in the nature of civilization and the rise of huge religious and philosophical traditions.
- 6.13** For example, in China, we find Confucius, Laozi, beginning traditions of Daoism and of Confucianism. In India, we not only find the maturing of Indian civilization in the Upanishads, we also find then the Buddha and the rise of Buddhist civilization. This is when the Hebrew scriptures are actually put together and compiled into one sort of book. Then we have Greek philosophy, theater, history. We have Plato, Aristotle, and Sophocles, Aristophanes, all of the things that we think of as classical Greece. All of those things are happening in this period.
- 6.14** So what we find here is not only the rise of civilization—that had already taken place—but here a maturing of civilization and the rise of some of the great traditions of Judaism, of Hinduism, Buddhism, Daoism, Confucianism, and then all of Greek culture arising right around the same time all over the world. Well, for the last 2,000 years, we've got the rise of the nation-state, the rise of Christianity, the Roman Empire, and then a continuous written culture.
- 6.15** In other places and times, there were presumably written cultures, but it was here, maybe for the first time, that we have a continuous written culture, so that people are well aware of who was thinking what in the past, and then responding to that, developing it, and so on. Arguably, that began during that previous period. And so, as it was declining, we started seeing a rise here with the start of those traditions. But that matures during this period.
- 6.16** We also begin to see, especially near the end of that, the development of advanced technologies. But we shouldn't pat ourselves on the back exclusively because it is surprising how many of the fundamental things that we take for granted were actually developed almost a thousand years ago. For example, looking into a mirror, you might say, who invented mirrors? When were the first mirrors appearing? Well, the answer is around the 13th century. They've been around for a long time. Now we just think of them as, well, everybody's been able to look at themselves in a mirror, right? Well, only for the last 800 years or so.
- 6.17** Now, that change, it's been a huge change, and especially near the end of the last 100 years or so. But when you look at those things, you start thinking, "Huh, around the year 2000. Gee, it's now 2025." And as Yeats is writing, it was 1920, so a little more than 100 years ago, Yeats wrote this poem. But he's already thinking, "I'm getting very close to the end of that historical period." We are in a position, from his point of view,

to say, "We're right at the beginning of a new historical period." But what is that going to be like? That's the question of this poem.

- 6.18** He's looking at a civilization that looks to him as if it's in its final days. There's been a huge development in these cycles throughout that period. But now, if that's about to be replaced with what? That's the question that haunts the poem. Maybe it's going to be awesome. Maybe it's going to be right out of Star Trek, or maybe it's going to be monstrous. Who knows?
- 6.19** So, he's concerned that, right now, it seems like things are in flux. Things are breaking down. That old cycle is about to collapse. When you see that happening, you see all sorts of changes, dramatic things, dangerous things. And so, the center is not holding. The falcon can't hear the falconer anymore. Ceremonies of innocence are drowned, and they're replaced by the worst, being full of passionate intensity. All sorts of conflict is happening. Presumably, that's not going to last forever. What will replace it?
- 6.20** So the poem continues. "Surely, some revelation is at hand. Surely, the Second Coming is at hand. The Second Coming! Hardly are those words out when a vast image out of Spiritus Mundi," that means the spirit of the world, this idea of a world spirit developing, "troubles my sight. Somewhere in the sands of the desert, a shape with a lion body and the head of a man, a gaze blank and pitiless as the sun, is moving its slow thighs, while all about it reel shadows of the indignant desert birds."
- 6.21** Here he's thinking of the Sphinx, something that was near the beginning of Egyptian civilization. And so, he's thinking of something like that, some new Sphinx, something that will be a symbol of the early stages of a new civilization. Somewhere out there, that is arising. It's starting to move, and around it reel the shadows of the desert birds. In other words, just as we're seeing conflict, as this stage of civilization begins to collapse, there's turmoil as another one is about to begin. But where is it? What is it?
- 6.22** He says, "The darkness drops again. But now I know that twenty centuries of stony sleep were vexed to nightmare by a rocking cradle. And what rough beast, its hour come round at last, slouches toward Bethlehem to be born?" So the darkness drops again. We've got this collapsing of a civilization taking place around us. Writing this right at the end of the First World War, he's thinking, "It sure seems like this civilization is collapsing. Darkness is dropping quickly, twenty centuries of stony sleep."
- 6.23** Partly, he's thinking, all right, twenty centuries, this last 2000-year period is coming to an end. But also, they were vexed to nightmare by a rocking cradle. In other words, it was the birth of Christianity. It was the birth of Christ that really led to whatever has led to the improvements of this period; but also the relative peace, to the extent that there has been peace of that period, now all that's coming to an end. And so, "What rough beast is slouching toward Bethlehem to be born?" What is going to be the originating thing of this new cycle of civilization?

- 6.24 And he's worried. He sees Christianity as having been essentially benign, despite the many flaws of institutional Christianity and many things that Christians have done that were not very good. Still, he sees Christianity as having been something that gave people a sense of value, that organized a civilization. And without it, he's worried something new is going to happen, something new is going to arise. We're not yet in a position to see what it is. And now, a hundred years later, I think we're still not really in a position to know what it is.
- 6.25 We see all sorts of institutions that have existed in some cases for centuries, and in other cases since the Second World War, start to fall apart, start not to make sense anymore. People have a sense that these structures need to be reorganized, rethought, and, in a sense, reconceptualized. But what would that new arrangement look like? Nobody knows. We still don't know "what rough beast, its hour come round at last, is slouching toward Bethlehem to be born."
- 6.26 But there is that sense of, in part, nostalgia. Wouldn't it have been nice to be born at an earlier time, when we weren't at the end of the turmoil structure of a civilization, where it was all starting to fall apart? Wouldn't it have been great to be back there? And indeed, we'll see that in the next poem. Wouldn't it have been great to be back at a time when it all made sense together? But instead, here we are, in this transitional period that is complicated. We live in interesting times, and in many ways, that is a curse.
- 6.27 But there is that combination of nostalgia, but also looking toward the future, saying, what is going to happen? "What rough beast is slouching toward Bethlehem to be born?" And why is it a rough beast? Partly, he's worried that the moral constraints that people have operated under, even if they didn't live up to them, are about to slip away. Those values are being lost. The constraints are being loosed.
- 6.28 And now what happens? How are people going to act? How is a civilization going to happen with a different set of rules? Well, that poem is meant to be a bit frightening, and I find it frightening. Even reading it 100 or so years later, I think, "We still don't know." It still terrifies me to think he's right. There is a basic new pattern. Maybe it's going to be awesome, with new technologies. Maybe we're all going to be slaves of ChatGPT. I don't know. But in any case, something new is arising.
- 6.29 Now, his next poem is one that I want to talk about. It's also very well known, very famous. It's written eight years later, at the end of the Roaring Twenties. And so, at this point, he feels reassured that things have regained something of an even keel. Maybe that collapse in civilization isn't quite as close as he thought. But nevertheless, it's talking about a problem and a possible solution that I think is very interesting and of global significance in a way that maybe saying "we're at the end of a cycle of a civilization" isn't.

- 6.30 This is, in a way, timeless. But there's something else that ties it into that idea of cycles of civilization. For many years, I think I was too limited in my interpretation of this poem. It's only recently that I've started thinking there's something else going on here that I hadn't been paying attention to. The poem is called "Sailing to Byzantium."
- 6.31 Why Byzantium? At one point, he was asked that question. "Why did you write the poem about that place in particular?" He said, "I think if I could be given a month of Antiquity, and leave, to spend it wherever I chose, I would spend it in Byzantium, a little before Justinian opened St. Sophia and closed the Academy of Plato. Maybe never before or since in recorded history, religious, aesthetic, and practical life were one." So in that place, he said, that civilization made sense. Its history, its religion, its aesthetic, its practical life, its philosophical life—all of them blend together. All of them were one. There was no conflict.
- 6.32 Now, it wasn't to last. Justinian closed Plato's Academy, and things began to change. But at that moment, he said, maybe that civilization was actually at its height. The Roman Empire had fallen in the West, but it was still there in the East, and it was still thoroughly Christian. It also still retained Greek philosophy and Greek culture. It was something where that civilization made sense. I wish I could go back there. In effect, that nostalgia for an earlier spot in the cycle, where he could say, "Yeah, there you could just think, 'This is awesome. I know who I am. I know where I am. I know what's around me. I understand this civilization.'"
- 6.33 Byzantium at that point, after the fall of the Western Empire, was now "the center of European civilization." He said, "The source was its spiritual philosophy, so I symbolize the search for the spiritual life by a journey to that city." He said, in the context of the poem, "I speak of a bird made of Grecian goldsmiths. I use it as a symbol of the intellectual joy of eternity, as contrasted with the instinctive joy of human life." So in part, this is about the quest for eternity, the quest for the spiritual. Here's how the poem begins, with the opposite of that.
- 6.34 "That is no country for old men. The young in one another's arms, birds in the trees—those dying generations—at their song, the salmon-falls, the mackerel-crowded seas, fish, flesh, or fowl, commend all summer long, whatever is begotten, born, and dies. Caught in that sensual music, all neglect monuments of unaging intellect." So what is he saying? Most of us, most of the time, are concerned with the ordinary things of life, with the things that come and go. And so, much of that involves procreation and propagation of the species.
- 6.35 But yes, that's what the animals are doing. That's what fish are doing. That's what the people are doing. The young in one another's arms. But that's all about what is begotten, born, and dies. Sensual music. There's a great beauty to all of that. Those aspects of everyday life are wonderful. But everybody neglects, as a result, "the monuments of unaging intellect," the gifts of the spirit. So he turns now from the young in one another's arms to an aged man. He's feeling his age by now.

- 6.36 He says, "An aged man is but a paltry thing, a tattered coat upon a stick, unless soul clap its hands and sing, and louder sing, for every tatter in its mortal dress. Nor is there singing school but studying monuments of its own magnificence; and therefore I've sailed the seas and come to the holy city of Byzantium." So here, yeah, "an aged man is but a paltry thing." In other words, if all we have is this music of sensuality around us, well, by the time you're old, you realize, I'm passing from that scene now, and it seems like that part is over.
- 6.37 If that's all there is to life, well, it's declining and it's soon about to end. That's it. I'm nothing but "a tattered coat upon a stick." Unless, unless what? "Unless soul clap its hands and sing." Now, that idea, hey, it is still possible to sing. It is still possible to actually do something. I don't have to be just a tattered coat on a stick. For every tatter in its mortal dress, that being can sing. OK? Nor is there singing school but studying monuments of its own magnificence.
- 6.38 So it is possible to try to actually, well, have a singing school actually propagate this, but also possible to turn to the past. So I can be concerned with the future, saying, "I have to teach the future. I have to get others to sing." But also, I can turn to the past and look at monuments of my own magnificence, not mine in particular, but our own magnificence, the magnificence of humanity. And therefore, I've sailed the seas and come to the holy city of Byzantium.
- 6.39 So here he's saying, I have turned to the past. I have turned to this holy city where it seems as if the spiritual life, practical life, a philosophical life, culture, it was all one. It was all unified. That part of the Roman Empire was still there. It had not yet collapsed. "O sages, standing in God's holy fire as in the gold mosaic of a wall, come from the holy fire, perne in a gyre, and be the singing-masters of my soul." We return to that idea of a gyre. What is a perne? It's a reel, a spindle, a spool. So now we have this thing revolving. And again, the idea of a cycle, a cycle of civilization.
- 6.40 So he's saying, "Sages standing in God's holy fire." In other words, those who were in tune with spirituality, with the eternal, as in the gold mosaic of a wall, as in something that was built to last, that would not deteriorate, that would not be falling apart, that would not be something that was born and died. Come out of that, and here, be the thing that is central in these cycles. Be the singing-masters of my soul. Be the being that actually helps me to sing, teaches me, from those monuments of magnificence, how to do the same, how to reach that spiritual realm and grasp onto eternity.
- 6.41 Now, what does he mean by a singing school? That used to be a commonplace. And by the time he is discussing it in the 1920s, even if those aren't particularly very active anymore, they still exist. But a few decades before, they were common. Here was the idea. People were spreading Christianity. And in order to do that, they wanted to have people sing. Singing seemed to be a really important part of worship. So what did they do? They realized most people can't sing. Most people, in fact, are illiterate. But we can teach them to sing.

- 6.42 So they produced books, books like the ones that I pictured there: Southern Harmony, the Christian Harmony, the Sacred Harp. All of these were designed to be ways of teaching people to sing. They began with what they called the gamut, which was a little course in music. Here's how you read music. Here are the notes, here are the scales, here are the staffs and what they mean. But here is what was distinctive about them. They used shape notes.
- 6.43 They said, admittedly, you might not know how to read music, so you might not know how to identify that as a C or a G. But tell you what, here's what we'll do. We'll make the notes different shapes. So if you see a note of that shape, no matter where it is on the staff, you'll know that's a C. And this one, that's a G, and so on. And so they were different shapes, depending upon where they were and what note that was. So you look at some of these—and by the way, the melody is always in the tenor line here. The tenors carried the melody, which is kind of interesting. The sopranos typically sang a descant.
- 6.44 But anyway, the thought was, you didn't really have to read music. You just had to identify the shapes. And that would give you another path into being able to sing these songs. So he's saying, "Be the singing-masters of my soul." In other words, teach me to sing the way those people went out and sang. They were trying to spread a kind of art, a kind of art that, yes, was part of this sensual music, but also was reaching toward eternity, reaching toward the spiritual as opposed to merely the sensual.
- 6.45 And so he's saying, "Do that for me." But now he's not asking specific people here. He's saying, "I'm turning to those things that are eternal, to those gold mosaics on the wall in Byzantium. I'm turning toward those monuments of unaging intellect, saying, 'Be my singing-masters. Teach me to sing. You actually had access somehow to that spiritual realm. You actually understood something beyond this sensual music that surrounds me, and that most of us spend most of our time thinking about. Help me get beyond that. Help me to become educated so that I, too, can grasp that.'"
- 6.46 And so he's looking to the sages of the past. They're not just to be monuments of unaging intellect, but to be the spiritual masters who can teach the soul. Jacques Barzun has written about our current age as an Alexandrian age, and what he has in mind is something like the relationship of Alexandria in Egypt to Athens. Athens was where all the creativity was going on. Then, a couple of centuries later, it was all happening in Alexandria, but mostly as commentaries on what had already happened in Athens.
- 6.47 Some new things were happening in Alexandria, but for the most part, now there was this history, and people spent most of their time commenting on that history, those "monuments of unaging intellect" they had been handed down from Athens. Barzun's worry is that we're in such a civilization. Try to do something new in whatever your field is, and you find there are so many monuments you have to study first. You want to

come up with a new idea in philosophy? We'll start you out on Plato and Aristotle, and then Descartes, Hume, and Kant, and so on.

- 6.48** You want to do something new in music? Let's take you back and start with medieval chant, and then you can go through Palestrina, and then you'll do the Baroque era, and then the Classical period, then the Romantics, then the—and in short, you're going to spend years of studying those monuments of unaging intellect before you can do anything. I think part of this is Yeats worrying that he's near the end of one of these cycles of civilization. That means this civilization is so Alexandrian that now there's all this stuff.
- 6.49** I mean, if you're interested in those monuments, there are a lot of monuments to study, but it's tempting, and it's overwhelming almost to spend your time studying the monuments, rather than actually singing yourself. And so he sees in part that problem. He's living at a time, not just as in the earlier poem, "Hey, things are about to collapse. This is dangerous," though he is partly feeling that as a person.
- 6.50** He's thinking, "Yeah, this life is about to end. I want to focus on something that is lasting, something more important than just the sensual music, something that will be part of that gold mosaic. I want to build monuments of unaging intellect, but I also want to be taught by them and learn from them how to do it. So I want them to be my spiritual masters, who can teach my soul not just how to sing as part of the sensual music, but to actually sing in a more lasting way, to develop my own monument and leave my own monument."
- 6.51** So he says, "Consume my heart away; sick with desire, and fastened to a dying animal," my body, in other words, "it knows not what it is. Gather me into the artifice of eternity." So the sensual music, wonderful, but also finite. It ends. However, it is possible for there to be these monuments that last. OK, and go back to Byzantium, you see them there in gold on the wall. So, "Gather me into that artifice of eternity. Once out of nature, I shall never take my bodily form from any natural thing." Those things, after all, are begotten, born, and die.
- 6.52** "But such a form as Grecian goldsmiths make of hammered gold and gold enamelling, to keep a drowsy emperor awake; or set upon a golden bow to sing to lords and ladies of Byzantium of what is past, or passing, or to come." So it is possible to build these monuments, to reach out and grasp the spiritual, grasp the eternal. Those things are capable of keeping the drowsy emperor awake. They can sing about those things that are begotten, born, and die, what's past, passing, or to come. But they can also be singing-masters to the soul.
- 6.53** Now, for a long time, I thought this poem was operating, as it were, on three levels. Part of it is him realizing, "I'm a mortal being. I am nearing the end of my life." And so, yes, while I can delight in the beauty of the sensual music all around me, I also want something to last. I want to leave behind something that is eternal, something that will

outlive me, something that could be considered a monument of unaging intellect. And so, part of it is just this personal feeling of mortality and wanting something to survive beyond his own death.

- 6.54** Now, a second thing I thought was going on here is also feeling that that's happening to the civilization and saying, "It's not just me as an individual person. If this cycle of civilization is ending, we'd better think about leaving monuments of unaging intellect and not just the day-to-day matters. We need to think, too, about the spiritual. We need to think about what could be eternal. We need to learn from that, but also figure out how to leave such monuments ourselves."
- 6.55** Then I thought, at a third level, what he's doing is really the contrast with the sensual and the spiritual. He's saying, "Part of human existence is just to be concerned with the day-to-day, to be concerned with everyday matters. And yes, with the sensual music, but also just the business affairs of life. Yes, we're concerned with all of that. We have to be. But we need to leave time for enabling ourselves to sing, for actually going beyond that, to leaving something eternal, to focusing on the spiritual, and thinking about the larger things, the things that will outlast us, the things that are eternal."
- 6.56** Now, I think all those things are going on in this poem. But I began increasingly recently to think, "I think there's something in addition." Because, couple this with his idea that we're nearing the end of one of these cycles. What inspired me here was actually a Star Trek episode, Cause and Effect. I have to tell you a little about the episode, just so you get the idea. What happens is that the Enterprise is caught in a time warp. Some bad decisions are made, the Enterprise blows up, and it actually disrupts the space-time continuum in such a way that the whole ship is sent into this loop they can't get out of.
- 6.57** And so they keep making the same mistake again and keep blowing up, and it keeps happening. At a certain point, there's a kind of déjà vu experience that makes them think, "We've been here before. We've done this before." Then they begin to think about that more, and they come up with the idea that we're caught in a time loop. That's why this feels familiar. It is familiar. This has happened before. They start thinking, "We're going to make a horrible mistake that is going to disrupt the continuum and throw us into this. How do we get out of it?"
- 6.58** The problem becomes that nothing's going to really survive as a result of this. We'll just be back where we were. How do we somehow signal ourselves? How do we pass something into the next journey through this loop? How do I transmit a signal, like "Don't make that decision! Do something else," into the next loop? I think that now is the additional aspect of what Yeats is doing. He's partly, yes, saying, "I'm going to die, but I want to leave behind something lasting."
- 6.59** Partly, he's saying, "This civilization is going to change, and I want it to leave something lasting." Partly, he is saying, "Yes, we need to turn toward the eternal, toward the spiritual, toward those things that last." But he's also saying, "I think this cycle of

civilization is ending. I think a lot of what we take for granted and what we treat as monuments is about to be destroyed." And so, how do we send signals to the next cycle?

- 6.60** I think that is part of what worries him. Is he going to be one of the things that's a signal for the next cycle? Are people going to be reading Yeats? It's not just a personal question. It's not just a civilizational question. It's part, like, we've learned a lot in this 2,000-year cycle. How do we get that into the next cycle? Some things do survive. We still read Plato, we still read Aristotle, we still read Sophocles, we still read the Hebrew scriptures. So all of those things managed to survive. But on the other hand, most things are lost. Even most of the works of great figures like Aristotle and Cicero were lost.
- 6.61** So, how do we send some signals into the next cycle? How do we become something like—or at least have something that is like the gold mosaics on the wall that survive in Byzantium even long after that civilization collapses? That seems to me a problem that is hard to think about, but goes beyond the personal or even the larger issues about spirituality, just saying, "We've learned a lot. How do we transmit that learning into a new civilization?"
- 6.62** That brings me to T. S. Eliot, who wrote one of the greatest poems of the 20th century, *The Waste Land*. It's also one of the most complicated poems. It has footnotes, which is rather unusual for a poem, and some people hate it for that reason. They think, "This isn't a poem. Poems are supposed to be, things you can understand themselves without a lot of footnotes and tracking things down and so on." Also, language after language appears in this poem. Actually, I think, by the end, I was once counting, seven languages appear, and that's assuming we're just counting languages and not stages of languages. So it gets complicated.
- 6.63** Here is the epigraph. We start with some Latin and Greek. "Nam Sibyllam quidem Cumis ego ipse oculis meis vidi in ampulla pendere, et cum illi pueri dicerent: Sibylla ti theleis; respondebat illa: apothanein thelo." OK, what does it mean? I always challenge my students, so translate. Then I feign disappointment that none of them could do it. But here's what it means. "I've seen with my own eyes the Sibyl, hanging in a jar. And when the boys asked her, 'What do you want?', she answered, 'I want to die.'"
- 6.64** It's a citation from Petronius. So you go to the Sibyl. The Sibyl, by the way, is the being who was granted a great favor by the gods. Said, "What do you want, Sibyl?" She said, "I want eternal life." Bad mistake. She should have said, "I want eternal youth." Instead, well, she ages, but she cannot die. Here she is hanging in a jar like a bat, shriveled, thousands of years old, but unable to do anything, and yet cannot die. "What do you want, Sibyl?" "I want to die." Dirty trick, in a way, the gods played. They could have said, "You mean you want eternal youth, don't you?" But she didn't.

- 6.65** Anyway, here's the idea. There is this quest for immortality, but be careful about that. It's not always what you expect. The dedication is to Ezra Pound, "il miglior fabbro," in other words, the greater craftsman. He's doing that not just because he's a friend of Ezra Pound and admires his poetry. There was a much longer version of this poem that was the first draft, and Pound told him to cut much of it out. So if this poem is a great poem, it's largely because Pound made him get rid of all the stuff that wasn't very good. But here he is echoing Dante's Purgatory, and that's going to be a common theme as well.
- 6.66** Here's the beginning of the poem, *The Burial of the Dead*. "April is the cruellest month, breeding lilacs out of the dead land, mixing memory and desire, stirring dull roots with spring rain. Winter kept us warm, covering Earth in forgetful snow, feeding a little life with dried tubers." Now, that's an odd beginning. First of all, we begin with the burial of the dead, but then we get April. You ask people, "What does April symbolize to you?" Most people, at least in the northern hemisphere, are going to say, "Oh, it's spring. It's the rebirth of things, and it's a fine time. It's wonderful."
- 6.67** And so, here's how Chaucer begins *The Canterbury Tales*. I won't bother to read the Middle English, though I always do that for my students, too. But here's the modern English version. "When April with his showers sweet with fruit, the drought of March has pierced unto the root and bathed each vein with liquor that has power to generate therein and sire the flower," in other words, it's great, right? Rain is giving a rebirth to everything, reinvigorating things, flowers, growth. It's nice, it's spring.
- 6.68** But instead, in Eliot, April is the cruellest month. Why? Because it's waking what had been slumbering. Those tubers, those roots, were there under the earth, blanketed by snow. It was nice. And now they're being jogged awake. So the image isn't of growth and flowers. The image here is of someone firmly asleep under a thick blanket in winter, and then being jostled awake. But then we get a sudden change of scene, and that happens again and again in the poem.
- 6.69** "Summer surprised us, coming over the Starnbergersee with a shower of rain; we stopped in the colonnade, and went on in sunlight, into the Hofgarten, and drank coffee, and talked for an hour. Bin gar keine Russin, stamm' aus Litauen, echt deutsch." I should translate for you. "I'm not a Russian. I'm Lithuanian, a real German." OK, so you're hearing these people talking in Switzerland. What did this have to do with April and the cruellest month and all that? But in addition, now we've got this other language. We've already had Latin and Greek and English, and now we have German.
- 6.70** Then, another change of scene. "When we were children staying at the archduke's, my cousin's, he took me out on a sled, and I was frightened. He said, Marie, Marie, hold on tight. And down we went. In the mountains, there you feel free. I read, much of the night, and go south in the winter." The suggestion here is, oh, wow, we're staying at the archduke's? We're obviously very rich, some of the European nobility.

- 6.71** Something I haven't commented on, really, about the First World War, is that it largely destroyed that entire group of European nobility. People gathered at one point just before the war for the coronation of a new king, and all of these luminaries were there. Every single one was to be out of that position, losing his or her kingdom within just a few years, by the end of the war. And so there is an image here of nobility, of—what?—pleasure, of leisure, that has been destroyed by the war. It's no longer there. It's a nostalgia for that. It remembers how things were before the war, at least if you were of a certain social class.
- 6.72** But now, again, a dramatic shift. "What are the roots that clutch, what branches grow out of this stony rubbish? Son of man, you cannot say, or guess, for you know only a heap of broken images, where the sun beats, and the dead tree gives no shelter, the cricket no relief, and the dry stone, no sound of water." So, we had that condition. Before the war, things were beautiful, things were great. Notice, April was cruel because it was waking people out of this snowy slumber. And then snow, that was something that was fun. We went sled-riding in the Alps. It was fantastic.
- 6.73** And now, we're in the desert, stony rubbish. We have nothing but a heap of broken images. That is one of, I think, the central images of this poem and one of the central themes. We are left with nothing but a heap of broken images. Where Yeats saw monuments of unaging intellect, of lasting significance, there in the gold mosaic on a wall, Eliot's looking around himself and saying, "I just see a heap of things." We have this fragment of this image, this fragment of that image. We have this little bit of a mosaic, maybe that little bit. The civilization has been shattered.
- 6.74** It's not just that that ruling class is gone. Any sense of unity of this civilization is gone. We have nothing but a heap of broken images. There is no water, there is no shelter, there is no relief. But then, hey, wait. "There's shadow under this red rock. Come in under the shadow of this red rock. I will show you something different from either your shadow at the morning striding behind you, or your shadow at evening rising to meet you. I will show you fear in a handful of dust."
- 6.75** It seems like we're being given shelter. Like, "Come here, come here. Here's a place." Then I'm going to show you something different. Different from your shadow at morning, striding behind. Another, something different from the past, but also something different from that thing rising to meet you at evening. Something different from the future. But it's not something to be celebrated. I'm going to show you fear in a handful of dust.
- 6.76** Now, back to German. *Frisch weht der Wind der Heimat zu. Mein Irisch Kind, wo weilest du?* "The wind blows fresh to the homeland. My Irish girl, where are you lingering?" There are a number of quotations here from *Tristan and Isolde*, and these are meant to indicate something about longing, about waiting, about frustrated waiting. We'll return to that, and I'll explain more about it. But it pops up again and

again, and it's this thought that we're anticipating something that is not going to come, or at least, if it comes, we won't be able to be there to appreciate it.

6.77 So, another shift. "You gave me hyacinths first a year ago; they called me the hyacinth girl. Yet when we came back late from the hyacinth garden, your arms full and your hair wet, I couldn't speak and my eyes failed. I was neither living nor dead, and I knew nothing. Looking into the heart of light, the silence. Oed' und leer das Meer." Desolate and empty the sea. So here is what happens.

6.78 We're neither living nor dead. Things were great. You gave me the hyacinths, and it was beautiful. The hyacinth garden. Everything was wonderful. But all of a sudden, something happened. I couldn't speak. My eyes failed. I was neither living nor dead. I knew nothing. And so here is, I think, another of the main themes in the poem. Eliot is looking around, saying, "I think there are a lot of us who are now in the position of being neither living nor dead." And he means something quite specific by that.

6.79 So far, we don't really understand what it is, but he's saying, "I think a lot of us are lost. We are really neither living nor dead. We're living in a way that is merely living. We're living in a way that is not really living. And we look into the heart of light, the silence, and we hear nothing, we see nothing, and in the end, empty and desolate is the sea. We are not seeing what we want to see." The image here is of Tristan, waiting for his love, and here's what happens.

6.80 Tristan transports Isolde to King Marke to be married. He and Isolde end up drinking a love potion, so they fall madly in love, but she's supposed to be married to the king. This is discovered by the king. He stabs Tristan, and Tristan manages to survive and run away, but he's trying to recover, hiding from the king, and he's also awaiting Isolde, who is supposed to come back.

6.81 Finally, he hears her approach. He rips off his bandages, but then he dies as he runs to meet her. She finally does get back, and he's gone. You can just see the opera develop around you. It's like the dramatic singing as all this is taking place. But the whole idea is yes, we're waiting, we're waiting, we're waiting, depending on—and the sea is empty. It is desolate. She does not arrive.

6.82 Now, another shift. "Unreal city, under the brown fog of a winter dawn, a crowd flowed over London Bridge. So many, I hadn't thought death had undone so many. Sighs, short and infrequent, were exhaled, and each man fixed his eyes before his feet. Flowed up the hill and down King William Street, to where Saint Mary Woolnoth kept the hours with a dead sound on the final stroke of nine."

6.83 There is a reference here to Dante. "I had not thought death had undone so many." And that helps to explain this. Partly, he's thinking, death undoing many, many people. The war killed 16 and a half million people. Part of it is, though, so many people lost things in the war, lost relatives, lost loved ones, but also just lost a sense of what the meaning of life was, that now he's saying they're just going through the motions.

They're going trudging to work early in the morning through the fog. They're not excited about it. They're not pleased about it. They're just going through the motions.

- 6.84** Here is the passage from the *Inferno* that he's referring to. "So long a train of people, I should never have believed death had undone so many." He's talking there about people in limbo, where they are neither living nor dead. "Here, to my hearing, there was no weeping but sighs, which caused the eternal air to tremble." So the thought is, these are people who are just, well, it's not like they've done anything pretty good in their lives. They're not being rewarded. They're not being punished. There's nothing.
- 6.85** Like, they had life, and they just didn't do anything with it. Here was this great gift, the gift of life, and they just went through the motions the whole life. And so, they end up in this place where they're not rewarded, they're not penalized. There are no cries here, there's no anguish, but there are sighs. The eternal air is there to tremble. But these are the people who did not reach out for eternity, who just went through the motions, got caught up in the sensual music of the things around them, what is passing and to come. Didn't care about anything else. Their lives really had no meaning, even to them.
- 6.86** Now another sudden shift. "There I saw one I knew, and stopped him, crying, 'Stetson! You who were with me in the ships at Mylae! That corpse you planted last year in your garden, has it begun to sprout? Will it bloom this year? Or has the sudden frost disturbed its bed? Oh, keep the dog far hence, that's friend to men, or with his nails, he'll dig it up again. You! Hypocrite lecteur, mon semblable, mon frère!'" That is a dedication, actually, from Baudelaire's *The Flowers of Evil*. OK, "You, hypocrite reader, my doppelganger, my brother."
- 6.87** And so, there is a reference to what? A number of sources, not just Baudelaire. A Webster poem, "Keep the wolf far thence, that's foe to men." Here it's a dog that's friend to men, or "he'll dig it up again." But also in the background, keep in mind this is a part of the poem called *The Burial of the Dead*. And so there is a part of the standard Book of Common Prayer that is detailing what you say at a funeral. And it goes like this.
- 6.88** There are passages that you read, and one of them is, "I am the resurrection, and the life," sayeth the Lord. "He that believeth in me, though he were dead, yet shall he live. And whosoever liveth and believeth in me shall never die." And it continues in another place. "I know that my redeemer liveth, and that he shall stand at the latter day upon the earth. And though after my skin worms destroy this body, yet in my flesh shall I see God, whom I shall see for myself, and mine eyes shall behold, and not another."
- 6.89** So there is this sense of eternity. And what's happened? The people who are neither living nor dead, they paid no attention. They have not thought about that. They are not destined for any sort of reward or even punishment. Their lives are really, in a certain sense, to use Nietzsche's phrase, beyond good and evil, but not because they've gotten

to a higher plane. It's just because they've ignored those questions. They've just gone through the motions.

- 6.90** Now, the second part of the poem, called *A Game of Chess*, is all about misdirected sterile sexuality. There are stories about Cleopatra, about Tereus and Philomela, who is turned then later into a nightingale, and that reappears a number of times. There's a hectoring wife, women in the pub who are talking and talking, and eventually, you figure out they're talking about an abortion. Then Ophelia in *Hamlet*.
- 6.91** I'm going to mostly skip past this, but the idea is, here is something that, even at that sensual level, gave it meaning. And Eliot's looking around himself, saying, "I don't think even that has the meaning within the sensual sphere that it used to have." It's supposed to have this orientation toward procreation, having children, the future. And now it's being pursued for its own sake, with no concern for the future at all. And that leads you to emptiness and disaster.
- 6.92** So here is just a glimpse of what goes on in this part. The hectoring wife saying, "I never know what you're thinking. Think." "I think we're in rats' alley where the dead men lost their bones." "Do you know nothing? Do you see nothing? Do you remember nothing?" "I remember those are pearls that were his eyes." No, I'd never want to be part of a relationship like that, let me tell you.
- 6.93** But what do you mean, "those are pearls that were his eyes"? Well, it's a reference to Shakespeare's *The Tempest*. "Full fathom five thy father lies; of his bones are coral made. Those are pearls that were his eyes. Nothing of him that doth fade, but doth suffer a sea-change into something rich and strange. Sea-nymphs hourly ring his knell, burthen ding-dong. Hark! Now I hear them, ding-dong, bell." So, about here a skeleton. Death by drowning, where in the end, those were his eyes, now they're pearls.
- 6.94** Well, the third section, the *Fire Sermon*. "The river's tent is broken, the last fingers of leaf clutch and sink into the wet bank. The wind crosses the brown land, unheard. The nymphs are departed. Sweet Thames, run softly till I end my song. The river bears no empty bottles, sandwich papers, silk handkerchiefs, cardboard boxes, cigarette ends, or other testimony of summer nights. The nymphs are departed. And their friends, the loitering heirs of city directors, departed, have left no addresses. By the waters of Leman, I sat down and wept. Sweet Thames, run softly till I end my song. Sweet Thames, run softly, for I speak not loud nor long. But at my back, in a cold blast, I hear the rattle of the bones, and chuckle spread from ear to ear."
- 6.95** There are, again, many, many different references here. So one of them is to Psalm 137. "By the rivers of Babylon, there we sat down, yea, we wept when we remembered Zion." That is a lament issued from the Babylonian captivity. And you might think that Eliot feels as if, after the war, that's where we are. We're in captivity, not because we lost the war and are now somewhere else or under an occupying power, but simply because now the things we valued are lost. It's as if our identity, our values, all of that is

gone. And suddenly we remember Zion, a nostalgia for what has been passed, but what is lost. We don't have that anymore.

- 6.96** And then what else? Well, "By the waters of Leman, I sat down and wept. Sweet Thames, run softly till I end my song." That comes from Spenser, and he's talking there about a wedding feast. "Sweet Thames, run softly till I end my song." But there it's all about the future. A wedding is celebrated, not for the past, but for the future, for the foundation of a new family and a new life. Here, he's in effect saying the same thing, but directed toward the past.
- 6.97** Seeing "run softly till I end my song," but on the other hand, this is not a celebration of a beginning. This is more like the mourning for an end. "At my back in a cold blast, I hear the rattle of the bones." A reference to Marvell's poem, "To His Coy Mistress." "But at my back I always hear time's winged chariot hurrying near; and yonder all before us lie deserts of vast eternity." So it's death, in other words, that is lurking behind us and hurrying behind us. That's the rattle we hear.
- 6.98** "A rat crept softly through the vegetation, dragging its slimy belly on the bank while I was fishing in the dull canal on a winter evening round behind the gas house, musing upon the king my brother's wreck and on the king my father's death before him." He's alluding to the image of the Fisher King, an old legend, where the king is charged with keeping the Holy Grail. He does that for years, but then he is wounded, and the kingdom turns into a wasteland, hence the title of the poem.
- 6.99** Religions, as a fertility cult centering around this, grew up in various parts of the world. And the idea is, there's a sacrifice of a sacred king who is revived and enables the earth to be reborn in the spring. Well, we started, remember, with April being the cruellest month. And so now it's being introduced, but saying, like, "Yeah, my father's been wounded. This kingdom is a wasteland. Is there any hope of revival?"
- 6.100** "At the violet hour, when the eyes and back turn upward from the desk, when the human engine waits like a taxi, throbbing, waiting, I, Tiresias, though blind, throbbing between two lives, old man with wrinkled female breasts, can see at the violet hour, the evening hour that strives homeward, and brings the sailor home from the sea." And Eliot has this strange note. He says, "Tiresias, though a mere spectator and not indeed a character, is yet the most important person in the poem, uniting all the rest." And he says, in the end, what Tiresias sees is the substance of the poem.
- 6.101** Well, what does Tiresias see? Who is Tiresias, first of all? He's a prophet of Thebes. Hera turned him into a woman for seven years, but then he was turned back into a man. He's blind, he's clairvoyant, he can see the future, but not the present, in other words. He can also understand birdsong. And what does he see? Well, in part, he's seeing meaningless sexuality, people focused on the present, not focused on the future, not focused on the eternal, and life becoming sterile and meaningless.

- 6.102** I think that is part of what's going on here. He's saying that's the substance of the poem. Life is becoming sterile. It's becoming meaningless. People are focused not on the future, not on the eternal, and in a certain sense, not even on the present. Even the present doesn't have any meaning for them, because the present can have meaning only in relation to the future or in relation to the eternal. If you give that up, life has no meaning at all. You're going through the motions. You're living, but not really living. You're neither living nor dead.
- 6.103** So, yes, we're consumed by desire, but desire that doesn't mean anything. "To Carthage then I came, burning, burning, burning, burning." But in the end, it means nothing. So he's referring here—by the way, Eliot was pursuing a PhD specializing in Indian philosophy, and so he's concerned with this. And this burning image is partly a reference to Augustine, but partly a reference to Buddha's fire sermon. We're all on fire, fire with desire. But in the end, that's a problem. It is not a good thing. It is something that keeps us from a focus on the future, from a focus on the eternal. We have to get rid of that.
- 6.104** There is a very brief section on death by water, about Phlebas the Phoenician, "a fortnight dead," who indeed has died by drowning and is there; his eyes are becoming the pearls that was referred to earlier. Who is Phlebas? I think a reference to Plato's Philebus, who argues that life is all about pleasure, and that's it. Again, the poem is like, pleasure—that is not enough to give a life meaning. You go through your life just seeking pleasure; you're neither living nor dead.
- 6.105** And so, consider Phlebas, who was once as handsome and tall as you. If that's all your life is, it's going to end. You will end up with your life and your death being meaningless. So, so far, it's a depressing poem. We go through one thing after another. It's all depressing. It's all people living, but not really living, just going through the motions.
- 6.106** But then we finally get to the section, "What the Thunder Said." "He who was living is now dead. We who were living are now dying. Who are those hooded hordes swarming over endless plains, stumbling in cracked earth, ringed by the flat horizon? Only, what is left of the city over the mountains? Cracks and reforms and bursts in the violet air. Falling towers. Jerusalem, Athens, Alexandria, Vienna, London. Unreal." All of these cities that were great capitals of great empires, gone. The cities are still there, but their greatness, gone. Now all it was is a past greatness. And he said, "Yes, we're on our way." London is the last one he mentions there. Unreal.
- 6.107** "In the decayed hole among the mountains in the faint moonlight, the grass is singing over the tumbled graves, about the chapel. There's the empty chapel." Nobody's there, actually. Nobody's focusing on the eternal. "Only the wind's home. It has no windows, and the door swings. Dry bones can harm no one. Only a cock stood on the rooftree. Co co rico, co co rico. In a flash of lightning, then a damp gust bringing rain."

- 6.108** This is the first optimistic note in the poem, a damp gust finally bringing rain to that dry, cracked earth. At this point, we get a recitation of the children's nursery rhyme, "London Bridge is falling down, falling down, falling down." And then we get a series of quotations from various texts, again, fragments in various languages. "Shall I at least set my own lands in order?" The Prince of Aquitaine, to the falling tower. The Prince, I mean, his own kingdom is collapsing around him, but maybe he can at least set his own land in order, and yet, London Bridge is falling down.
- 6.109** "He hid himself in the fire that refines." Maybe even here, the destruction, the fire, this collapse of a sense of meaning, can refine us, can help. And so the next line, "Quando fiam ceu chelidon, when shall I be as the swallow?" And here the idea is that Philomela, who has been raped and horribly violated, ends up being turned into a nightingale to escape. And so she sings. But can anyone understand? Tiresias can understand.
- 6.110** And so, is there any possibility of that? I will skip the details of Tiresias' story. It's really disturbing. But the idea is that her tongue has been ripped out, so she can't say what's happened to her, but she can sing as a nightingale. And so, Tiresias is actually able to understand and can communicate what she no longer can. And so, now we get the Prince of Aquitaine to the ruined tower. Things are falling apart, but still there's a message we can hear.
- 6.111** And then another keynote. "These fragments have I shored against my ruins." So Eliot is saying, "I've given you just fragments, constant changes in language, constant changes in scenery, constant changes in the narrative voice. But I'm shoring them against my ruins. I don't have a grand monument of unaging intellect to point you to. I just have these fragments, and I've been gathering up these fragments, and that's all I've got among the ruins."
- 6.112** "Why then I'll fit you. Hieron is mad again." It looks this is a reference to a tragedy, a Spanish tragedy, where somebody's feigning madness and intentionally pretending to be kind of crazy. Says, "Yeah, this makes no sense. None of it makes any sense. It's just fragments." But then something key. "Datta. Dayadhvam. Damyata. Shanti, shanti, shanti." We end with Sanskrit. This is a reference to an Upanishad. We did—"Tell us something, sir." It's what the thunder said. Da. Did you understand? Yes, you told us, "Damyata. Be subdued." Yes, you've understood.
- 6.113** It says to a different group, "Da." Did you understand? Yes. Datta, give. And then finally to a third group, "Da." Did you understand? Yes. Dayadhvam, be merciful. You've understood. So that is what the thunder says, "Da, da, da." That is to say, be subdued. Give, be merciful. Let that triad be taught. Subduing, giving, mercy. And that, I think, is a key part of the poem. If civilization has been shattered, if all we have is a heap of broken images, well, at least let's go back to the roots of Indo-European civilization. Let's go back to the Upanishads.

- 6.114** What does it say? Here is what you have to do. Be self-controlled, subdue yourself, give, be merciful, concerned with others. That's the foundation. Let's rebuild from that. So Eliot, asked about the significance of the poem, ends up saying, "Here's the thing. If you live in a certain way, you are going to be neither living nor dead. You'll just be merely living. I see a lot of people around me who are just, well, living, but merely living—not really living, living in a way where their lives have no meaning."
- 6.115** We need meaning, but that means it has to come from a vision of the future. It has to come from a vision of the eternal. If you just pursue pleasure, if you just focus on things in your own life, you will be just going through the motions. You will not, in fact, be capable of living a life that is meaningful, even for yourself. And so, it's not too surprising that, a few years after *The Waste Land*, Eliot, who at this point was an agnostic, converts to Catholicism. It's because he starts realizing, "Yeah, even my life does not have meaning, unless I focus it and see it in the context of something larger than myself."
- 6.116** That, I think, is in part the theme of this poem. If you think about your life in a way that isn't tied to something larger than you, of course it's a meaningless life, and it isn't going to seem significant even to you.